Fame Game (Trouble Finds You)
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Fame Game (Trouble Finds You)

by FrostyKayn

Summary

Let the Prince of Rock, Mydeimos, fake-date a Pop Princess, Robin, for the collab. It'll be fire. It'll benefit everyone. It's perfectly planned by the best in the industry, with contingency plans stacked like a PR professional's dream.
So Phainon shouldn't be worried, right?
...Right?

Notes

Hi, please have this small contribution to the Mydei/Phainon tag.
This fic is heavily inspired by songs by Juliet Simms, Trouble Find You, which I also use for the title.
I hope you enjoy it as much as I enjoy writing it!

Please note that English is not my first language, so if there's a grammar mistake, please do let me know.

This work now has a Russian Translation on Ficbook translated by the amazing @stilettklack on Twitter!

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: Just Another PR Stunt

“I’m sorry, what?”

Phainon asked again, with a sharper voice and a higher pitch. He did not actually miss what the man next to him had said. He heard it just fine the first time. He just wanted him to repeat it, just to be sure that he got it right.

On the passenger seat, Mydei, the love of his life, the man who had met his parents on barbecue night a few weekends back in Phainon’s hometown, the man who inspired the matching ring he commissioned Cartonus, the famous rockstar with ten million followers on Chrystagram, pressed his lips and sighed in that particular way that told Phainon that he would rather fight a man twice his size than have to repeat it. But Phainon pretended he overlooked that.

Reality was cruel, Mydeimos, he whispered in his own mind. *You have to face it. You’re not an exception to its cruelty just because you’re pretty.*

“I said,” Mydei said, slower this time, with every drag of his words conveying his dismay. “They want me to have this fake relationship with that pop star Clockie Princess girl.”

Ah.

So Phainon really got it right the first time.

He kind of lowkey hoped he had mistaken it for something else, for some reason. Like, maybe he had turned deaf with how many times he flies to the sky. Perhaps his driving skills had dulled to the point that he could no longer have a proper conversation while he had one foot on the gas.

“Is that so.”

“Hm.”

“They want you to have a fake relationship with *Robin*.”

“That’s what I just said.”

“*The Popstar* Robin.”

“Yes.”

“The super famous child actress, super talented singer, everybody’s sweetheart *Robin*.”

“HKS!”

Phainon couldn’t help but let out a little snicker at Mydei’s malicious hiss. He glanced at the beautiful man from his peripheral vision, only to be welcomed with the deepest furrow of the other’s brows. His thin lips pressed tight in distaste, and boy, did this muscular man with a black outfit from head to toe, red tattoo to complete his rebellious look, and fiery golden eyes look adorable when he *sulked*.

Phainon almost wanted to pull over just to kiss him.

But he was very proud of his impeccable self-control, so Phainon cleared his throat and pushed that thought aside. “Sorry, ‘Dei, just had to be sure,” he said. “I just don’t get it. Why Robin, all of a sudden, among all the celebrities and people and Halovians in the world, choose to approach you now?”

“Beat me.”

Phainon punched Mydei’s arm. Mydei returned it with twice the vigor.

Ah, he loves this man.

“Hmm, let me think, maybe she’s dating someone worse, and you’re being used as a distraction,” Phainon hummed. “Or maybe she’s gay? Oh, oh! Maybe she’s pregnant, and they decided that a hot, badass man who says *let’s rock the fucking world* on public television is a perfect scapegoat to be framed as the irresponsible Dad who ditches the kid.”

Mydei rolled his eyes. “Stop watching that Gardishians Show, Phainon. Your brain starts to rot,” he hissed in pure annoyance, and Phainon couldn’t help but let out a wheezing laugh.

“Hey, don’t trash them like that! Hyacine actually liked them. Well, in a way that she wants to cure their issues,” he said. When Mydei did not let up the glare, Phainon raised his fingers from the steering wheel. “Okay, sorry, sorry. Back to the topic. You still did not answer the *why*?”

Mydei groaned, wiping his face with his hands as he stared out of the window, looking so hard to convey how miserable he felt. “The heck I know *why*. Aglaea only told me that part. She said they will fill me in when I arrive,” he said—still sulking, still adorable.

Phainon began to question the impeccable self-control he had been so proud of a moment earlier.

“Ooooh, the mystery.”

Mydei punched Phainon’s arm. Thrice the power.

“Ow!” Phainon said. It didn’t actually hurt. He just wanted to mess with Mydei. “Wait, *they*?”

“Yeah. Aglaea said she will be there too,” Mydei said gruffly.

“Who, Robin?”

“No, the janitor. Yes, *Robin*, Phainon. Who do *you* think?” Mydei barked.

Phainon couldn’t help but burst into laughter. “Damn, you’re awfully pissy since you took that call, man,” he said. “Wait, is that why you insist on dragging me along? Because you want me to meet Robin? Aww, my sweet Pomme Honeycake, how thoughtful of you. You know how much of a Robin fan I am.”

From his peripheral vision, Phainon could see Mydei completely zeroed in on Phainon, ignoring his jokes and looking straight up, baffled, like he was questioning his life choices, including why he was dating a dumbass like

Phainon. It looked cute, still. But also dangerous, like Mydei was on the verge of turning into Nikador himself and impaling Phainon with his Lance of Fury.

“What?” Phainon demanded, feeling nervous now.

“You can’t be this dumb, HKS,” he said. “That’s not why I want you there at all!”

“Oh, uh, so you just want me to drive you there because you don’t want to lose a moment of our precious weekend together? That’s romantic too!”

Mydei sighed. Yes, that *definitely* looked like he was questioning his life choices.

“HKS! Don’t you get even slightly disturbed that I will be having a public relationship with someone else?”

This time, Mydei sounded so damn serious that Phainon’s teasing smile faltered. He paused and glanced at Mydei, who was still staring at him like a cat with its claws out, ready to strike if he did not like what Phainon would say next.

“Um… that’s a *fake* relationship, right?”

“Yeah. But *a relationship*.”

“Yeah… but it’s not real, right? Like, an act?” Phainon paused. “I… uh, I think it’s fine, depending on the reason. And It’s Aglaea. She always has a good reason, so….”

Mydei raised his brows. “Huh,” he scoffed. “Almost looks like you’re fine with the idea of me being in a relationship with someone else.”

Okay, he *definitely* did not like Phainon’s answer at all.

“No, ‘Dei, c’mon, think about it, the whole idea is just so silly. I mean, you, *Robin*, a fake relationship. Come on, you’re famous, she’s even *more* famous. No one’s benefitting from this… arrangement whatsoever.

Someone’s just messing with you,” Phainon said. His smile did not falter, but his voice got a bit more serious now. Mydei seemed to believe that this was a real situation.

Maybe it was.

Maybe Phainon simply didn't understand the world of rock stars and celebrities. He never had to before this. Mydei was always kind enough to keep him out of that part of his life throughout their relationship.

So really, he didn’t know how he should behave now. It was new to him that Mydei was suddenly involving him in his decision about something in his career. Normally he limited that kind of interaction on music and lyrics alone, asking Phainon if it sounded good or if the lyrics sounded too cliche.

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “*Aglaea* messing with me?”

Phainon shrugged. Okay, now *that* sounds silly. “Yeah, that doesn’t make sense. I don’t know. Maybe it’s a prank? Perhaps your album or concert ticket reaches a certain milestone, and they want to celebrate with a surprise? Have you checked the news? The socials? Try asking Anaxa. He won’t lie about these kinds of things.”

Mydei scoffed. “No need,” he said. “We’ll be there soon enough. We’ll just have to hear what they want.”

Phainon nodded. Yeah, that sounded about right. He pulled up to the building he knew too well and grabbed the parking ticket. Only when the parking ticket was printed did it dawn on him.

“Wait, *we*?”

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Mydeimos, the main vocalist and frontman of the super-famous rock band Sons of Gorgo, the love of his life, the man Phainon would do anything for, dragged him along to the elevator that climbed to the high floor of the Mnestia Tower, not caring about the fact that three security layers eyed Phainon with disdain (probably more because he was holding hands with Mydeimos the rockstar, not because of his fashion sense).

Still, when Phainon saw his reflection on the elevator walls, he noticed his worn-out jeans, dirty sneakers, and a black shirt with a massive "I <3 OKHEMA" sign printed on the front. Even Phainon caught on to how messy he looked.

“You finally see what the rest of us feel when we look at how you dressed,” Mydei said, upon hearing Phainon’s groan and the horror in Phainon’s eyes.

“I did not know I was gonna be dragged along to enter the building! I thought you’d told me to wait in the car!” Phainon hissed. “If I’d known that you would do this, I wouldn’t have agreed to drive you in the first place. I don’t have a clean shirt. Yesterday was supposed to be my laundry day, and *you* kept me occupied the whole day.”

Phainon pressed an index finger to Mydei’s chest, only for him to let out a smug smirk.

This bastard. He’s super lucky that he’s cute.

“You’re coming along regardless, HKS,” Mydei said as he tightened his hold on their entwined fingers. He paused, staring at the climbing number above the elevator’s door as he continued. “I need you there.”

Mydei’s voice remained calm, but something was wavering on the edge of his voice; something that sounded like exhaustion, nervousness, anger… Phainon couldn’t quite catch what that was. But from the look of his golden eyes, Phainon could tell that Mydei was being serious, and so Phainon nodded.

It’s very rare for Mydei to admit out loud that he needed Phainon outside the bedroom. Mydei was usually very reserved and impossibly prideful when he was not high on libido. So Phainon wouldn’t betray him and be the best boyfriend he could be, just as he always promised Mydei.

The elevator door dinged, and the next thing Phainon knew, he entered a large, super opulent room made of mahogany, marble, and crystal chandeliers with gold accents all across. A room that screamed Aglaea in the first second he was there.

Inside that lavish room, a few people were chatting in hushed voices. The first person Phainon noticed was Aglaea behind her desk, with Anaxa, her husband, just next to her, raising his brows at Phainon in a way that said he was surprised by Phainon’s presence.

Then, on the sofa meant for guests, Phainon could see three figures sitting, glancing at the door as he and Mydeimos entered the room. On the single sofa, he saw a blond man in a flashy outfit and pink-tinted sunglasses, who shifted his gaze toward them, raising his brows upon noticing their presence. And on the loveseat sat a more stern, serious-looking guy with silver eyes, and… Robin.

The Robin.

Phainon had seen her hundreds and hundreds of times on TV, the big screen, and digital videos. He thought that he wouldn’t be surprised to see her in person. Yet, she could still somehow surprise him. Robin looked even more petite than Phainon had imagined. She was way, *way more beautiful*. The lighting, makeup, camera filters, and post-production alterations did not do her beauty justice at all.

She was a star on the screen. Now, in person, she looked like a literal angel.

Robin nodded with a small smile at Phainon and Mydei, greeting them with a wave and a small hello.

Phainon could swear that his heart stopped.

Before anyone could say anything else, before Mydei could even grunt in annoyance, the pink-sunglasses blond man rose from his seat, smiling as he opened his arms to greet Mydei.

“Well, hello, if it isn’t the Prince of rock himself,” he announced in an absolutely confident way, almost looking like he was trying to be seductive. The blond man was small, a few inches shorter than Phainon, but his presence quickly filled the room as he approached Mydei. “Look at you, looking far more handsome and sturdier up close.”

The man patted Mydei’s biceps playfully, to which Mydei quickly pulled away, and Phainon instinctively leaned to swat his hand. The man flashed a bright smile as he glanced at Phainon. He still looked confident and relaxed, but wow, his eyes…

How could Phainon feel so little under the gaze of a man shorter than him?

“I’m sorry, is….*Okhema* supposed to be here?” he said, giving Phainon half a once-over before he apparently decided that Phainon was not worth his time. “I thought I made it clear when I said that this is a *private meeting*. No guards or assistants allowed.”

“Oh, my name is Pha…”, “He’s staying,” “Cut to the chase, Aventurine.”

The man smiled even more smugly in front of Phainon, Mydeimos, and Aglaea’s words.

“Alright, wow,” he said, flashing a wink at Mydei as he continued. “Whatever. So you’ve heard of my brilliant plan, yes, Mydeimos? Have you decided to agree with it yet? Trust me, it’s going to happen in a very short timeline. In just six months, you will collaborate with Robin; she will join you on the upcoming summer tour; you two will act lovey-dovey on stage; and maybe have a few lunches and dates here and there. Nothing too giving. Fans would eat it up more if you only gave them hints to fantasize about. It will be over before you know—”

“Yeah, before all of that, get to the *why*,” Mydei cut the man’s words.

The man—(Aventurine, as Aglaea called him) paused, staring at Mydei in a mild, visible surprise that made Phainon sure that no one had ever cut his words so brashly like that before. His smile remained, but the purple in his eyes sparkled in a way that Phainon could describe as *murder intent*.

Okay, this tiny guy was clearly not someone you could mess with. He looked like someone who would orchestrate a whole social media campaign to annihilate your character if you did as much as getting into his bad side.

Phainon subconsciously straightened up, brushing his thumb on Mydei's hand.

"Ahem, Mister Aventurine, please allow me," Robin got up from her seat. Her voice was smooth, her smile was gentle, and as she stood, Phainon could see her white, airy dress flutter like a gentle feather that made a swan beautiful. That dress made even getting up from a seat look like a graceful awakening for her.

Phainon bit the inner of his lower lip. The sharp turn from Aventurine's dangerous aura to Robin's gentle, calming presence was so quick that he almost felt his head spinning.

Robin nodded at Aventurine, her smile a sign of gratitude and… reassurance. Huh. She probably had realized the shift in Aventurine's mood, too, and perhaps decided that it would be easier for the conversation to progress if she just jumped in.

Beautiful and smart, too.

Is she even real?

"Hello, Mydeimos. First of all, my name is Robin. And I'm so happy I can finally meet you in person. I'm a huge fan of your art."

Mydei nodded. He did not look like he was impressed with Robin at all, but Phainon could see that his edges were softening, if only for a little. His jaw was unclenched, but his glare was still there, hanging on out of habit.

“I know you,” Mydei said. “And so does the entire world and their mother. I guess you’ll be the person who will answer the why?”

The man beside Robin (his brother?) also got up from his seat, narrowing his eyes on Mydei like he was offended by the way Mydei treated his little sister. Robin instinctively held her brother’s wrist; her movement was so in sync that it was like she’d seen it coming.

“Yes,” she said. Her smile did not falter. “I am grateful that you and Miss Aglaea are willing to lend us an ear, despite this request being sprung on you all of a sudden. As you may have already heard, it is, at its core, nothing more than a humble request for a collaboration. As you may already know, I’m always a fan of Sons of Gorgo. Your music always makes me feel energetic when I’m feeling super down. I am a longtime fan, and I always look forward to a chance to collaborate with you or simply to attend your concert. But time never seems to allow me.”

She slipped a hair behind her ear, looking like a bashful fan at Mydei’s meet and greet. But like, a hundred times more graceful.

Phainon knew that she was not doing it for show. He once read an article about Robin in a Penacony Air in-flight magazine that revealed Robin’s top 10 playlist, and Mydei’s *Regrets Are None* was among the top three. Phainon remembered that he took a picture of it and shared it with Mydei, only for Mydei to respond with a thumbs-up emoji. So Mydei must have known that she was saying the truth, too.

“But a couple of weeks ago, my grandfather sent me a few vinyls that belonged to our dear mother, and I came across the vinyl from *Queen Gorgo*.”

She paused, as if waiting for Mydei’s reaction.

Again, good call.

Because Phainon could see that Mydei was stiffening, his grip on Phainon’s hand was even tighter now as she mentioned Mydei’s late mother's stage name. He was always like that; even though by far the mention of Queen

Gorgo had always been followed by a positive commentary on her music and her image as the *Undethroned Queen of Rock and Roll*, Mydei always looked like he was bracing himself as if he were set to defend her against anything.

It was adorable, really—Mother's most formidable defender, Mydeimos. Phainon wanted to kiss his cheek.

"I love your music, but hers was absolutely phenomenal, and I love, love, LOVE them so much! It was far ahead of its time; the surprising blend of blues and rock really reached the very core of my heart. I couldn't stop listening to it, and I couldn't stop thinking about it. Her music was so beautiful that it inspired me."

Robin paused again, pressing her lips and blinking a few times, like she was trying not to fangirl. It was almost cute. Phainon almost wanted to coo.

How could someone be so beautiful, graceful, and adorably cute at the same time? What is she, really?

"I see," Mydei scoffed. "Thank you on her behalf, I guess."

"No, thank you, I'm so happy to even have the chance to appropriately express my praises. Your Mother is just amazing. I see where you get the talent and the inspiration from," she smiled—a pristine image of Dollywood Royalty.

Phainon could feel Mydei tensing. Again.

"... and actually, this is why we're here. I wrote a few songs as a tribute to her, and by some miracle, the Studios agreed to release them as my new summer release. But I think it is wrong to release them without involving you. Because you're her son, and um… you're the one who carries her legacy. So I think the proper way to release the songs is to involve you in a proper collaboration."

Mydei shrugged. "If that's the only reason, then just release them. No need to involve me," Mydei said. "Musicians inspire each other all the time. I

won’t sue you just because some of the beats you wrote sound similar to my Mom’s. I can name at least five underground bands that have done that. Why all the fuss of orchestrating the whole fake relationship thing?”

“Now, we finally get to the real problem,” the blond man with tacky fashion interrupted. Apparently, he had already given up his murderous intent and returned to that slimy smile attitude. “You see, Mydeimos. *Robin* can’t just do that. She can’t just walk out the door with heavy eyeliner and a black leather jacket and scream at the world. *Robin* has this brand about a girl next door. She’s our angel. Our sweet girl. She’s literally The Clockie Princess, you know that, right?”

The whole world knows that. But sure, by Kephale, forbid an artist from expressing himself, Phainon murmured in his head. But Mydei did not seem to be fazed.

“Yeah, and?”

“It means that she can’t just release a gritty, rebellious song with too many drums and screechy guitars on her own. It’s far too risky. Not just for her career, but for her image in general. I have a five-year-old daughter who sang Robin’s songs in class with her whole friend group, and those kids have matching keychains of Robin’s origami bird figure. We can’t just release rock-and-roll tracks all of a sudden. Not after the huge success of *Inside*. A sudden change of a pop star’s brand image was one of the top reasons for their fallout. The shock will literally kill the fans. So no, we can’t just *release them* without a care. It would be catastrophic.”

Translation: this guy didn’t want to lose sales on kids' merchandise once Robin is releasing a rock album. He didn’t want Robin to lose her popularity, which might cost him half of his enormous paycheck.

Yeah, catastrophic indeed.

“So don’t release it, then,” Mydei said, looking all baffled now, like he didn’t even understand why they were having this conversation at all.

Which Phainon agreed wholeheartedly. If it was going to have such a huge risk for her image, then why bother releasing those songs?

“I can answer why that would be such a huge loss, Mydei, and I don’t even talk about profit,” Anaxa chimed in from his place next to Aglaea. “Ratio had sent me a few samples of the tracks, and they’re *bangers*. It was far too cool, definitely far too amazing to be left dusty in the corner.”

Now, since it’s Anaxa, Phainon knew that it must come from a place of *professionalism*—an absolute truth. Anaxa loved Queen Gorgo. He still is, hence why he was very insistent that Mydei join his label when Sons of Gorgo was first formed. And Phainon was not very familiar with the music industry, but he was aware of Dr. Ratio. He was a genius producer who had worked with famous stars such as The Trailblazers, Boothill, and Lynx and The Landaus.

“I think we should listen to the samples now,” Aglaea added. “So it would be fair for Mydei.”

The room waited, and Mydei only shrugged. “Sure,” he said. “Go ahead.”

Aglaea typed on her laptop, and then a rhythmic guitar riff came through, followed by punchy drums and piano chords from the sound system in her room.

Then, a raw, gritty, commanding woman‘s voice was heard, singing with the air of smoky confidence. The snarl, the sharp *yeah*, the raspy verses were so sharp, so confident, like it was sung from the peak of Queen Gorgo's rock era.

Phainon paused.

Wait, that… can’t be Robin, right?

But when the song played on, and she hit the high notes, it was clear that *it is* Robin. Phainon raised his brows, almost whistling in admiration, but held himself back not to add an unnecessary voice to the otherwise perfect song.

Then, the next song played, and it was just as bold as the previous one. This one even had a hint of a challenging, seductive voice. Phainon could almost know which Gorgo's song inspired this; one of Mydei's favorite songs, too. The one that Phainon had said he wanted to play as their angry make-out song, but rejected with a yell about *"I will not do anything filthy with you with my mom's voice in the background"*, and a punch that left him bruised for days.

Then, the last song played. This one was bold, theatrical, thunderous, and uncharacteristically confident for Robin. It was more than a song inspired by Queen Gorgo. It felt like this track was meant to be written for Queen Gorgo herself in her prime, and at the same time, it also sounded the closest to *Robin* compared to the other tracks. The energy of her singing was contagious; it made you want to dance, join in with her *'ooooh lalala,*' and would *definitely* be a concert climax.

That song was such a statement, as if Robin was entering Queen Gorgo's castle, placing a laurel on her own head, and giving the entire place a new dawn with her voice. But instead of claiming the throne, she stood on the other side of the Queen, completing the image of royalty that had only ever been the Queen… and her son, Mydeimos.

Phainon could almost see where the idea of a fake relationship came from.

"The Rock Princess," Phainon whispered to himself, at the same time that the song ended. Making her voice the only one breaking the silence.

His quiet commentary was welcomed with a booming laugh from Aventurine.

"Clever observation, Okhema," Aventurine said. For the first time, acknowledging Phainon as a person and not just some unwanted mosquito. "It made her a *different kind of princess*. So you understand why I'm uneasy, right?"

No, Phainon did not understand. For him, it was good to show that Robin had an extensive range of creativity. She's more than just a studio-made pop

star. She's a talented artist who drew inspiration from a legendary musician and created an entirely new genre.

What's so catastrophic about it?

"You're afraid that this change of genre would be rejected harshly by the fans," Mydei suddenly spoke. "So you want to parade it behind a fake relationship with the son of Queen Gorgo. Because then, if people come to hate this, if the response did not fit your expectation, you could just frame the whole album as a love-driven experiment. A pop princess pulled by the magnetic charm of a rock boy, entered her rebellious phase, and strayed from her sparkly castle to make a few songs out of love. You could write off the whole thing as just *a phase*—an influence of a man she has an infatuation with. If it doesn't work out, you could break us up, and you could usher her back to Clockie Castle, where she could continue making pop music for the young girls."

Mydei paused, staring right at Aventurine as he continued.

"You want me there as the damage control."

Mydei spoke it in a flat tone, with no emotions present whatsoever. However, his brutal observation seemed to freeze the room, revealing the cold intention behind the collaboration. Robin pressed her lips and closed her eyes in surrender, looking like she did not want to be there at all. Aglaea let out a little smile, looking proud that Mydei had noticed something she must have seen since this Aventurine guy approached her the first time.

While Aventurine whistled.

"Brawn, Beauty, Brain," he said, in the same light tone and bright smile, despite his plan just being outed so brutally. "Please save something for the rest of us mortals, Mydeimos. It's not hurt to not be perfect for once, I assure you."

Mydei did not answer him. He was still silent, and his face was void of expression, but his tightened hold on Phainon's hand was enough of a giveaway for Phainon to understand what he truly felt.

“That’s more or less summarizes it, but I wouldn’t call it *damage control*, when this collaboration will benefit you the most. Robin did not just write a song inspired by your Mother. She invented a genius masterpiece. A whole album of it. She will bring the golden rock era from your mother to life, while giving it modern touches. It will be a fresh start for the rock-and-roll world. She would continue your mother’s voice that screams at the girls to own their femininity, be bold, and pursue the guys or girls they have crushes on. It’s empowering to the young audience, while also expanding the demographic for Sons of Gorgo. Make your band even more massive by targeting the young women’s market. Do you know how well that market is doing? They would literally buy anything, even badly formulated cosmetics, so long as they have your name on it.”

Aventurine was straight-up speaking nonsense now. Phainon could not even follow his own train of thought, aside from the fact that this man could not wait to cash in on those songs, milking every last bit of money he could make from them, while also benefiting from the PR insurance. That sounds remarkably similar to capitalism, in bold and black letters. But Aglaea raised her brows, and Mydei did not respond. Perhaps he’s onto something.

“And I haven’t even mentioned how it would benefit *you*. You will greatly benefit from Robin’s exposure. She had three times as many followers on Chrystagram, almost a billion views on TabTube; you will be the sexiest rockstar of the decade. Dating Robin would increase your charisma. You’ll be granted the title of sexiest man alive. The ladies would be all over you.”

Mydei scoffed. “Yeah, except I’m literally—.”

“Bisexual,” Anaxa and Aglaea retorted in unison, a rehearsed white lie they crafted at the beginning of Mydei’s career to keep him safe from the prejudices in the underground scene. Phainon did not mind. Status rarely means anything to him. He knew Mydei, and they had begun their relationship with openness and complete honesty from the start.

Mydei scoffed. “Whatever. That last part wasn’t necessary at all. I don’t care about sex appeal,”

“But you do agree those are amazing songs,” Aventurine pressed.

“Yes. The riffs are banger. Who did that?”

“Me,” Robin smiled. “I could play guitar too.”

“Huh,” Mydei hummed. “That’s sick.”

Robin nodded with a tiny blush, looking like she was proud of getting recognition from Mydei. She was genuine about this, Phainon could tell. And he thought it would be a harmless, even fun thing to do, if only that Aventurine guy did not spin it in that way just to make sure she could come out of it without a scratch, should her *experiment* fail.

It made the collaboration thing sound more sinister than it actually is.

But if Phainon thought about it, despite his questionable method, Aventurine might not be a terrible person. He was just a brilliant PR guy trying to accommodate his client. Perhaps just lacking a little (or a lot!) in the empathy department.

But again, perhaps the marketing people wouldn’t be great at their job if they weren’t a little bit morally grey.

Phainon just wondered how it would be for Mydei if the public didn’t like that collaboration at all. Would he be the one paying for the downfall?

“What about him?” Phainon suddenly asked. He still felt like he didn’t belong, and Aventurine’s gaze still made him feel small, but he pressed on. “If this thing failed, what about Mydei and the band?”

“I understand where that worry comes from, but the whole thing will be carefully crafted to protect everyone’s image,” Robin’s brother said. His tone was calm, less flashy than Aventurine’s, but no less persuasive. “As Mister Aventurine mentioned, we’ve ensured this collaboration will benefit both parties. I know it may *seem* like we’re trying to use you as a fallback if things don’t go well—which, for the record, I truly doubt. The music Robin just shared was phenomenal. And she created it out of deep respect for you and your mother’s legacy. With your creative input, I believe it could be

even more extraordinary. This arrangement serves only as both a precaution and a strategic promotional move.”

He cleared his throat, his gaze softening with a quiet melancholy as he continued.

“In an ideal world, I would give a Robin complete freedom to explore her artistry however she chooses without having to involve an outside party. However, right now, Clockie Studios relies heavily on her fame. Thousands of people work under that name. It’s my job to make sure Robin’s creative evolution doesn't jeopardize anyone’s livelihood. I know it’s not perfect, but… sometimes a small white lie is the only way to move things forward without closing any doors.”

Wow.

Talking about being persuasive.

It was either Robin’s brother had somehow learned of Mydei’s kindness to use it against him, or he was just a man sharing Mydei’s values for his people’s economy.

Because it hit Mydei right at his core, Phainon knew that. The only reason Mydei continued to perform at all, aside from his love for music and his mother’s legacy, was that there were people whose livelihoods depended on his fame. His five bandmates and their families, the Kremnoan people he hired as roadies or crew, and the individuals in the Kremnoan tourism industry who gained popularity after Mydei became a hit rockstar.

Aglaea must have noticed it too, because then she added. "Sunday spoke the truth, Mydei. I've reviewed the proposed PR plan thoroughly, and I do think it would serve us rather well," Aglaea said. "They've got the contingency sorted, and our team will ensure we come out of this without a scratch to your reputation. That said, this is entirely your call. We will not be moving forward with any of it unless you're on board."

Mydei only responded to Aglaea with a nod. “Alright,” he said, finally. “I only have two conditions to agree with this plan. First, I will get the final

say on the narrative. It's my mother's legacy. A single bad story about her, and I will quit the whole thing."

"Absolutely," Robin answered. "I am only doing it out of respect for her, and to carry on her music, I promise. I will not proceed if it harms her image in any way, either."

Mydei nodded in her direction again.

"And second," he said again, no less authoritative than the first one. "I will not do this if my partner has even the slightest discomfort about the plan."

Phainon nodded. Yeah, that's so reasonable and diplomatic of him to wish for his partner's approval. After all, a public fake relationship sounded like…

Wait.

Wait, wait, wait, wait.

It's him. *Phainon*.

Phainon is Mydei's partner.

He must state his agreement, isn't he?

Damn that Mydeimos bastard. So when he said that *he needed Phainon to be here*, it was quite in a literal sense, not some kind of romantic, moment-of-vulnerability thing as Phainon had thought. Damn you, Mydeimos. You're so lucky, you're super cute, and you have a nice ass.

Aventurine scoffed. "Sure, if you could put your boyfriend on the phone…"

"Phainon," Mydei nudged his shoulder, ignoring Aventurine. Again. "Now you've heard 'em. What do you think?"

For the first time since they entered the room, Phainon could feel the gazes of all people zeroed in on him. He raised his brows, suddenly feeling hyper aware of himself and the bad fashion he wore because Mydei had refused to

let him get out of bed all day yesterday. Aventurine narrowed his eyes at him, looking suspicious.

“Wait, *I Love Okhema* is your boyfriend?” Aventurine raised his voice, sounding scandalized. “Wow, rockstars do have weird taste in partners.”

Aventurine’s unnecessary jab at his fashion made Phainon even more self-aware. Bastard. Phainon was sure not to let Mydei get away with this. He’s super lucky that Phainon is head over heels for him—

His thought was interrupted when their eyes met, and Phainon momentarily forgot about his personal vendetta. He was far too distracted by Mydei’s golden eyes and how serious he looked.

He was being serious. He genuinely asked Phainon’s opinion about it.

And if Phainon knew anything about Mydeimos (he knows *everything*), he could see that Mydei was not actually opposed to the idea of this collaboration, as strange as it might be. Mydei had always wanted his mother’s music to be heard by as many people as it could, her legacy and message to be carried as far as possible. Queen Gorgo was a huge hit in the rockstar scene back in her day. She was predicted to be the next big thing, but then she was pregnant with Mydei, and she quit the scene altogether, promising to return with a Prince who knew exactly how to *rock*. But then, she passed away when Mydei was still very young.

The music industry was in grief at her passing. They called her a star dimmed too soon, an undethroned queen, basically put her on a pedestal for years. Mydei lowkey blamed himself for that. He still did now, hence his ambition to carry on his Mother’s legacy.

And everyone in the room knows that if it comes to promotion, nothing in the world is bigger than Robin. She was the biggest platform they could get.

That reason was an enticing enough offer on its own. Adding Robin’s phenomenal tracks on top of it was definitely a one-in-a-million chance. Something that other celebrities might be willing to kill for. But Phainon

knew that the music was what moved Mydei into agreement. Phainon saw how he was when they played the songs. He enjoyed them. Phainon could see how much he liked them, even under the mask of nonchalance that he wore so perfectly.

On paper, it was probably one of the best offers not only for Mydei nor the band, but also for Chrysos Records.

Still, with that much at stake, Mydei placed the final decision in Phainon's hands. *Phainon*. The last person in the room who knows anything about music, legacy, or fame.

Oh.

Was that why Mydei was so stressed about it back in the car? Was he worried about Phainon's thoughts? Did he have that much value in their relationship as much as he values his own ambition?

Aww.

Damn this man and his cute determination and his cute butt. Phainon wanted to cry.

Is it considered voyeurism if he kissed him right here and now?

Aventurine cleared his throat, definitely trying to get Phainon out of his own thoughts.

Bastard. But well, thank you for that.

"Ahem. I mean, if you want to do it, then go ahead, 'Dei," Phainon said. "That sounds cool. Your mom would really love it if she's still around."

"The *fake-relationship* part, HKS," Mydei hissed.

"Alright, alright, I'm getting there, be patient," Phainon replied. "I'm okay with that, too. Don't worry about it. I mean, as I said, it's just what celebrities do, right? Make headlines, give them a story? I mean, it sounds like a solid one, if you ask me. And for a better cause than we thought, too."

Pahinon gave Mydei a reassuring smile; the joke he threw carelessly at the car just now lingered in his voice, and Mydei smiled at him in return.

“I must be sure, though,” Phainon said, shifting his eyes to Robin’s brother (Sunday?), Aventurine, then Aglaea. “This will not hurt Mydei, right? His reputation, his music, himself, nothing?”

“It will not, I promise,” Robin’s brother, Sunday, said. “We will make sure the campaign goes smoothly, I can promise you that.”

“Right,” Phainon nodded. “But if it hurts him in any way, or makes him uncomfortable, I will stop agreeing with this. Okay? You must stop it immediately.”

Phainon turned to Mydei on the last part of his words, which was welcomed with Mydei’s lopsided smirk. Like he was proud of him.

“Alright,” he said as he squeezed Phainon’s hand. “The same goes the other way around. The moment it made Phainon uncomfortable, I would stop it too.”

“Aww, stop being so sweet, you two. My teeth will decay,” Aventurine clapped his hand, and Phainon could still hear him muttering *I love Okhema? Really?* Under his breath, before he continued. “Then in that case, let’s go over the details.”

Robin gave them the biggest smile, and her eyes lit up with hope and unmistakable joy, as beautiful as the first ray of the morning sun. Phainon couldn’t help but trust her to take care of Mydei throughout the act. She seemed to know her way around Aventurine’s schemes, and her love for music seemed to be so unmistakable.

By Kephale, Phainon hoped he did not just make a mistake.

Chapter 2: Blow Me Away

Chapter Summary

> As Aventurine's plan unfolded, Phainon had an absolute thrill watching it unfold. He did not doubt Mydei. He knew their love was strong. Until he witnessed a few loose ends that he tried to ignore.

Chapter Notes

> Hiii! I hope you enjoy this as much as I enjoy writing it.
> the title of the chapter, as usual, is taken from the song it took inspiration from, "Blow Me Away" by Breaking Benjamin ft Valora. I thought this song is perfect for Mydei and Robin's duet :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The meeting was… well, weird.

Phainon expected to be ushered out once he had given Mydei his approval of the plan. But apparently, Aventurine had gone back to considering him as an irrelevant mosquito as he presented his ‘roadmap’ of how this *Robin Goes Rock* ‘campaign’ would go for the next six months.

After ten minutes, Phainon gave up pretending to understand all of his marketing jargon and returned to the game on his phone. He was positive that Mydei would fill him in later, using simplified language he would definitely understand.

Though he did turn his attention back to the screen when Aventurine mentioned Robin’s and Mydei’s Moodboard, curious about what that was.

Apparently, it was a board filled with images, color palettes, and bullet points of how Robin would appear in public during her time “dating” Mydei. The outfit, the makeup, the accessories—every detail was meticulously planned.

Robin must always wear a bright inner layer: soft, pastel-toned chiffon or satin blouses in flowing silhouettes, dresses with gentle pleats, the kind that swayed delicately when she walked. The outerwear, however, was where the “rock” came in—cropped leather jackets, chunky bangles, platform boots, all in black or dark purple metallics. Only the top layer was allowed to be rebellious. The core of her fashion—the part closest to her body—had to remain feminine and bright.

Her makeup followed the same philosophy. No full black eyeliner, no heavy shadows. She would wear bright, translucent makeup with white or lavender eyeshadow over the lids, and a smoky gradient only at the outer edges; all the dark shades were concentrated on the outside, as if they had been placed there by an external influence.

“It’s a narrative layering for Robin,” Aventuine explained, swiping to the next slide in the confidence that told them he was very proud of his creation. “We’re keeping her core and adding the tension to it. The passion of young love, the admiration for the brave new world, which is completely different from her own. Mydei’s influence was engulfing her, *protecting* her.”

Phainon blinked slowly.

No, the way he saw it, that’s not how it looked at all.

Phainon knew nothing about Public Relations, but from what Aventurine had presented, he could only see that Robin’s rock persona was meant to be *detachable*; it was all outer accessories she could take off at the end of the night, and when things did not work out, her pop princess image stayed untouched.

Huh.

Before Phainon could say anything, Aventurine moved to Mydei’s moodboard. It was much simpler. Just his usual chaotic rocker aesthetic with hidden easter eggs tucked in: faded Clockie Studios shirt, a dove feather pendant on his necklace, a treble clef charm on his leather bracelet,

a small Robin-styled star on his favorite jackets, a silver star sticker on his guitar instead of the sun sticker—

“No,” Mydei said sharply. “The guitar and the sun sticker are *off limits.”*

“I see,” Aventurine hummed. “But maybe…”

“*Off. Limits.*”

“Alright,” Aventurine bit his tongue, his lips curved in a lopsided smirk as he made the tiniest glance at Phainon’s neck; probably at his sun tattoo that slightly resembled the one on Mydei’s guitar. “Noted.”

Then came the timeline: Mydei and Robin would start working on Robin’s tracks in two days, adding Mydei’s creative elements, with Anaxa and Dr. Ratio also joining in to co-produce the songs. Mydei had suggested putting it all together into one EP, to which Robin wholeheartedly agreed.

After the music, Aventurine also revealed how they would make news. In the first week, Robin would post a social media post of her breakfast with Mydei’s hand blurred in the background, then they were “caught” by Paparazzi getting out of a beachside restaurant in South Golden Hour. In the next few days, Robin would wear one of Mydei’s shirts, preferably from Mydei’s famous paparazzi photo, so the fans could easily connect the dots. Mydei would say something vague in a radio interview about “unexpected muses.” These weren’t obvious—just enough for obsessive fans to connect the dots in theory threads and “spot the reference” videos.

Phainon still wasn’t sure there would be people lifeless enough to connect the dots from them, let alone make theories and gossip. But again, it wasn’t his world. Phainon zoned out until a photoshopped image of Robin and Mydei at the Net Gala came to the screen.

They would attend as a couple, stealing the headlines, with so many reporters and media covering the event. Robin would wear a Gorgo-inspired dress, while Mydei donned a suit that matched her aesthetic. Not a matchy-matchy couple outfit per se; Robin would still wear her bright, sparkly colors. But their outfit must make a statement about the ‘Royal Couple’.

Phainon gaped, feeling a mix of unease and secondhand claustrophobia.

Mydei had received the invitation to the gala, Phainon knew as much. Aglaea had also proposed a few designs of the outfit he would be wearing; Phainon also knew about that. What he didn't know was that they had secretly matched it with Robin. It was as if they had planned it much earlier than 'a couple of days'.

The moodboard, the dress, the songs…

How long had they planned about this?

He glanced at Mydei, who was still staring at the screen, looking bored and nodding along like he was mentally five floors above this conversation. He did not look shocked, nor was he even slightly fazed. He seemed completely fine, listening to Aventurine outline where he would be, what he would wear, and how he would behave over the next *six months.*

Phainon turned to Robin and saw that she looked just as calm despite having her identity sliced into digestible bullet points and moodboard colors. She even chimed in with a few suggestions, pointing out where they could subtly echo Queen Gorgo's tour legacy, especially in the second quarter of the campaign. She looked a bit excited about the whole thing.

Perhaps this was normal, Phainon thought. *Perhaps this was just how it worked in this celebrity world. They're completely okay having their identity written down and planned out like a premonition.*

Phainon remained silent and returned to his phone. He's gotta find another chest to round up his stars to 160 anyway. He almost hit enough pity to get the Fig Stew chimera.

The meeting ended around thirty minutes later, just right when Phainon got enough stars to finally try his luck on the Fig Stew banner. Mydei nudged Phainon's chair, signaling him to get out. But just as Phainon wanted to get up from his chair, Robin approached them.

Wait, no, not them

Him.

Robin approached him. *Phainon*.

“Hello, can I have a moment of your time, please? My name is Robin, pleasure to meet you, um, Mister…”

Robin extended her hand for a handshake, to which Phainon could only stare in awe, unsure how to behave in front of such a famous person, whom he had seen on TV since he was in school. He blinked, completely starstruck as words refused to form on his tongue.

Mydei elbowed him, sobering him up.

“Oh, uh… yeah, right, Robin. *Phainon*. My name… is Phainon. Nice to meet you,” he said, giving Robin a quick handshake, and wow, so this is what it feels like touching an angel. Her hands were smooth, she smelled nice, and she was positively glowing, holy shit. “Um… and yes, Robin. I know you. I played a knight in my school play and sang your song.”

Phainon said that to cover his nervousness, but it sounded too awkward and robotic. He could hear Mydei snicker next to him, but thankfully, Robin did not join him in the laugh and nodded instead.

“I see, that sounds wonderful. I guess since we will be seeing each other more often, you could tell me about the play later? That must be a fun experience,” she said. “Oh, and please, no need to be so formal. I will be in your care from now,” she made a slight bow, a very graceful one, and Phainon nodded.

“Sure,” he said. He patted himself for *not* stammering. His mouth was dry, and he was nervous as fuck. Man, he’s not even into women, but by Kephale, this lady’s charm was something else. “Please also take care of Mydei. He could be… uh, *a handful*,” he continued, glancing at Mydei, who was just rolling his eyes.

“Let’s go home, HKS,” Mydei said, before turning to Robin. “We’ll be going ahead, Miss.”

“Oh, sure, please, don’t let me keep you,” Robin said. “Thank you again for being willing to do this with me, Mydei. It means so much to me. Please take care on your way home.”

“What’s the rush, boys? Come on, join us in the celebratory kickoff dinner,” Aventurine suddenly joined in the conversation, with his bright, cunning smile and his relaxed mannerism that somehow made Phainon a little bit stiff. “I know a lovely place downtown. Very private, super tasty food, my treat. You won’t regret it.”

Phainon glanced at Mydei, who only shrugged, not even thinking twice before rejecting. “No thanks, we already have a plan.”

“Come onnnn, it’ll be…”

“This isn’t in your plan, right?” Mydei interrupted. Again. Phainon bit back a smile. Aventurine had to start getting used to it. “I didn’t see it on your presentation deck, so no, we will not be joining. Thank you for the invitation, though.”

Aventurine opened his mouth, closed it for a moment, then chuckled. “Alright, I’ll see you at Golden Hour in a week, then,” he said, flashing a bright smile as he nodded. “Oh, but, *Okhema*, one more thing.”

“Phainon,” Mydei retorted. But his eyes were still on Aventurine, narrowing in a way that made Phainon a little bit… well, surprised.

“What?” Phainon whispered, wondering why Mydei had suddenly called him.

“*His* name is *Phainon*,” Mydei continued. His eyes were still locked onto Aventurine.

Oh.

He corrected Aventurine in a cold, flat tone that he usually reserved for people he did not like. Phainon had only seen this attitude when Mydei met an uncle from his father’s side. It scared him… a little. Phainon hadn’t seen

Mydei like this for a while. He was usually just aloof or curt, but rarely intimidating.

Phainon wondered if Mydei was also a little wary of Aventurine, and if this was his defense mechanism.

“If we’re gonna do this, you better respect him and address him properly because no way I’m gonna do any of your shit if he’s not being treated well.”

Aventurine did not back off. He met Mydei’s stare with lazy eyes, challenging him head-on despite Mydei’s arm looking bigger than Aventurine’s thigh, or that Mydei was a whole head taller than him.

This guy looked eerily fearless.

It made Phainon even more uneasy because a tough, muscular guy being challenging was one thing, but it was a whole different level when a petite, sleek guy was doing that. It felt like he knew nothing that the rest of them didn’t, and you could never be safe with him.

“Alright, *Phainon*,” he said, finally breaking his gaze from Mydei and shifting to talk to Phainon directly, flashing a polite smile and cheerful attitude. “Apologies for my whole… *impudence* today. You see, I’m really on the edge with the entire… *Robin Goes Rock* thing,” he let out a laugh. No pressure, no awkwardness at all. As if they were all just an old friend enjoying an old joke that everyone was familiar with.

Except that they didn’t, and it was weird as heck.

“But well, I’m glad your approval now helps us run things. I will take care of this just right, don’t worry. Your boyfriend is in good hands. Although I have just one more thing I need from you, before we part ways today…”

Phainon nodded. “Sure,” he replied, a little bit curious about what he could do to help Mydei, but mostly he just wanted this to be over soon, so he could go back to their apartment and enjoy the weekend together, as it was so rare to come by these days.

“I’m sure this goes without saying, but I would sleep better at night if you promise to keep this whole thing *confidential*, okay?” Aventurine smiled. “I talk about best friends, siblings, even nieces or nephews. People outside of this little tight-knit band of ours. After all, the success of this campaign relies solely on the complete control of the narrative. It would be easier for Mydei, too, if there were no *unnecessary complications*.”

Phainon did not know whether he was supposed to be offended or what that meant. But Aventurine was giving him his genuine smile, not the smug one. So he nodded, returning the hospitality in full.

“Sure, I will definitely remember that, Mister Aventurine,” he said. “Please let me know if there’s anything else I can do to help Mydei and Miss Robin in this project. I will happily do so.”

Aventurine answered with *a "thank you, absolutely*,” but before he could say anything more, Mydei interrupted him, saying they had somewhere to be and *really* needed to go.

And just like that, they got out of Aglaea’s office, taking the elevator down to the parking lot and finally back in the safety of their car.

Mydei leaned back to the passenger’s seat, groaning loudly as he covered his eyes with his arm. “By strife’s name, I hate PR people.”

Phainon chuckled. “You did well, ‘Dei,” he said as he rubbed Mydei’s shoulder, giving him an empathetic hum as Mydei leaned into his touch. “Didn’t even look like you’re going to stab that Aventurine guy. Well, you did a little, though, but overall, nice job.”

“I gotta be. He would’ve sunk his teeth in deeper if he smelled any of my emotion back then,” Mydei mumbled. “One thing I learned from Aglaea is that if the PR people start talking, you'd better not give them anything, especially emotions. They knew their way around it. Someone like *Aventurine* would know even better and use that to get to you.”

“Hmm, coming from Aglaea, that's gotta be some real shit,” Phainon nodded. “But, why did you drag me in there, ‘Dei? Isn’t it like… showing

your trump card to the enemy or something? Like, the way you acted, Aventurine would know that he could get you through me now."

Mydei peeked at him from behind his arm.

"Yeah, and that's precisely the point I want to get across. I want him to know that whatever shit he wants me to do in his circus, you will have a say in it. So whatever it is he and Aglaea are planning, they will not just consider how it would affect Robin, me, or the band, but also how it could affect *you*." he paused, and Phainon could see a slight tug on Mydei's lips as he continued. "Also, I want you to stop being naive for once and understand how important your decision would be in this."

Phainon raised his brows. "Me? Naive?"

Mydei gave him a look.

"I'm not naive!"

"Hephaestion once joked that he could kiss me in one music video to make a hit, and you said, *'okay, if it's good for the band'*."

Phainon gaped, starting the engine as he said, "Well…" That was not wrong. "Fine. But what was I supposed to say? I'm not just gonna keep you from *success* out of mere jealousy."

Mydei rolled his eyes. "This is exactly why I brought you in there, HKS. This time, it's not a Hephaestion joke you could just shrug off. This is big, and we can't always control the output. I want you to know what we've gotten into, and you have to be honest about how you feel about this entire situation. I could always find a way to honor Mom's music. But the music, the legacy, they're not more important than you. You hear that?"

He sounded serious, his heavy voice thickened by the silence in the car, like he wanted to hammer every syllable down to Phainon's skull. Like he always did when he talked about his parents.

Phainon hummed, allowing the silence to stretch a little more before nodding.

“Alright,” Phainon said, grabbing Mydei’s hand and placing it above the gear. “I’m truly fine with it, don’t worry. I know how fake that was. Aventuine had designed *everything* to the point that I won’t even have room to be surprised. I’ve known every small bit you would say and do in that scenario,” he chuckled. “If anything, it’s kind of exciting, you know? It must be hilarious to see how people react to those small clues Aventurine has placed. Though I also wanna see him fume when his plan fails. He seems very confident about how people will respond to those tiny clues. I don’t think people will have that much time to make theories out of celebrities.”

Mydei winced. “You’ll be surprised by what people on the internet can do.”

Phainon raised his brows. “Really? Then it’ll even be hilarious to watch. Like a worldwide virtual easter egg hunt, except I know what the actual catch is.”

Mydei’s lips tugged a little. “Yeah, you could do that,” he said. “But anyway, thank you for allowing me to do this.”

Phainon shrugged. “It’s fine, ‘Dei. You know I’m always here to support you,” he said. “Though I hope I won’t ever cross paths too much with that Aventurine. Dude totally creeped me out.”

Mydei scoffed. “You’re scared of someone smaller than you? Loser.”

“He’s almost half your size, yet he met your eye to eye. There’s something crazy-scary about small guys with that kind of guts, y’know? It feels like he knows something we don’t. Besides, he looked like… uh…”

“Sly fox? Shark?”

“No,” Phainon said. “Like the embodiment of capitalism.”

Mydei laughed again, this time louder. “You’re so dumb,” he said. “But that wasn’t wrong.”

“I know, right?” Phainon hummed. “But again, I think it means he’s really good at his job. And there’s Aglaea, Anaxa, and Robin’s brother, too. I know they’re decent people. Aglaea and Anaxa are, at least. And Robin is a literal angel. So I could trust that you’re in such capable hands. I wouldn’t have room to be worried about anything at all.”

Mydei grunted. “Hmm.”

“It’s just six months, anyway, right?”

“Yeah,” Mydei said. “It is. But just remember you got that safe word, ‘kay? Whenever you feel uncomfortable. Just say the word, and I’ll stop. You know how I mean it.”

“Mmm,” Phainon hummed. “You’re always so attentive to my *safe words*.”

“HKS, this is serious,” Mydei glared at him.

“Oh, sorry, I thought we already broke the ice when we talked shit about your PR maven guy,” Phainon chuckled. “But fine, I hear you. For now, do you want Honeycake takeout? After all of that, no way I’m gonna allow you to the kitchen…”

“Yes!” Mydei replied quickly. “Yes, please!”

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The rest of their weekends were not as eventful. Phainon had the Sunday he wanted with Mydei, cooking home meals together (well, Mydei did most of the actual cooking, while Phainon “helped” by sliding behind him, pressing his chest against Mydei’s back, and stealing kisses under the collar of his

shirt). He did the easier prep work—chopping vegetables, licking sauce off his boyfriend's fingers, deliberately driving Mydei to the brink of patience.

"Try to do that once again, and I will just give up this food and watch you die of starvation," Mydei had said, with a real annoyance in his voice. Despite the dark in his eyes, he looked like he *actually* wanted to finish the cooking.

"Keep bluffing," Phainon taunted. "You know you love keeping me *full*."

But despite his teasing, Phainon left Mydei to finish cooking and eating lunch together. Then, they caught up on their backlog of movies. They half-watched some, fully ignored others—especially once Phainon pulled Mydei onto his lap and dragged him into a slow, open-mouthed kiss that left no room for popcorn, only hands and heat and skin against skin, and the determination to tend to each other's insatiable needs.

Time flew by so fast when Phainon had Mydei in his arms, because the next thing they knew, the sun had dipped entirely below the horizon, leaving them alone in the dim light of their room, with their regulated breaths being the only sound.

The last hours of their free time together always felt bittersweet for Phainon. It always felt so wholesome, because as the weight of temporary separation loomed above them, Mydei would get a little bit… sentimental, for lack of better words. His emotions would clash and be unleashed in the most feral yet sweetest ways possible. His kisses would be deep with hunger, but they lingered like a promise. His touches would be rough, yet they wandered like a brush mapping Phainon's shapes for his keepsake, and his eyes…

His eyes would stare at him in challenge, in lust, in pride, and yet, as Phainon dived deeper, he would find the warmth and light that was just enough to rekindle his soul.

And as the night ended against their will, Mydei would curl against him, his hand inside Phainon's. He would press his back against Phainon's chest like

he hoped he could freeze them in time, but knew that because he couldn’t, he’d soaked in Phainon’s presence before morning light forced them apart.

It was cute to see such a child-like determination in the usually proud man. It made Phainon feel honored that Mydei allowed him to know that part of him. But it was also heartbreaking, knowing that it would be days, weeks, or even months before they could be this close again. Before Phainon could see this side of him again, and not the aloof rockstar who speaks profanities on video interviews or screams his lungs out on stage.

And with Mydei’s recording session and summer tour coming up, Phainon knew that it might probably be months, this time.

Phainon drifted to a dreamless sleep. With Mydei so close to him like that, it’s rare for Phainon to dream, knowing that he had everything he had ever wanted in this world in his embrace. When he slowly stirred from slumber, he could tell from the red glow bleeding through his eyelids that dawn had arrived: the moment to temporarily part had arrived.

Phainon pressed his lips to the back of Mydei’s neck, even before opening his own eyes, just to catch him before the world did. He inhaled the smell of Mydei’s hair; his natural scent and faint smell of his shampoo lingered in his nose, and he nuzzled against the other’s neck as the minutes dragged him further away from their small heaven, closer to the day with responsibilities.

When their bedside clock beeped, Mydei stirred, a low whine escaping his throat as he instinctively arched his back, pressing his body closer to Phainon in the same manner a little boy sank deeper into his blanket on a school day. His fingers fumbled for Phainon’s wrist, as if trying to keep him there a little longer.

“Morning, princess,” Phainon whispered against the curve of Mydei’s jaw, voice rough with sleep. He pressed a soft kiss there, lingering longer than usual. “Wanna join me for a shower?”

Mydei's response was a sleepy growl full of lazy protest and a firmer grip on his hand. “Stay.”

Phainon chuckled quietly. “Hey, now,” he said, even as his own body wanted nothing more but to obey Mydei’s words. “I gotta go, or else I’m gonna be late.”

“Stay,” Mydei repeated—this time with the petulance of a boy trying to will the sun back down. His voice was thick with sleep and grief tangled up together.

Phainon shifted, rising just enough to plant a kiss on Mydei’s cheek, then another on the corner of his eye, mirroring the tattoo on his left eye. Mydei made a weak protest sound. He still wouldn’t let go of Phainon’s fingers, holding them hostage in a lazy but determined grip.

“Alright, then, keep holding on to me,” Phainon chuckled again, pressing another kiss on Mydei’s nose. “If you really want to be dragged to the cold shower so badly.”

Mydei grunted, but eventually, he loosened his grip, letting Phainon slip away.

When Phainon got out of the shower, Mydei had dozed back off. His soft snore accompanied Phainon as he got ready for the day, dressing in his uniform, packing the few things he needed for the trip, zipping his suitcase, putting on his perfume, and reheating Mydei’s cooking for a quick breakfast. He would have wanted Mydei to join him, but Mydei looked so spent that Phainon did not have the heart to wake him. So Phainon ate alone and allowed Mydei to sleep a little longer.

Though he did not leave without saying goodbye, knowing Mydei would hate waking up to an empty house. So he kneeled on Mydei’s side of the bed and kissed the tip of his nose.

“Hey, sleeping beauty,” he whispered. “Wake up. I really have to leave.”

Mydei stirred in his sleep, opening an eye and stretching like a graceful lion, and frowned as he stared at Phainon. “You don’t have to go to work,” he grunted, his voice still groggy with sleep, but there was a hint of sadness

in there; the specific gloom that was always shown whenever one of them had to leave for work. “You could be my trophy husband.”

Phainon laughed softly, brushing hair from Mydei’s temple to kiss the furrow that shaped between his brows.

“How about *you* become *my* trophy husband?” he said, then kissed Mydei on the cheek. On the chin. On the tip of his nose. Except on his lips, because if Phainon did that, it would be even harder to leave.

“What’s even the point of that?” Mydei grumbled, still with that childlike whine of his. “You’ll just leave me again. Over and over. If you were *my* trophy husband, you could be with me on tour. You can always travel with me, we’d be going places together. We don’t have to do this every few days.”

“Come on, now, it’s just a short regional leg this time. I’ll see you in two days, I promise,” Phainon said. Then, with a wicked grin, he continued. “You won’t be alone for long this time. Today you’re scheduled to debut as a pop princess’s boyfriend, remember?”

“Fuck you,” Mydei muttered, tossing a pillow half-heartedly in his direction.

Phainon laughed. “Is that a promise?”

“*Get out*. Go fly somewhere, I don’t care.”

Phainon caught the pillow and laughed, leaning in for one last peck on Mydei’s nose. But the blonde did not let up. He caught Phainon’s lips to kiss him—drawn out, final, reluctant.

Phainon almost didn't want to leave him, with how dearly Mydei held on to him. It always squeezed his heart, how this rockstar whom the people praised and idolized melted in his touch.

“What’s the word?” Phainon broke the kiss, much to Mydei’s frown.

“No.”

“Honeycake.”

“*Stay*.”

Phainon chuckled.

“Safe flight, HKS,” he whispered into the kiss, before pressing one more against Phainon’s lips. Then, another whisper. “Call me when you land.”

“I will,” Phainon promised, kissing him once more—a seal, a goodbye. His hand lingered on Mydei’s cheek, savoring the last few seconds it had before he had to let go.

And then he stood, suitcase in hand, walking out the door, carrying the warmth and the ache with him.

He closed the door quietly. Behind it, his heart stayed curled in a bed of messy sheets, wearing a sad smile and a sleepy whisper of love.

-

To Phainon’s dismay, he did not get to see Mydei again in two days as he had planned.

When he landed back in Okhema after his short regional flight, he heard the news that one of the senior pilots on his roster was suddenly hospitalized, and Phainon was the only one available to cover his leg of a long-haul route. Rivet Town, of all places. The flight schedule was brutal, and the layovers barely allowed time to breathe, let alone to come home. Phainon got stuck in the rotation until the weekend, surviving on airport hotels and tight turnarounds.

Even calling Mydei proved to be difficult. Their conversation was reduced to a quick “good morning” before his early briefings, or a rushed “good night, sleep tight” sent at six in the evening—because by the time Mydei

actually went to bed, Phainon would already be 30,000 feet above the continent.

Phainon did catch the photos Mydei sent when his phone was off, though; the image of Robin in the recording booth, giving a peace sign and an angelic smile. A short clip of a mixer application, giving Phainon a glimpse of music that Mydei was working on, Hephaestion's selfie (definitely taken by Hephaestion himself when Mydei left his phone lying around), and more photos about the randomest things, like the sunset, his cooking, and a blurry picture of a cheerful Samoyed outside of Anaxa's house / recording studio that Mydei captioned as "you" under.

Phainon returned it with photos of the hotel walls, the cockpit, his mirror selfie on the hotel's mirror, and his catered breakfast. It was frustrating. Not just the exhaustion, but the gap that stretched longer between messages. Not because anything had gone wrong—just that they were too far apart, for too long, and the time zones were a bastard.

They had been doing this for years. Still, it didn't make it any easier.

Phainon sighed with relief when he finally landed back in Okhema on Monday morning, already looking forward to his rest day as he dragged his suitcase out of the plane. Though, as he got out of the gate, he was suddenly welcomed with the image of his boyfriend…

In the airport television. Which, for some reason, showed Mydei instead of boring old people, probably world leaders, as he could always expect on an international news channel.

Mydei was shown in a slightly pixelated image, clearly taken from a distance. He was wearing his usual sunglasses, a black sleeveless shirt with a Clockie Studio large print, and a pair of worn-out black jeans. His blond hair was tied in a ponytail, while his braided hair hung free, held by small fingers that belonged to…

Robin.

She was wearing an oversized striped shirt that clearly did not belong to her, a pleated denim mini-skirt, and a pair of black Oxford shoes with frilly, cream-colored socks. Her hair was tied up, revealing her head wings completely. In the next photo, the news showed, Mydei placed his black baseball hat on Robin as they walked to Mydei's car, apparently giving her a shield against the sun and probably the paparazzi. Her head wings perked up, like she was delighted.

Judging by the smile that the news portal zoomed in on, it was even clearer that she was, indeed, having fun.

Then, his eyes caught the title of the news.

Two Stars From Different Galaxies Collide in Romance?

Oh, Aventurine. The man that you are.

Phainon had to cover his lips with his fist, or else he would burst out laughing. He couldn't hear what the presenter was saying over the airport noises, but they looked serious as they pointed out on Robin's head, Mydei's arm, and Kephale knows what else, looking like they were looking for signs.

Huh, so Aventurine's plan was already in motion.

How long had it been? Phainon had truly lost track of time.

"Oh, sweet Kephale, so it's real?"

Phainon could hear Nymphas, one of the flight attendants on his flight, exclaim. She tugged a friend next to her, pointing at the TV screen.

"Nereia, look. Robin and Mydeimos are officially an item now?"

"What, for real?" Nereia, another flight attendant, replied. She glanced at the screen and scoffed. "Pft, probably just a publicity stunt, Nymph. There's no way Mydeimos would date someone like Robin. Isn't she… *too pop* for him?"

Too girly, Phainon made a mental retort. *Too girly and too Uptown. Mydei's taste was more like a country boy. Specifically, a boy from Aedes Elysiae.*

Nymphas shrugged. "Probably, but maybe it's from Robin's side? She had been a fan of Mydeimos since he debuted, after all!" she said, sounding too excited despite Nereia's criticism. "My dear Mnestia, she must be really happy that they finally got to hang out like that. I mean, look at her smile! She's beaming! Even her head wings perked up! When did the last time we saw her so happy like that?"

She was straight-up gushing now, and Phainon couldn't help but approach them, intrigued by Nymphas' apparent knowledge of the matter.

"Hi, ladies, what is it you're talking about?" he asked. "Is it about Mydeimos and Robin?"

"Oh, Captain, hello!" Nymphas greeted him with a bright smile. "Are you following the news about them as well?"

"No, not so much. But I am somewhat of a fan of Robin, and I just caught the news of them together on TV just now. I'm curious about why she's hanging out with Mydeimos. Isn't he like, a totally different musician or something?" he replied. "What is it about them being in romance?"

Phainon was deliberately playing dumb now, and he felt a little bad about it. But his curiosity was enough to get Nymphas perked up, looking like she was glad to have someone to talk about it.

"No official statements yet, Captain. But it had been trending for a few days now. There's a theory circulating on the internet about Robin finally getting to hang out with her long-standing celebrity crush. It was so cute!"

"Long-standing crush?" Phainon hummed, genuinely invested in her words now because Phainon did not know *that*. He did know that Robin was a fan of Mydei. He didn't know that it was a *crush* or that it was a *long-standing*. "I thought she just liked their song?"

“She’s a fan of Sons of Gorgo, yes. But she’s also a total fangirl of Mydeimos *since forever*. In Sons of Gorgo's debut year, they won the Best Rock Artist. There’s an edit that shows Robin giving them a standing ovation, smiling wider than when she won Best Female Artist of the Year. Her eyes were glued to Mydeimos. There’s a video thread for that. I think people are still using her GIF as a reaction meme.”

Since forever, Phainon had repeated that in his mind and had taken a mental note to look for the video thread Nymphas mentioned.

“Then, when she won Best Song of the Year in that same year, she also said that her win was dedicated to all the artists in the nominations, including Sons of Gorgo. She mentioned them specifically! Oh, and she mentioned in a few interviews that Mydeimos’ fiery vocals helped lift the mood. She wore a Red Lion shirt in some paparazzi pictures, too! Red Lion was synonymous with Mydeimos, right?” Nympas added again.

She must have realized that she totally geeked out now, because then she cleared her throat and went back to her more serious self, looking a bit sheepish.

“I mean, it’s just so cute, you know? For her to finally get so close to the person she had had a celebrity crush on since forever. I couldn’t help but feel so happy for her. With Robin’s tight schedule, she rarely had time for personal stuff. She must finally have time for herself now that her Clockie Weekly Show wrapped up its final season.”

Phainon chuckled. “Don’t worry, I understand,” he said. “But what started the dating rumor?”

“There’s this Chrystagram Story on Robin’s account. It was not unusual; Robin was not very stingy in sharing her daily life. But on that particular post, there’s an arm of a man with a red tattoo in the background. It was too blurry, but some people matched it with Mydeimos’ arm tattoo, and the pattern was identical. Then there’s this live interview of Mydeimos at an event. He was wearing a chain necklace with a dove feather pendant that looked like it was Robin’s…”

“Mydeimos wears anything he likes. The internet is reading too much into it,” Nereia interrupted, huffing as they walked outside the exit gate. “It’s probably just something that some fans gave him. He likes to wear them in public to show he appreciates them.”

“No, no, but listen to this,” Nymphas said. “Yesterday, Mydeimos posted a Chrystagram Stories of him in the studio, and you know what the caption is?”

“A dove emoji,” Nereia answered. “Still, it didn’t mean anything.”

“That’s two clues hinting at doves, Nereia! Dove is the official emoji for Robin! Everyone knows that,” Nymphas said. “Captain is a Robin fan. You know that, right, Captain?”

Phainon did not know that, but he knows now, so he nodded. “Yeah, I guess?”

Nereia huffed. “I’m betting they’re just in a project together,” she said. “Mydeimos was not the type of person who liked his personal life to be under the spotlight. I mean, four years since debut and not a single dating rumor? That man knows how to keep a secret. This is probably a deliberate move. They’re probably just releasing something together. A duet, maybe. Not necessarily *romance*.”

Wow. Phainon was almost impressed by Nereia’s sensibility. He pressed his lips, trying so hard to bite back a smile. Wait until Aglaea or that Aventurine man hears about this.

“Hm,” Nymphas pouted. “Didn’t he have that… news about him with that bandmate of his?”

“Hepy? Oh, no, that was debunked quickly after. Hepy was just generally touchy, and they’re nothing but good friends.”

Ah. Now Phainon remembered that news. They thought Mydeimos and Hephaestion were a couple, back when Mydeimos first came out as bisexual (as per Aglaea’s direction), until they had to clarify that they’re

not. It was hilarious. Phainon still teased Mydei about it sometimes. Nereia seemed to know about Mydei's stuff. She's probably a huge fan of Mydei, as much as Nymphas is a massive fan of Robin.

Phainon almost wished he could give Nereia something related to Mydei. Probably a signed copy of his album or something. But he couldn't risk exposing his connection to Mydei. They had strictly promised each other to keep their relationship a private matter when Mydei resigned his contract to Anaxa's label.

"But, assuming that it's real," Nymphas insisted, bringing Phainon back to the ongoing conversation. "Don't you think they look good together?"

Nereia paused for a bit, sighing in a way that she was resigning to Nymphas' persistence. "Kind of?" she said. "It's like a Dollywood Power Couple. You wouldn't have a choice but to root for them."

"Right? What do you think, Captain?" Nymphas asked him directly now, tilting her head in his direction to look at his expression.

Phainon did not even fake his smile and enthusiasm. "What Nereia said," he replied. "I think they're a perfect match for each other."

Oh, the thrill of knowing something people don't.

When they finally parted ways at the exit, and Phainon got a cab ride home, Phainon finally opened his phone and scrolled through the *Dweetter* app. True to Nymphas' words, Mydei, Robin, and a hashtag called #LionDove were trending. Phainon clicked on the hashtag and was presented with more photos of Mydei and Robin in front of the Golden Hour restaurant. In a few pictures taken before they entered Mydei's car, they were seen holding hands, and Mydei even smiled; his pristine white teeth, which Phainon loved to trace with his tongue, flashed for the camera.

He looked so beautiful.

And so did Robin next to him. They were a great contrast, but they looked so perfect together. Like *the Dollywood Power Couple*, as Nereia had called

it.

Phainon scrolled through the posts under the picture and read some of them.

- ***@TimelyClockieDove*** *A pair of music royalty from different sides of the music world, paired off to conquer the world. We never got a chance.*
- **@mydeisguitarcase** OMGGGG Shippp??? Ship ship ship!
- **@daughtersofgorgo** Robin finally dating her celebrity crush is so inspiring. We could all date our celebrity crush, too, trust!
- **@mydeixmisia** our ship had officially sunk. But congrats lovebirds!! Or should we say… lovecubs?
- **@Robindiehard** Ew him? She's too good for him.
- **@Mydeidiehard @robindiehard** EXCUSE YOU??? He's too rock and roll for the pop princess. He's too good for her!!!

Phainon couldn't help but laugh over the people arguing about how Robin and Mydei were not a good match, nodding over a theory that it was most likely a publicity stunt, but also amused by the theory that stated that it was, in fact, a real dating story. There was a story thread about it that called back Robin, mentioning Mydei over the past few years. Phainon watched every video, finally catching that Music Award moment that Nymphas talked about.

There was an edited video that included an explanatory line about Robin's gaze, which was fixed directly on Mydei while she was giving her speech. As she mentioned Sons of Gorgo, her hand pointed in the general direction where the band sat, but her forefinger was pointed directly at Mydei. There was an interview on *Good Morning Penacony!* Show where Robin mentioned that she learned how to play the electric guitar for her newly

released movie by listening to Mydei's guitar in Sons of Gorgo's second album. Then there was a picture of her wearing white shirts featuring red lion-cub images, dating back to Sons of Gorgo's debut year.

It was hilarious how people had the time to collect all of those moments and place them together to support these dating allegations.

Mydei was right.

Aventurine *does* know what he's doing.

Phainon only stopped scrolling when he finally got home. True to his suspicion, Mydei wasn't home yet. He was probably already off to the studio. Phainon sent him a quick text to tell him that he's already home, took a shower, and lay on his bed, planning to get some sleep to make up for his exhausting week, but he just couldn't stop scrolling.

Phainon caught a few videos of Mydei in return, who had mentioned Robin in some way. It was far less than Robin mentioning Mydei, which makes it even more hilarious. There's a video where they asked Mydei what he thinks about Robin in a red-carpet interview, to which Mydei hummed, "She's super talented. She earned the fame she has now." Which, in *Mydei's language* (according to people), meant, "She's incredible, I adore her, and she deserves all the love".

Phainon was sure that in *Mydei's real language*, it means that "I know who Robin is, but I don't pay that much attention, and I want to go home."

Then, in a game show, when Mydei was asked where the lyrics came from, he correctly guessed Robin's lyrics thrice, whereas the rest of his bandmates failed every time. The post said it meant Mydei was secretly a Robin's big fan, but Phainon knew the reason Mydei got everything right was that Phainon sang those songs in the shower almost every day. He blasted them in their car. Mydei had no choice but to know the lyrics.

Then, when an interviewer asked Mydei what he thinks of Robin's Lion Cub shirts, which were Sons of Gorgo official merchandise, Mydei said,

“It’s very kind of Robin to help promote our merch. Kudos,” and he was *blushing* while saying that.

Phainon couldn’t help but laugh out loud at that.

Mydei was not blushing. He was suffering from heatstroke. He spent almost two weeks in the cold winter of Jarilo’s Snowplains to shoot a video clip, and the sudden blast of Okhema’s summer heat was what made him *blush*.

Oh, this is gold.

Phainon now understood what Mydei meant when he told him about what people on the internet could do.

He took a couple of screenshots to tell (and tease) Mydei later. He was in the middle of watching a theory video about why Mydei and Robin would rule the music industry if the dating allegations were true when he heard his front door open.

Phainon did not even have time to jump out of bed to greet Mydei. When he entered the room, his guitar case on one shoulder and a bag of takeout that smelled suspiciously like Thai food. His shoulders drooped, with bags under his eyes, but a smile spread across his face as their eyes met.

“Hey,” he said, sounding as exhausted as he looked. Mydei dropped the guitar case and the takeout gently on the floor, and lay on the bed, his head on Phainon’s thigh.

“Hey, yourself,” Phainon said, getting up just enough to kiss Mydei.

“I thought you’d be sleeping,” Mydei said, tilting his head to Phainon’s gaze.

“I was gonna, but I was distracted by the news about Robin and your dating allegations,” Phainon said. “These are so funny. They said you’ve been secretly dating for years, based on one heatstroke interview right after you got back from Jarilo. Aventurine really outdid himself. It’s a freakin snowball out there, ‘Dei.”

Mydei looked at Phainon—really looked at him, and chuckled. “I’m glad you’re having fun out of that circus show, at least,” he said. His voice was heavy, like he could fall asleep anytime soon.

“Are you kidding? These are gold. I was in the middle of watching ‘The Moments Mydei and Robin crossed paths and gave each other references, when you came in,” Phainon laughed. He brushed his thumb under Mydei’s eyes. “How’s the recording? You look terribly exhausted.”

“Mmm,” Mydei hummed. “Anaxa kicked me out.”

Phainon furrowed his brows. He shut his phone and placed it on the table to give Mydei his full attention. “For a good reason, I suppose?”

“Mmm, I hadn’t slept a wink since yesterday,” Mydei said. “Finishing the last track of the EP. Anaxa came in this morning and just… kicked me out. Had Aglaea’s bodyguard escort me and shit.”

“Oh, dear,” Phainon frowned. “Why, did you decide that sleep is for the weak?”

Mydei scoffed. He did not say anything for a while, and with the quiet hum of his breath, Phainon would have mistaken him as sleeping.

But then, he opened his eyes and stared at Phainon.

“Veritas told us two days ago that while the EP was gold and could sell well, it still needs the punch for it to actually work,” Mydei said. “That man was fuckin insane, HKS. Crazy perfectionist, but I gotta admit. He knows his shit. This EP was intended as Robin’s coming-of-age experiment, and I attempted to preserve my mom’s legacy through her talent. This shit is so ambitious that they decided to name this Royalty. But it lacked something puchy. Not fit for a king or whatever. I don’t really understand what he was saying, but I kind of agree.”

Phainon combed Mydei’s wild mane, half-damp from sweat. “This Veritas is… Dr. Ratio, right?” he asked, trying to catch on.

“Yeah,” Mydei sighed. “Fucking Veritas Ratio. He had us in the studio for days, sunrise to sunset. Perdikkas was planning Veritas’ murder. We were all running out of creative juice, so in desperation, I pulled one of Mom’s samplers from way back. The one I never thought would see the light of day. Blow Me Away. You remember that?”

“Mm-hmm,” Phainon said, his hands now moved to Mydei’s temple, massaging it gently. Mydei sighed into his touch, and Phainon let out a smile. “It’s the song that your Mom wrote when she was pregnant with you? The one she envisioned to be your debut duet song, Mom and kid?”

“Mmm,” Mydei hummed, whether to answer Phainon’s question or as a response to his massage, Phainon would never know. “I was just taking a shot in the dark, not actually thinking it’s going to work. I just want to distract him. But then Veritas asked Robin and me to record it later that day. When it’s finished, I did everything I could to finish the demo as fast as I could.”

“And?”

Mydei smiled. “And… you listen to this.”

He pulled out his phone and played the song.

Robin’s harmonious scream was the first thing that Phainon listened to, followed by a series of explosive drums, riffs, and a harmony that was so powerful that Phainon couldn’t help but gape.

That song was the bomb. Robin’s voice came out so powerful. *Explosive*. She didn’t just match the energy—she met Mydei’s growl head-on with the same brevity. She wasn’t screaming—she was *singing*, every note sharp and alive, riding the rhythm instead of fighting it. They were truly a harmony—the prince and princess of their own domains, merging into one.

An absolute harmony.

Royalty.

The song ended with Mydei and Robin singing the last part of the chorus. The silence that crashed in after their final shout was chilling. Fiery. Full of energy. Phainon tried to describe it in his mind, but he couldn't find the words. The energy still echoed in the walls of their room, filling it with a sense of soul.

"Damn," Phainon said. "That's amazing."

"This girl, Phainon," Mydei whispered. There's softness in his tired gaze, admiration in his weary voice. "She could match Mom's vocal range. That song was the toughest one to preserve. I couldn't ever change it because it sounded too much like Mom. I didn't want to erase any part of it. Yet, I could never sing it because I couldn't sing her part. No one, not a single person, has ever met that range. And she just walked into that booth, and…"

Mydei paused. His brows furrowed, like he was trying to find the right word for it.

"And own it."

"And *own* it," Mydei repeated, closing his eyes again. His lips were tugged into a lazy smile. "Yes, that's it. That's the word I've been looking for to picture her. Fuckin hell, she's—I love you."

Phainon paused. He did not know to whom the love was addressed; Robin? Gorgo's image in Mydei's head? Phainon? He could not tell when Mydei was slurry like that. Still, he brushed a finger on Mydei's cheek and hummed, "Love you too."

Mydei did not reply.

He had fallen asleep.

Phainon stared at Mydei's peaceful slumber face, the ghost of a smile that remained from having his mother revived in the form of the melody. The contentment he felt made Phainon's heart flutter. He leaned to kiss Mydei's

temple one last time before lying on the bed, falling to his much-needed sleep.

Mydei’s dreamy eyes were the last thing Phainon saw before he closed his own. And this time, somehow, despite having Mydei so close, Phainon dreams.

He stood in the shadows of the concert crowd, surrounded by faceless fans chanting Mydei’s name. Mydei was on the huge stage. He was bathed in the gold spotlight, voice soaring, hair whipping.

He was the star; everyone worshipped him, obsessed with him.

He’s perfect. A perfection that rules over the people.

Phainon raised his hand once, hoping for a glance, a smirk, a nod—something. But Mydei just looked forward. Never at Phainon, but at the lights, at something beyond the crowds that cheered for him.

He was looking at the stars, where he truly belonged.

A place where another face of the crowd like Phainon could never reach.

Chapter End Notes

Oooh the fear started to creep in. Please stay strong, Phainon!

End note: I finished this as much as I could, to celebrate Mydei X Phainon getting into top 16 ships in Summer 2025 aaaa long live our Homotron3000!!
also if you'd like let's be friends on X! @mydaymousee

Chapter 3: Royalty

Chapter Summary

> As the music was ready to be published and Phainon walked deeper into Aventurine's marketing ploy, he realized that this whole fake-relationship thing might be tougher than he thought.

Chapter Notes

> Hello! Aaaah I'm just so happy I could finish this chapter >.<
>
> I had to change the rating because apparently I can't resist writing a little bit of Phaidei sexy time in between the plot, but it will be very mild and not at explicit. So yeah, I hope it's okay!
>
> Anyway, I hope you enjoy a little bit of pain here

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon woke up to the smell of garlic toast and meat, and to butterfly kisses skimming the tip of his nose, chin, cheek, and…

He put both of his hands on the shape of Mydei’s face, capturing him and returning the kisses with a peck on his lips. Then, when he opened his eyes, he was giggling at the frown that greeted him. Mydei looked really cute like that, like a kitten who got offended that someone was kissing its mighty paw without its regal permission.

“Hey there, beautiful,” Phainon whispered.

Mydei let out a scoff and a gentle smile. “Hey sunshine,” he hummed, pressing another kiss to Phainon as he climbed back to bed, caging Phainon under him as he continued to give small, quick kisses. Phainon couldn’t help but chuckle, circling his hands around Mydei’s neck and pulling him closer.

“What’s with this kitty kisses?” he asked between Mydei’s kisses. His heart sang with joy, and warmth bloomed all over him as Mydei’s fingers found his messy hair. “Missed me much?”

“Mmm,” Mydei hummed into the kiss. His lips stayed longer this time. Deeper. “Shut...” another kiss, then “...up…” then another kiss. “... HKS,” then another kiss.

Phainon held Mydei tighter, not letting him escape. He kissed him long and deep, licking along Mydei’s lower lip. As Mydei let out a low, breathy sigh, Phainon’s tongue lingered between his parting lips, lazily poking Mydei’s with his own.

The rockstar didn’t stay lost in the haze for long. He pushed back, kissing Phainon deeper, whining into his mouth as his body melted into Phainon’s. They were pressed into each other so tightly, Phainon could feel Mydei’s heartbeat against his own, his body heat all over his skin, and his half-hard member against his own.

He didn’t waste another second before rolling Mydei over, caging him to the bed, and moving his hips against Mydei’s, which he welcomed with a slight whine.

The blond, however, pulled away, his kiss-swollen lips tugged into a frown. “Aren’t you hungry?” he said. “Your breakfast’s gonna get cold.”

“Mm,” Phainon kissed the corner of Mydei’s lips, one of his hands already slipping into Mydei’s pants and cupping his now hard member, which was promptly welcomed with Mydei’s sharp gasp. “Still feels pretty hot to me.”

“I gotta uh… go back to the studio in a bit,” Mydei said with a low, heavy voice. His words were interrupted with a hitch of his breath.

“Then,” Phainon sucked the spot on Mydei’s skin where his jaw and neck met, then kissed the inside of Mydei’s ear as he whispered. “We just gotta be quick.”

Mydei’s surrender was the bite on Phainon’s lips, and Phainon matched his harmony with the caress to the part of Mydei’s skin that he knew would elicit the cutest and sexiest reactions. Soon enough, they were engaged in a rhythm that satisfied their needs, savored each other’s presence, and cured the unbearable longing they had endured for the past week. They move slowly, reverently, worshipping each other’s bodies with that quiet awareness at the edge of their touch that this wasn’t their usual weekend sanctuary. Their time was borrowed, this time. There’s a world waiting for them—for Mydei.

Mydei’s long, guttural moan was Phainon’s finish line, the starburst he’d been chasing so fervently, pulling him under in its wake. Phainon pressed his forehead to Mydei’s, breathing in the warmth of Mydei’s happy sigh—the smell of peppermint mapping the blush on Phainon’s skin, a flare that rekindled the phantom trail of Mydei’s kisses all across his face.

He was happy. So, so happy that the nightmare he had the night before quickly dissolved in the fullness of Mydei’s presence.

“Regional leg my ass,” Mydei groaned between panting breaths. His face was flushed, his voice trembled, and his glassy golden eyes were the prettiest diamonds Phainon had ever laid on. “You’ve gone a whole week, you fucker.”

Phainon scoffed a tiny laugh. “I miss you too,” Phainon said, pulling away from Mydei and lying half on top of him, kissing Mydei’s shoulder blade sloppily. “How long have you been awake?”

“An hour and a half, maybe. I don’t remember,” Mydei replied. “I cooked you breakfast.”

“*Cook*,” Phainon hummed. “I thought you bought me a Pad Thai takeaway. Must be a dream.”

“No, I did buy you a Pad Thai. *Yesterday*,” Mydei said. “I think it’s still edible, but your stomach's gonna be upset if you eat a Thai pad in the morning. So I cooked you Swedish meatball salad.”

Swedish Meatball salad. Phainon's absolute favorite. As if on cue, Phainon's stomach growled. He kissed the part of Mydei's skin he could reach as he mumbled, "*I love* you so fuckin' much."

Mydei did not answer him, but his lips tugged a little. "I know," Mydei said. "Go clean up and brush your teeth, you stank."

"Didn't hear you complain when you assaulted my mouth just now," Phainon poked Mydei's cheek, laughing when Mydei rolled his eyes. "Come on, I'll help you clean up too."

"No, you'll just fuck me again if you get anywhere near my ass," Mydei furrowed his brows. There was a slight amusement in his smile when he pushed Phainon away playfully. "Go use the sink in the guest restroom."

"Playing hard to get?" Phainon teased, flicking Mydei's nose.

"No, HKS. I really do gotta go back to the studio. Ratio and Anaxa had finished mixing yesterday's songs while I was sleeping like a log. They want me to come back and have a listen with the rest of the team," Mydei replied, brushing his thumb against Phainon's cheek. "If all is set, maybe we could wrap up early and… we can pick up where we left off? How about that?"

"Mm, sounds good," Phainon said, pressing his lips on Mydei's thumb. "Alright, up we go, then."

Mydei exhaled a quiet laugh, like he didn't really want to go either. But as much as Phainon was tempted to keep Mydei in bed for himself, he knew better not to submit to his selfish whim. Mydei had something to do—something probably worth millions of credits and important to the overall well-being of his career and Chrysos Records.

So he got up from bed, brushed his teeth and washed his face, and changed into something decent. When he arrived at the dining room, Mydei was already there, freshly changed into his usual rockstar attire: a sleeveless, worn-out black shirt, skinny black jeans, and a pair of scuffed-up Cherry

Red Dr. Markenz, the ones Phainon had gifted him a few years ago on their first Valentine's Day together.

"What, no Clockie Studios shirt today?" Phainon teased.

Mydei only scoffed. "Fuck off."

Breakfast was like their usual lazy mornings, with them updating each other on what they missed while they were apart. Phainon talked about his long flights, which surprisingly went smoothly with minimal turbulence, and Rivet Town's new airport mascot, which was *so damn cute*. (Yes, I saw your photo. It's literally a golden trash can, HKS | Trash cans *can* be cute. Caelus thinks so, too | I wouldn't count on Caelus's taste to justify my opinion. His taste is trash). and the joke Phainon learned from his young First Officer.

Phainon also poked fun at the internet comments of Mydei's fake relationship with Robin, listing them from what he thought was funniest. But Mydei only scoffed, with no real smile on his face. Phainon decided that Mydei wasn't too comfortable talking about that, so Phainon changed the subject.

In return, Mydei told him about his week: how cool and professional Ratio was, how exhausting Aventurine was to be around, and a more elaborate version of how amazing Robin was as a vocalist and musician.

Mydei had never spoken so openly about anyone in the music industry to Phainon, and this change was welcomed. Phainon listened closely to how great Robin's vocal range was, how meticulous and soulful her input was, and how Mydei felt that his mother's legacy was in good hands. Phainon listened with awe. He had always loved Robin's music, and all this time, he had always thought that she was primarily a performer; that most of her songs were handled by a set of professionals. To realize she had just as much passion for music as Mydei…

Phainon couldn't help but feel happy that Mydei finally found someone who could truly match his energy, and his Mom's. It was so strange to even think about that Phainon would ever see a day when Queen Gorgo's spirit

would be brought open like this again, without Mydei trying to translate it to his own voice and music.

He had been with Mydei for four years and had seen him compose songs and write lyrics so many times. Yet, Phainon had never seen Mydei like this before. So full of fire, like he was glowing from the inside.

Alive.

It was a blessing to listen to the truth behind the spotlight. He couldn't help but imagine that there were people out there who would give just about anything to hear even just a fragment of this story. Nymphas would really love to know this. Phainon wished he could talk to her about it.

But he promised Aventurine, and even long before that, he promised Anaxa and Aglaea. So no, he had to keep it to himself.

After they finished their breakfast, Phainon took the time to braid the side of Mydei's hair as he watched him through the living room mirror, analyzing the movement of Phainon's hands while his finger traced a random pattern on Phainon's thigh.

"You're free today, yeah?" Mydei asked.

"Mhm," Phainon hummed.

"Come with me to the studio. I'd like you to listen to the finalized tracks, too."

Phainon stopped his fingers, staring at Mydei through the mirror. "Are you sure it's okay?" he asked. "Wouldn't that like… messing with the whole fake-dating thing if I'm there?"

Mydei shrugged. "It's just the whole band who's gonna be there, and Robin, and the producers, and some of the studio dudes who already know about us," he replied, shifting his body to stare directly at Phainon instead of through the mirror. "Today it's just that and the photoshoot, I think. The

whole band will be there. You could hang with Perdikkas or Hep if hanging around me makes you nervous."

"It's not you I'm worried about, princess," Phainon said. He kissed the rubber that tied Mydei's braid and went back to the dining table to sip Mydei's homemade pomegranate and milk. Good Heavens. Phainon loves this man and his sexy ass and his magic cooking hand and his absurdly gorgeous look. "Maybe you should ask Aventurine or Aglaea, just to be sure? I don't want to be a bother."

"Who gives a fuck about Aventurine?" Mydei rolled his eyes.

"Everyone? Isn't he like the industry's PR master or something? Even Aglaea respected him."

"I don't, and that should be the only thing that matters," Mydei said. "But fine, if you're so hesitant, just drive me there. That way, we can have more time together, at least."

Phainon smiled at Mydei. "Aww, you really want me to be there," he cooed. "You do miss me that much, huh?"

"Fuck off. I got up earlier than you to cook your breakfast. I'm too tired to drive, and it's too much of a hassle to ask for a driver to pick me up. If *Aventurine* decides you can't be around, you could go back home."

"You only woke up *one hour* earlier. Can't be that tired, especially since you sleep earlier too."

"One hour and *twenty minutes*!"

"Oh, now you suddenly remember the minute?"

"Because it *actually* matters," Mydei insisted. "At least it matters more than that two-centimeter height difference you keep bragging about."

"*Excuse you*, my father's genes worked hard for those *two centimeters*!"

They kept arguing about the most pointless things—the kind of back-and-forth, the harmless jabs that Phainon loved dearly, and judging by the way Mydei's lip twitched with a barely-there smile, he knew the meeting was mutual.

In the end, of course, he drove Mydei to the studio. There was no way in hell he'd say no—not especially when the drive promised a gentle moment where Mydei leaned against him in the car, his head resting on Phainon's shoulder, one hand still lazily tangled with his own. Even if Phainon ended up banned from joining him, it was worth it just to be this close.

Just to be part of the ride, even if he wasn't meant to stay.

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As it turned out, Mydei was right. The studio was full of familiar faces. Nobody even blinked when Phainon followed Mydei through the doors, least of all Hephaestion, who lit up the moment he saw him.

"Boyfriendddd!" he shouted, crossing the room with open arms and rushing to hug Phainon tightly.

"Hey…" Phainon chuckled awkwardly, patting Hephaestion's back upon contact. "You look energetic, Hep,"

Mydei's neutral face twisted slightly, in a subtle way that only Phainon could notice.

"*Hephaestion*, get off him."

"What, *Mydeimos*, you get to be a fake-boyfriend and I can't?" Hephaestion pouted, his hands still around Phainon's shoulder, refusing to let go. "I mean, I can be Phai's fake boyfriend whenever you're becoming Robin's. Oooh, Alibi, y'know? Hey, Aventurine, isn't that genius?"

Phainon whipped his head to the other side of the room where Hephaestion called out to, and true enough, as the Producer's seat swiveled to face them, Phainon saw Aventurine sitting there like he owned the place. He was wearing brown pants and a teal shirt this time, with the sleeves rolled up and the fit complementing his posture perfectly; the downturned heart shape on the top button gave a peek of his pale, smooth skin, making him look almost comically slick, like a boss in a child's game. He was also wearing a lopsided smile that was sending chills down Phainon's spine.

"Now, let's not complicate the situation, Hepy. You have thousands of boys and girls who think you're single and always ready to mingle. We wouldn't want to break their hearts," he chuckled with easy confidence. "And hello again, *Phainon*. You look so handsome when you're not wearing a tacky tourist shirt."

Right. Leave it to Aventurine to make him feel self-conscious in mere seconds.

"Tacky? That's rich, coming from someone wearing a shirt with a heart-shaped hole on the collar," a man with dark blue hair suddenly appeared from the other room, his brows furrowed, but he nodded in Phainon and Mydei's general direction, acknowledging them.

"Didn't hear you complain this morning when you helped button it up." Aventurine gave the man the sleaziest grin that Phainon had ever seen in public, and he had to avert his eyes so as not to be voyeuristic. "Phainon, meet Dr. Veritas Ratio, Robin's producer and my fiancé. Veritas, that's Phainon. Mydeimos' *private* partner," he glanced at Phainon as he said the last part. "The man whom we all owe gratitude for, because all of this production will not happen without the consent that flows from his generous and big, beautiful heart."

Phainon could feel Hephaestion grinning, and some of the production guys were chuckling with Aventurine. Phainon smiled politely, though he felt that the joke was off. It wasn't supposed to be a big deal—at least not like Aventurine made it sound. Phainon was just allowing Mydei to do what he must have wanted.

“And hello, rockstar. Nice shoes you got there. It’s inspiring, truly. Cherry red will always be a *bomb*,” Aventurine grinned at Mydei, to Phainon’s relief. He really didn’t want to be under Aventurine’s gaze one second longer.

“Oh, are Mydei and Mister Phainon here?” Robin’s angelic voice was suddenly heard from across the room. When their eyes met, Robin’s smile turned brighter. “Hiiii, Mister Phainon! It’s really lovely to see you again!”

She walked over and opened her arms for a hug. Hephaestion, to his credit, let go of Phainon’s shoulders just in time and retreated to his stool, where he had sat earlier.

“Hi Robin, as I said, just Phainon is fine,” Phainon said, chuckling and returning Robin’s hug with an awkward one. His hand half-hovered on her back; his brain was slightly distracted by Robin’s flowery, powdery perfume. He didn’t even register how his hug felt before Robin released him.

“Come here, come here,” Robin held his hand and guided him to the empty loveseat cushion. “I’ve been looking forward to seeing you again! Mydei said that you may visit on your day off. How’s Rivet Town? Have they finally made a golden version of their mascot?”

“Yeah, sorry it’s overdue. I had an unexpected schedule,” Phainon said. “Wait, you know about the mascot?”

“I do! It’s so cute!”

Mydei groaned exasperatedly, to Robin’s delight. They gushed over the Rivet Town Garbage Can mascot for a while, then Phainon asked how Robin’s week was, to which she responded by recounting her week with Mydei. She echoed the same excitement he’d seen from Mydei that morning over breakfast. Her head wings wiggled a little, an enthusiasm that was impossible to fake. Mydei grabbed a rolling chair and sat next to Phainon, contributing to the conversation here and there.

But Phainon didn’t pay that much attention. He was far too distracted by their shoulders that almost brushed as they were so close. He wanted to lean on him, but knew that Aventurine would have his head if he did something like that. So he kept his distance, folding his attention back toward Robin.

She was in the middle of talking about Mydei’s quick vocal lesson for rock music when Phainon zoned out, baffled by the fact that he was being so casual with the very figure he had always seen on television since he was at school. Her enthusiasm when talking about Queen Gorgo reminded Phainon of the interviews he watched, about how Robin had always loved Mydei and Sons of Gorgo. It must be a dream come true for her to finally have the chance to channel that inspiration, alongside the very man she has admired forever.

It’s so adorable, and Phainon was so, so happy for her.

He couldn’t help but smile along with her, joining her in her excitement as he asked the right things, what she felt about the unreleased sampler that Mydei took from Queen Gorgo’s archive. She had nothing but the highest praise, spoken with a dreamy sigh and starry-eyed.

Phainon nudged Mydei’s shoulder like a proud parent. *Proud boyfriend*.

Mydei only scoffed, brushing it off with practiced cool, as usual.

I love you, Phainon thought to himself, wishing so desperately he could say it openly to Mydei. But not now, not in this room. But Phainon thought about it anyway, held onto it like a prayer. *I love you and your brilliant mind and your beautiful talent and your gorgeous soul. I love you.*

“... My point is, I’m so happy we are allowed to have this chance,” Robin sighed happily, staring at Mydei with that dreamy look in her eyes. “I really love every moment I spend with Mydei. He’s so lovely.”

Yeah, *lovely*. That’s what Phainon just thought, too.

He swallowed, feeling a bit weirded out that Robin could echo his thoughts in that beautiful voice of hers, chanting the mantra he spoke in his mind.

His mind didn’t linger, though. He was distracted by Anaxa’s arrival at the studio, with Hyacine in tow. Then, there was Reca, the man who had shot multiple music videos and album visual concepts for Sons of Gorgo. Then there’s Sunday with a gruff man who might be his bodyguard.

When everyone finally arrived at the studio, and Ratio started the briefing about the album, Phainon finally realized that the room was filled with big names in the entertainment industry —the ones who won awards on an annual basis, the ones whose profiles were written about in Peekypedia, along with the lists of their infamous works, awards, philanthropy, and controversy stories.

While Phainon was just… well, *Phainon*.

The only input he could give was probably just a “sounds cool”.

Phainon clamped his mouth shut, feeling a little bit self-conscious. He was, by no means, a shy person. Phainon took pride in being confident. He would not shake in the face of someone important (except if he really liked them and they’re very pretty, like Robin, or if they’re small and menacing, like Aventurine).

But looking around the room now, he felt just a little out of place.

He probably should’ve just dropped Mydei off and gone home.

But now he was seated, tucked in, and far too deep inside the room to leave. He’d have to sit through it.

The tracks began to play.

The first and second ones he’d already heard, but now polished with Mydei’s voice layered into the verses. Robin’s vocals had changed since the demo—more grit, sharper edges. She carried a hint of Queen Gorgo's influence in her tone now, but still sounded wholly herself.

The room looked stunned, as if they did not believe Robin had that kind of range.

Maybe they hadn’t expected her to deliver like that.

Or maybe they had—and were still blown away anyway.

The room barely had the time to breathe when the third track played.

It opened with an explosive guitar and drum, echoed in the studio like a clap of thunder. Mydei’s low, raw voice opened the song, followed by Robin’s voice soaring like a war cry. They were completing each verse together, as if they were answering each other’s call as they climbed toward each other from opposite cliffs. Queen Gorgo’s original track was playing in the backtrack, along with her. The raw, outdated quality didn’t clash—it enriched the sound, as if she were an ethereal presence guiding them. A mother’s voice in the bones of the song. The passing of a torch, now complete.

When their voices finally collided in the chorus, it was electric—a perfect blend of opposing forces that created the perfect harmony.

Yin and Yang. Dark and light. The howl of the wind and the mighty thunder.

The sound of two stars colliding into a *starburst*.

Phainon was stunned.

The song… literally blows him away.

And clearly, he was not the only one. The rest of the room was smiling as they had just struck gold. Maybe they were. Phainon could imagine how much Aventurine could milk every last bit of credits from this song alone. Ratio smiled smugly, his expression looking uncannily like Aventurine in that moment. Anaxa looked *absolutely* thrilled, like he’d just won a lottery. Which, in a way, he had. The man *loved* rock, and he adored Queen Gorgo. Of course, he would be so excited. It might be the moment he had waited for in his career; the very reason he signed Mydei and the Sons of Gorgo.

When Phainon turned to Mydei, however, he froze.

Mydei was *beaming*. Not the satisfied smile, not the open grin, it's nothing that Phainon had ever witnessed on him before. He was completely unguarded, probably too happy to hide his proud, longing, joyful, radiant smile. He was proud of himself. He missed his mom. He just saw a piece of his mother after so long. He was happy that this song could finally see the light of day.

His face was painted with so many open emotions that Phainon had never witnessed before. He did not even bother to hide them. It was the very first time Mydei had been completely honest in his expression, like he was relieved that this song could finally see the light of day—

Like he finally found the reason he pursued music at all.

Mydei was *happy*.

He was so, *so* happy.

His grin was so childlike that Phainon swore for a second he was seeing the nine-year-old version of himself—the boy who once dreamed of making music with his mother.

Phainon had never seen so many expressions on Mydei's face. Not like this. Not all at once.

He'd thought he knew Mydei. *Knew him fully.* But now, in the face of his mother's song that had been buried for more than a decade, mastered to perfection with Robin's voice filling the blank parts, Phainon realized he'd been wrong.

He hadn't met the whole Mydei, after all.

And he was glad. *Kephale, Mnestia, all the Titans and Aeons in the Skies and Beyond,* he was so, so *glad*. To witness this. To be here. To see the piece of Mydei that perhaps even Mydei didn't know was there. And he felt like he had fallen in love again with Mydei. His heart went rabid like the first time he realized he was in love with him.

Phainon couldn’t help but smile with him.

His hand found Mydei’s, and the blonde was holding him so tightly, as if he‘d flown to the stratosphere if he did not find something to keep him to the ground.

When Perdikkas’ drum finally closed the song, Ratio hit the pause button, allowing the remnants of the music to slowly fade into the silence, as he knew that after something like *that*, they all needed a room to breathe.

“Great call, Babe,” Aventurine said, smiling. “I do think we all need a break after that masterpiece. Because holy shit, guys,” he clapped his hands excitedly. “We’re all going to be richer by millions when this campaign ends, I promise you.”

“Mydeimos Gorgo, ladies and gentlemen,” Robin suddenly rose to her feet, clapping along with Aventurine, her wide smile mirroring Mydei’s.

And, as if following her cue, the room erupted in applause.

Mydei stood and returned it with a grin. “Robin Gopherwood!” he called back, and the cheers only grew louder.

Phainon tilted his head, smiling as Mydei and Robin stood on either side of him, their laughter and applause rising like a tide.

The world belonged to them now—the stars from opposite corners of the galaxy, colliding in the most harmonious way.

And Phainon was lucky to drift close, to linger in the shadow of their radiant light.

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The fourth and final tracks were definitely made for Robin. They leaned into a more pop sound, laced with that early punk-electronic edge from Sons of Gorgo's first albums. The last track, *"Goddess*," was catchy, upbeat, and easy to dance to. It was radio-ready—a clear single meant to go viral. A complete balance to Mydei's rock influence in the first two songs, and after the peak of the *Blow Me Away* track.

As the team reviewed the final master, Peucesta suggested a few minor tweaks, which Anaxa quickly approved. They returned to the mixing booth alongside Perdikkas, Hephaestion, and Ratio, while Aventurine held Mydei and Robin back to sit with him and Mr. Reca and discuss video concepts for *Blow Me Away* and *Goddess*.

While the room settled back into its professional rhythm, Phainon was happily distracted by a bowl of edamame the studio had provided. He was only half-listening to the music video discussion, knowing full well that he was not a part of that world. But he caught that Reca's assistant, Gerald, had a topline concept: Mydei as an immortal warrior in full Ancient Greek God regalia. With golden armor on his feet and arms, red drapes in the color of the blood, a nod to Queen Gorgo's signature color, and he would be bare-chested. To show his *raw strength*.

It sounded cool. Phainon was *very* invested in that visual. He was humming happily as he reached for more edamame, his mind filled with the image of bare-chested Mydei, framed by the regal scarlet and gold colors that accentuated his tattoo. *That* was definitely going into his fantasies. Phainon was already wondering if Mydei could keep the costume. Perhaps that could… *spice up* their weekends. Phainon could worship him all night.

However, his fantasy was interrupted abruptly as he heard Robin's part.

Robin would be styled in an angelic gown, locked in a shimmering prison — a metaphor for her Dollywood years. Throughout the first and second verse, Mydei would come to her cage and set her free, and by the final chorus, Robin would unleash her *feminine power* (whatever that means in that context), and they would emerge as the rock royalty.

Yeah, strange.

“What’s so empowering about locking her up and being set free by a strong, muscular man?” Phainon hummed to himself, munching the last of the beans in the bowl on his lap. “Sounds just like another Clockie Studios cartoon plot to me.”

Phainon did not notice the silence until a loud, deliberate *ahem* was heard.

He looked up from his bowl to find everyone staring at him. Mydei stifled a laugh, while Robin gave him a smile that looked suspiciously like gratitude.

Oh, shit.

“... I just said that out loud, didn’t I?” Phainon asked. A blush crept to his cheeks. “Sorry. I mean, it’s a cool idea. Just… kinda goes against the whole ‘empowering femininity’ angle that Queen Gorgo always carry, don’t you think?”

“Do *you* have a better idea?” Gerald narrowed his eyes, looking offended.

“Gerald, hold it, I think he has a good point,” Reca interrupted. “I mean, this guy right here sees through the lens of the crowd. If he translates the idea this way, most people will likely think the same. Maybe we should just brainstorm through a couple…”

“Fuck it,” Mydei said as he leaned back into the couch with the kind of casual finality only he could pull off. “Throw *me* in the damn cage. You want to show her power? Give her the power to break an undying Greek warrior out of prison.”

Aventurine’s brows lifted. A sly smile curled at the edge of his lips, the kind that usually preceded a PR coup or a scandal. “You sure you’re okay playing the damsel?” he asked. “The man in chains? The one being saved?”

Mydei scoffed, looking amused. “What’s the big deal? My entire career is built on a woman’s legacy. People already call me Mama’s boy, anyway. Why not let another strong woman save me again? Let her unlock the door. Let her rescue the war god. Show how her power *blows them away*.”

Mydei glanced across the room, smiling at Robin. She gently returned his smile. Deep, steady. Grateful. Maybe even a little surprised. There was a sparkle in her eyes that looked like… *admiration*.

The glances that Robin and Mydei shared looked too knowing, *too private*, that Phainon had to look away, focusing his eyes back on the half-finished beans in his lap. He did not know why he did that. It was just the look of partners in crime; two people who had spent the last week together, supporting each other, and probably were as close as siblings by now.

Probably.

Except Robin had admired Mydei *for years* now.

Phainon decided to mute the rest of the meeting, ignoring it by grabbing his phone and checking the work group chat. When Leonnius and Ptolemy excused themselves for a smoke break, Phainon decided to come along.

“Why?” Mydei asked. “You don’t smoke.”

“Just wanted to catch up with Lemy,” Phainon said as he patted Ptolemy’s shoulder. “We hadn’t seen each other for a long time now.”

Mydei nodded and was pulled back to whatever conversation that Aventurine had while Phainon walked outside the studio with Leonnius, snickering as he playfully punched his shoulder.

“You just want to escape that room after that thing with Gerald,” Leonnius called him on his bullshit as they got out of the room.

“Can you blame him? That’s awkward as hell,” Ptolemy laughed. “You never changed, huh, country boy?”

Phainon chuckled, grateful they were teasing him for his awkwardness, not his discomfort. He sat by the fence of the studio’s porch while the others complained about their packed schedules. As the breeze settled around them, Phainon started thinking maybe it was time to head home. The

listening party was over. Mydei had only invited him for that. Phainon didn’t need to stay for the rest of the day.

He stood, just about to head back in to excuse himself, when the studio door swung open. Mydei and Robin emerged from the door, which promptly brought a smile to Phainon’s lips. He was just about to greet them…

When he saw Robin’s shoes.

It’s *Cherry Red* Mary Jane—the exact same color as Mydei’s boots.

The boots that Phainon gifted him for Valentine’s Day years ago. The same color as the low-ankle boots he had at home, which Mydei had gifted him for White Day.

He pressed his lips and almost instantly realized what it meant.

“You’re uh… going to lunch together? For the paparazzi, I suppose?” he asked, deciding to shift his question into a safer territory.

“Yes, another paparazzi spotting,” Robin said brightly. “Mister Aventurine got me these just now, he said it’ll be good for the narrative if we match our shoes. Isn’t it cute?”

“It is,” Phainon said. He was smiling, but his mouth was dry, for some reason. “Cherry red looks totally cute on you. I bet the internet would eat it up.”

“Oh, they better,” Aventurine materialized like a smug genie from behind Mydei. “Because I’m placing a delightful little bet with Skott over these. I said: 'Get me one pair in this exact shade of red, and if I make it go viral and it sells out in under 24 hours, he owes me a million-credit contract.' If not?” He grinned. “I’ll pay for the shoes twenty times the market price. Sounds good, huh?”

Mydei sighed. “It’s for another *teaser*,” Mydei rolled his eyes, deciding to ignore Aventurine and pointing at the feather pendant hanging on his chain

necklace. “We’re going to get a hot dog at that popular spot by the beach. You want something? I could buy it for you.”

Of course you’re not invited, Phainon scolds himself mentally. *It’s going to risk breaking the ruse if you do.*

“No, it’s fine, ‘Dei, I’ll just go back home,” he said. “I need a nap, anyway. Still pretty exhausted from the long work week. I’ll see you soon, yeah?”

“Yeah, sure,” Mydei replied. A weak smile on his lips revealed that Phainon was a little disappointed. But without Mydei around, it would be hella awkward for him to be in this place. He would look even more out of place. “Take care. I’ll see you soon…”

…*Love you*, Phainon finished Mydei’s words silently in his mind. He only let out his biggest grin, waving Robin goodbye, and then walked to his car.

He should not have come to the studio. He should have stayed home, because then, in the privacy of their own home, they could part ways more properly. Phainon covered his mouth with his balled fingers, pressing his lips to his thumb and index fingers’ knuckles, mimicking the usual butterfly kisses he always gave Mydei before they parted ways.

He couldn’t even kiss Mydei goodbye now.

-

His drive back home was quiet, with only the occasional song from the radio playing. Phainon could feel his heart a little bit heavy, but he took a couple of deep breaths, reminding himself that this was a part of dating a celebrity. He knew what he was signing up for when he made the move to Mydei all those years ago. Mydei had always been kind enough to tell him everything about his job and to shield him from the media's negative aspects.

Mydei had always been so kind to him.

And Phainon should not be selfish. Not now. Not over damn shoes.

Why did he make a fuss about it, anyway? It shouldn’t matter that much. Phainon hadn’t even had a chance to wear those shoes these past months, so it wasn’t exactly *their thing*.

And besides, it’s just a ruse.

A story that Aventurine arranged to make some profit.

Robin wore it because it was part of the act. It was part of the music's advertising. Just like the pendant that Mydei wore. It was just symbolism to sell the narrative—*the music*.

The music that Mydei loved so much. The music that got him smiling like a little boy. The music that was his legacy, inherited by the mother who loved Mydei so much. The music that was his lifelong dream.

It was all just a big orchestra.

Nothing about it was true aside from their passion for the music they produced.

So it wasn’t supposed to be a big deal.

As Phainon parked his car in his apartment building, his phone rang suddenly, startling him. He grabbed it from the passenger seat… only to see Cyrene’s name on the screen.

Wait, *Cyrene…* called?

Now, his older sister was never one to call before texting first. Cy was never big on phone calls, even more so since he worked as a pilot, knowing there was a good chance her call couldn’t get through. For her to call without even a notice…

This might be an urgent matter.

Phainon quickly slid the button on his screen. “Hi, Cy,” he greeted.

“Hey, Phai,” she answered. Her voice was calm, almost *too* quiet. She paused for another second before she continued. “Uh, where are you?”

“Home,” Phainon replied. “I’m off duty today. But I just got back from driving Mydei to Anaxa’s studio. What’s up? Are you okay? Is Mom and Dad okay?”

“I’m okay. Mom and Dad’s fine too,” Cyrene said. “I just wanted to check on you. Are *you* okay?”

“Uh, yeah?” Phainon stared at the wall in front of him. “I’m fine.”

There was a beat of heavy silence, like Cyrene was thinking about something but deliberately chose not to say it out loud, as if she were waiting for Phainon to talk about it first.

Except that Phainon did not know what he was supposed to talk to her about.

“Cy? You there?”

“Phai,” Cyrene started, apparently not having the patience to gauge it from him now. “Is everything okay with you and Mydei?”

Phainon could feel his breath hitched.

Of course.

Of course, the news would reach her. Of course, she would ask about it.

And worst of all, Phainon did not know what to say about this whole fake-relationship thing. It was meant to make it look like Mydei and Robin were dating, and Phainon was told directly not to tell a single soul about it. *Not even siblings*, Aventurine had said. Phainon closed his eyes, mouthing curses to himself before he answered.

“Yeah, definitely,” Phainon said. “We’re good. He cooked me breakfast as usual. Like I said, I just drove him to the studio. Why do you ask?”

“Hmm, the studio,” Cyrene hummed. “He’s recording new songs?”

“Yeah, he has this upcoming collaboration with Robin. But you can’t tell anyone that, Cy. I think Mydei wanted to keep it a secret for now,” Phainon said. “They uh… they had been recording for the whole week, I guess? Mydei’s been so excited about it.”

“I see,” Cyrene said quietly. “But you two are doing well, right?”

“Totally,” Phainon answered, and Cyrene’s cryptic answer somehow made his chest feel even more pained. He bit his lower lip. “Why are you asking, Cyrene? Is there anything I should be worried about?”

“No, no, of course not,” Cyrene said. “It’s just… I’ve been watching CMZ, and I was wondering if you have something you haven’t told me yet.”

Phainon could feel his heart fall to his knees. Oh no, Cyrene and her perceptive eyes. Aventurine’s words about keeping the entire scenario from the outside party rang in his mind, making his heart pound faster. Phainon was thankful that this was not a video call. Cyrene would be able to call on his bullshit if it were.

“What? Nothing,” he chuckled. “Everything is okay in the Mydei-Phai household, I promise. Do you want the details of our makeout session, too?”

“Phainon!” Cyrene hissed. “You haven’t seen the latest news? The one that just got out now?”

“What? No! I’m driving. I don’t drive and scroll!” Phainon said. “What happened?”

“Mydei is with Robin, and…”

“And I know that! It’s not the first time Mydei has collaborated with a female singer. They’re probably just hanging out together as buddies.

Nothing to worry about."

"They wear matching shoes," Cyrene said, sounding impatient with Phainon's dismissal. "Mydei was wearing *your* shoes. And he matched it with Robin. They call them a new pair. *A couple*. Do you know about this?"

Yes, he knew. And he had been sulking about it for the previous twenty minutes. But he couldn't tell Cyrene that.

"Ah, it's probably nothing," Phainon said with a weak chuckle. "Robin's stylist probably saw Mydei wear it one day and decided it would look good on her? It's probably just a coincidence. It's…"

"Phainon!" Cyrene said this more sternly this time. "They're on a date! Take a look at the paparazzi photos I sent you just now! There's no way nothing's going on between them!"

Phainon sighed. He pressed the bridge of his nose with his fingers, feeling like he was going to combust.

"Cyrene, calm down," he said. "We're fine, okay? Nothing to worry about. If something's going on between us, you'll be the first to know. Don't worry."

There was another stretch of silence from the other side of the line. "Fine, if you say so," Cyrene finally relented. "I'm glad to hear that. But if something *does* happen, please tell me, okay, Phai? You don't have to go through it alone."

"Sure," Phainon said. "Thanks for checking up on me."

"Anytime. And come home when you have time, okay, city boy? Mom said she misses you so much."

Phainon could feel his lips curve into a smile. "I miss you guys so much, too."

Cyrene hung up the phone, and Phainon had to take a couple more breaths before he could bring himself out of the car.

He idly scrolled through social media on his way to their shared penthouse and saw that #LionDove was trending. He pursed his lips, weighing whether he had to click on the tag, considering his feelings from this morning. Maybe he should just let it be. Maybe he should just distract himself with something instead.

But curiosity had taken the better of him.

He clicked the tag anyway.

The timeline was filled with Mydei and Robin's photo at the hot dog joint near the Bastion Beach. Robin's hair was tied into a high bun, and she was wearing an oversized red flannel, which Phainon did not know she had. She did not bring that when they said goodbye a few minutes ago. The stylist must have given the finishing touch on their way there. She was holding a corn dog, which, in one photo, she offered to Mydei.

In the other photo, Mydei bit the hot dog, and they laughed at each other as she wiped the sauce from the corner of his lips.

The caption of that particular photo, however, was what got Phainon.

- ***@TimelyLionDove IN PRIVATE SHE'S WIPING THAT DAMN SAUCE WITH HER LIPS I JUST KNEW THAT. TRUST ME I AM THAT FEATHER PENDANT ON MYDEI'S NECK.***

- @mydeisguitarcase No please where do we get cherry red mary jane?? Hello???

- @Gopherwilds was at the mall when i saw the image. People rushed to Dr. Markenz. Cherry red color sold out in golden hour don't even bother coming.

- @3amsimps It's sold out online too T.T damn I was gonna buy a matching pair with my bf damn why people are moving so fast. T.T

- **@TimelyClockieDove** they’re in love, Your Honor. And we’re so lucky to witness this.
- @Nymphsss It’s the most beautiful hot dog date I’ve ever seen. I’m so glad they’re together, these photos cure my depression <3.

He took a deep breath as he entered his house and glanced at his shoe cabinet. His own pair of Cherry Red looked lonely there, just as he was now. He closed his eyes, taking another deep breath as he tried to recall Mydei’s face this morning when Blow Me Away played. His child-like joy, his brightest grin…

He smiled to himself.

If he could see those expressions on Mydei’s face again, it’s worth going through. He would endure this happily for months. Years. Lifetimes, if he must.

As long as he could keep seeing Mydei smiling like that, he would endure everything.

Even if he had to brave the loud noise of the whole world.

-

Chapter End Notes

thank you for reading!! As always I would be shamelessly put my X account here @mydaymousee
Just in case someone wants to yell at me hehe :D

Chapter 4: Glass Walls

Chapter Summary

> As the world falls in love with Robin and Mydei's picture-perfect Dollywood Royalty Couple, Phainon wrestles with that strange, silly feeling in his chest

Chapter Notes

> Hi hello! I can't believe I write this much for a week T.T the hold Phaidei had on me was very lethal. call the police >.<
>
> Also, a few warnings before you read this:
> 1. SLIGHT MYPHAI in this chapter (right at the last part of the fic after the jacuzzi!). I always love Phaidei more, but I'm also a sucker for a switch myphai / phaidei. But it's so slight and not explicit (I lost my ability to write smut lol)
> 2. This has a slight DanCae mention and even a slighter mention of RenHeng. I love and respect both ships so so much so I hope you're okay with it!
> 3. I made Cae and Stelle Phainon's childhood friends from Aedes Elysiae in this part!
>
> Anyways, as always, I hope you enjoy this!
>
> Edit: there's also an art of Mydei with Phai's choker now by my girl noriiko! please send help cause it's so good im dead T.T > https://x.com/noriiko_uwu/status/1958775033800925686

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Happily.

Right.

Phainon had to focus on that part instead. Mydeimos Gorgo, the love of his life, the man who made mornings bearable, the person Phainon had always imagined spending the rest of his life with, was having a good time. He looked alive, radiant, and in his element. Robin Gopherwood, the celebrity Phainon had loved since middle school—the girl he had grown up watching on TV, whose music had filled Phainon's teenage years, serving as a soundtrack to his best high school memories—was living her dream.

The two people Phainon cared about were having the time of their lives, a pivotal moment in their careers and their lives.

So he should be happy about that, rather than reading about the random noises people wrote about on social media, because they could only assume. They ate everything Aventurine was baiting them, nothing more. They knew nothing about Mydei or Robin.

Phainon knew *everything*.

So he should focus on what's important: Their smiles, the fun they were having, the music they were making.

A pair of shoes was nothing in comparison.

Okay, now he could just have fun watching the campaign unfold, note down whatever crazy theories they came up with online, and recap them to laugh with Mydei later.

Yep. Sounds like a plan.

Phainon reheated the Pad Thai Mydei had bought him while humming a song from Robin's latest album, then sat on the stool in the kitchen, scrolling through the hashtag as he ate. It continued to grow in volume, and not even just a typical fangirl scream in all caps or a keyboard smash this time. There were even complete analyses of their choice of wardrobe down to the smallest accessory, a few more fan edits on how "in love" they are, and there's even a video of a woman who claimed to be a body language analyst, talking about how *genuinely obsessed* they are with each other.

Phainon scoffed. But out of curiosity, he played the video.

The woman looked mature. In her early thirties, if Phainon could guess. She wore platinum-framed glasses, red lipstick, and a well-tailored outfit that appeared to be designer. She looked legit. Like she knew what she was talking about.

“Now, watch this,” she said, tapping her screen to freeze a shot of Robin looking up at Mydei. “Robin’s eyes here look wide, soft, and unblinking. She’s not just happy; she’s invested. This is a young girl experiencing first love. And that open laugh. It’s nothing like Robin had ever done in public before.

Wow, okay. So there’s someone out there who spends the time to analyze a celebrity’s smile, after all. Good to know.

She then switched the screen to show a photo of Mydei.

“Now, Mydei might not be there yet. Like, maybe he likes her, but not quite in love. *But he’s getting there. Because… look, what’s interesting about his gesture is… the shoulder shielding. The second he spots the paparazzi, his arm automatically comes around her. That’s a protective move. You can’t fake that instinct. This man* cares about her.*”*

Yeah, of course he did. That’s what Mydei would do to Phainon, too, whenever he felt that Phainon was feeling uneasy. The kind of thing he did without thinking. Just purely from his genuine feeling.

No, wait a minute.

That wasn’t necessarily an act of love. That was Mydei caring for his coworkers, his bandmates, his fans—*anyone*. The analyst knew nothing about that. She was simply stringing together coincidence with confidence. Phainon scoffed, forcing the lump in his throat down with Pad Thai.

“Then we have the gravity lean. It’s subtle, but his torso angles toward her whenever she speaks. That’s admiration in motion. And finally, the smile… small, soft, gentle. That’s different from The Mydeimos’ Smile, *which was*

usually a cocky grin. That small smile was a genuine sign. The dawn of adoration. He's starting to fall for her."

Phainon could feel his lips curve into an amused smile.

Wrong.

That smile —the little curve, the gentleness in his golden honey eyes, *that* wasn't adoration. That was Mydei looking at a Samoyed, or a story about a garbage can mascot.

Mydei's *real* look of adoration was half-lidded golden eyes clouded in a mist of desire, face completely relaxed, but with his brows furrowed a little, like he couldn't believe how he could even *love*.

The same look that he showed Phainon every morning when he woke up next to him. When he pressed against Phainon, making a show of last-minute resistance before he actually let Phainon go to work.

Yeah, none of them knew Mydei at all.

Phainon continued to watch the video. Now she was talking about the shoes; how Mydei's were scuffed, while Robin's pair looked new. She at least did her homework, saying that Cherry Red color had always been Mydei's signature since his debut. He wore those shoes almost everywhere, and it's likely that Robin's complete smittenness with him led her to match his aesthetic. Or, and this was a much higher possibility, that Mydei was giving it to her as a possessive sign.

Possessive sign.

Hah. At least she's correct about one thing. Mydei was indeed a possessive man.

"Seems like you're not as mysterious as you make yourself to be, 'Dei," Phainon hummed to himself, only half-amused because he was fixated with more images of his boyfriend staring at the pop stars with emojis

surrounding them, more theories, and then on a post that discussed why Robin / Mydei were not suitable for each other; clearly a Mydei-hater post.

Phainon found himself frowning when he realized that he lingered longer on these kinds of posts, feeling somewhat offended by how some people thought Mydei was not good enough for Robin, yet also confused about why he was rooting for *his boyfriend* to be with Robin.

He caught himself halfway through typing about why Mydei deserved Robin, realizing that he had almost gotten sucked into the stage that Aventurine set. Mydei was *his*. He wasn't supposed to be Robin's, and those haters' posts were right. They were not a good match, because Mydei prefers men. Robin was just a fan of his work, and he did not have to defend Mydei and Robin's relationship because *it was not true.*

He shook his head, scrapping his draft and moving on to the next post. But the more Phainon scrolled, the tag continued to grow as Phainon read into one thread that discussed why Robin/Mydei's relationship might fail, the tag increased into 1,000 new posts, 1,500, 3,000… 3,355…

Now, there were even more new trending words under the #LionDove tag. It's the #CherryBombCouple, Dr. Markenz, Cherry Red.

Oh, by Kephale.

That acid in the pit of his stomach kicked back in.

Phainon groaned. He hated how the mention of the shoes still troubled him, despite his best efforts not to think about it.

Phainon put his phone down and closed his eyes, because *he knew* he should stop. He should steer clear of social media before it consumes him, because *none of those were real*. It was just Aventurine's big circus. He knew that. He even knew that Aventurine would improvise along the way, adding a new twist based on the audience's response online.

Except that he never thought that the improvisation that Aventurine created just touched something very personal to him.

Phainon wondered if Aventurine knew that.

Or Mydei… Did he even remember how much those shoes meant to Phainon?

We can't always control the output, Mydei had warned him a week ago.

And Phainon had assured him that everything would be okay.

Well, it *was* okay.

He was just caught off guard, that's all.

Right, well, again, it was *just shoes*. What they had now was far more meaningful than that. Heck, he could overwrite the meanings of those shoes! Maybe get a new matching pair in a different color, or even a whole new brand. He could give them to Mydei on their next special occasion. Perhaps the day he proposed. Or their wedding day. Phainon was Mydei's real partner. He could easily propose something new to move past these sentimental knots.

It wasn't a big deal. He could always overwrite it.

Phainon got up from his seat, deciding that since he no longer had the appetite for lunch, he might as well just distract himself by washing the dishes, doing his laundry, or cleaning the house. Anything to keep moving, because sitting with his thoughts proved to be counterproductive.

Still, despite constantly convincing himself that he was okay, the uncomfortable feeling stubbornly sat in the pit of his stomach, tugging his heart deeper with each passing second. He kept glancing at his shoe cabinet, staring at his own pair of Cherry Red shoes. Mydei gave them on White Day in the same year Phainon gave him the boots, and Phainon had teased him to no end, calling him for not being creative, et cetera, et cetera.

But Mydei said, in a flat, serious tone, that he gave him those pairs because he wanted something to match him; a fashion statement to mark them as a couple.

Phainon remembered how that answer had caught him so off-guard, his laugh stalling halfway as he was flustered terribly. Mydei had laughed then, kissing his “Phainon.exe stopped working” face to sober him up, and spent the rest of the week teasing Phainon about it.

But he wore the shoes all week, that bastard. Prompting Phainon to do the same, and got scolded by the airline for coming into work with that.

Phainon scoffed.

Yeah, *a possessive man*, indeed.

Phainon glanced at the shoes again. They were still clean and as good as new, not worn out or lived-in from use. He couldn’t wear them to work for obvious reasons, and he had so few occasions to wear them anywhere else. They rarely went out on their free days, deciding to spend what little time they had together in each other’s presence at home.

Maybe he should propose a vacation together somewhere, when Mydei’s summer tour ends.

Yeah, it’s been too long since they were out for vacation together.

His musings were interrupted by a ping of a message; the ringtone he reserved for Mydei. Phainon hesitantly opened the message, only to see a picture of a fluffy white cotton candy with a happy dog face staring back at him, with Robin’s cute duck face just next to it.

My Day Mouse <3
You and your favorite singer together.

Phainon snorted. He zoomed in on the picture, looking at how Robin’s face was a bit of a blur, while the cotton candy was crisp and crystal clear. It’s just so Mydei. He could be in the most beautiful place in the world, or be with the most beautiful woman who ever lived, and yet his focus would be on a damn cotton candy.

Phainon snapped a photo of the vacuum cleaner he just used to reply to Mydei's message, but as he typed his text, Phainon paused to stare at the image.

It felt dull, somehow.

Boring.

So pale compared to Mydei's life of Cherry-Red shoes, pastel-colored cotton candy, and the sparkling pop stars and Dollywood glamour surrounding him.

He discarded the picture and just sent the text instead.

You
Close, but my favorite singer is still Mydeimos Gorgo (˘ ³˘)♥
Also, say hi to Robin for me.
(Wow, so casually to The RobinTM. Cant believe this is my life now)

My Day Mouse <3
Fuckin dork.
She said lets hangout smtm.
G2g. Dnt forget to eat well.
HKS.

You
Take care.
But
Where is
My kisses? (@﹏@`。)

My Day Mouse <3
(•◡•) ⊂∩⊃♥
DO NOT reheat the Pad Thai it prob gone bad.
Nvm u probably ate it alrd.

"Too bad you're not here to stop me, *Mydeimos*," Phainon said out loud to the hollow of his house, deciding not to type that because had Mydei known

that he indeed ate the Pad Thai, Phainon would never let him hear the end of it.

But Phainon let his smile linger.

Yeah, he was thinking too much about it.

Since he had nothing else to do around the house, Phainon decided to look for a new pair of shoes online, hoping to find something unique to buy for Mydei. New, unique colors or patterns. Something Mydei could use as his new signature.

However, anytime he types the keyword for “boots”, it’s always followed by Mydei and Robin's related words.

Boots Cherry Red, Boots Dr Markenz Mydei Robin, Boots and Mary Janes Robin, Boots and Loafers Cherry Red. Boots Couple Cherry Red.

Oh, by Kephale.

There’s no escaping them, isn’t there?

Phainon locked his phone out of frustration. But then, it rang again, signaling a new message.

Thankfully, it was Caelus this time.

Wait, why was he thankful that it was Caelus and not Mydei? Ugh, he must be more exhausted than he let on.

Partnurrr #2 (Cae)
S.O.S, Snowy. S.O.S!!

Phainon furrowed his brows. He typed in a “hi!” but before he could type in anything, though, Caelus called him.

“Cae, he…”

“Snowy! Snowy! Are you free?” Caelus whispered. His voice sounded urgent, almost panicky. The use of Phainon’s childhood name alone alarmed him, making him sit straighter.

Caelus hadn’t called him that name since they both moved to Okhema.

“Yeah, I’m free. You okay, buddy?” Phainon replied, his voice thick with worry.

“Ok, great, can you come over?” Caelus whispered. “Danny boy is going insaaaaane!” he continued, with a long, dragged, scandalous voice.

“Danny… wh, Dan Heng? What happened? Why are you calling him Danny?” Phainon asked, getting up from his seat now because it sounded so serious. “I mean, sure, I can come over! Are you okay, though?”

“I’m okay, but…” Caelus hissed. “But please come if you can! This is *Code S*.”

Code S means *Code Strange*. Their old childhood signal for something weird is happening, and you need to *get here now*. Hearing Caelus use it for the first time in years made Phainon’s pulse spike. It’s either an extremely dangerous or abysmally stupid situation. With Caelus, those two categories often overlapped. But Phainon was curious, regardless.

“Alright, alright, I’ll be there soon,” Phainon said, before hanging up the phone. He quickly grabbed his jacket, slipped into his Cherry-Red shoes, and bolted out the door.

As he walked down the hall, he found it strange that he felt relieved to have something to do that was not house chores. Maybe it had something to do with the loneliness in his house, or the silence in his living room that was starting to feel louder than the trending tag ever could.

Or maybe it was just his imagination.

-

When Phainon entered Caelus' house, he was faced by a dimly lit room, curtains almost entirely drawn, lamps partly turned on, and Caelus lying on the couch, a thin blanket draped over his body. There were empty bags of chips, chocolate wrappers, personal-size pizza boxes, and coffee cans around him.

It looked like a hedonistic catastrophe, which was weird, even for Caelus.

"Cae?" Phainon whispered as he slowly entered the house. "Caelus?"

Caelus's head shot up, startling Phainon.

"Snowy!" Caelus jerked, rushing to grab Phainon's shoulders. "You came!"

"Yeah, what happ—"

"Danny's going insane," Caelus whispered urgently. His eyes widened in horror. "He's shutting us in for days! He won't even allow me to open the curtain!"

Phainon's brain racked with something to do, but then, an electronic whirring was heard, and the curtain was drawn up, letting in the bright golden evening sunlight. Caelus shrieked quietly, hiding behind Phainon when Dan Heng walked in from the kitchen, one hand holding a trash bag.

"Caelus, don't rope Phainon into this," Dan Heng deadpanned. He then turned to Phainon, his face looking apologetic, and Phainon instantly knew that this must fall into the *'Abysmally Stupid' category*. "Thanks for coming, Phainon. But I am not going insane. It was all nothing but *Caelus's madness*."

"*Our* madness."

"That was *exclusively your* idea. I was just playing along," Dan Heng said, picking up the empty coffee can from the floor. "Apologize, now!"

“No, Danny boy, *no*. We shouldn’t break the immersion. Especially when we have a 3P that has just joined here!”

Phainon blinked, still trying to catch what kind of Caelus’ antics he had walked in on. His eyes swept over Caelus’ dramatic wide eyes, Dan Heng’s frown, and the snack carnage. “So this is a Code S for…”

Dan Heng glared at Caelus, which was welcomed by a defeated groan.

“Ugh, fine,” he said, letting his hands off Phainon’s shoulders and adjusting his position on the couch. “Sorry to shock you, Phainon. I’m helping Dan Heng with his method acting. Dan’s playing a gamer-stalker role in his next movie. So we came up with the idea to completely shut in to capture the *true essence* of isolation….”

“*Your* idea,” Dan Heng insisted.

“Alright, fine, *my* great idea,” Caelus hissed at Dan Heng. “But it was indeed a Code S! Dan Heng’s actually going insane! He is starting to threaten me into doing something I don’t want!”

Dan Heng let out a long, exasperated sigh. But the tiny curve on the corner of his lips gave away his affection. “You refused to clean up the trash, and you started to rage at the concept of a shower. You’re the one going insane! And this was supposed to be *my* method acting.”

At that, Phainon’s head was thrown back as he burst into a laugh and fell onto the floor. Caelus still pouted, but the ghost of a smile still lingered under that mask, and Dan Heng pressed his lips, clearly trying to suppress his own laughter.

“Oh boy, you guys are dorks,” he said between his laughs. “I can’t believe you rope me into your kinky role play, Cae. Should I walk out now?”

“No! No, please,” Caleus said, rushing into holding Phainon’s leg. “Don’t leave me here with Danny boy alone. He’s gonna drag me into the shower.”

“Honestly, I think you *do* need a shower,” Phainon said, making an exaggerated sniffing gesture. “You’re stinky.”

Dan Heng mouthed a thank you to Caelus’s more dramatic groan. Phainon laughed again. Despite what he said, he’s glad that he actually came. Caelus’s nonsense and watching these dorks in love was definitely what he needed after all of those… *things* he read—a great distraction. Caelus was truly his hero.

“Again, sorry for making you come all the way here, Phainon,” Dan Heng said. “I hope you’re not in the middle of something important.”

“Oh no, that’s no trouble at all,” Phainon laughed, “If anything, I’m glad you called. I was bored at home, and Mydei is not coming back until later tonig…”

“Alright!” Caelus snapped his fingers, almost too excitedly. “If you’re staying, then let’s teach Dan Heng how to beat this boss!”

“Not after you clean up after yourself first!”

Caelus rolled his eyes, and Phainon laughed again, volunteering to help the couple clean up their living room while talking about how their lives have been. Dan Heng tried to stop him, saying that since he’s a guest, he should stay back and enjoy watching Caelus suffer the consequences of his idea. But Phainon insisted, to Caelus’s dramatic thankful stare.

They ended up cleaning the living room together while Caelus talked excitedly about his streaming session, Stelle and March's duo project, Dan Heng’s movie, and absolutely everything and nothing. Caelus was very insistent on listing what their mutual friends had been up to, even Sushang and Guinaifen, whom Phainon was not familiar with.

Dan Heng occasionally chimed in, asking Phainon about his flights, what he had been up to, and about Cyrene. They even asked about Big Snowy, Phainon’s dog back in Aedes Elysiae, but not about Mydei. It was almost as if they were deliberately not asking about him.

Phainon wondered if the current news had anything to do with it.

“Oh, and have I mentioned that Mr. Yang is starting a new party planner business?” Caelus said excitedly. “He’s planning to have a Rock Evernight Party or whatever. It’s gonna be amazing. I think you and Myd…”

“Caelus,” Dan Heng suddenly interrupted him. “Pick up this can, it’s gross. Also, have you told Phainon about that funny thing with Casie? I think it was *hilarious*.”

And he smiled at Caelus in a very pointed way that something clicked in Phainon’s mind.

Yep. Totally on purpose.

“No, please, what was it again about the party?” Phainon asked, smiling. “Is Mydei and I invited? If so, we will try to make the time! I mean, he’s going on tour in a month, but I’m sure he’ll say yes if…”

“Wait, really? I thought Cyrene said you guys were… ow! Dan, the heck?”

Caelus shot a glance at Dan Heng, who was, apparently, just stepping on his foot. Dan Heng returned the glare with the same intensity, giving him the loudest *shut up!* a stare could muster—until he caught Phainon’s knowing smile.

Dan Heng’s expression shifted, the edge dropping into something almost sheepish. He sighed, his expression resigned as he’d just been caught halfway through a poorly thought-out plan, or, like, *embarrassed* on behalf of Caelus.

“I knew it. You guys were so deliberately avoiding asking about Mydei!” Phainon pointed out, letting out a stifled laugh. “Is it why Cae invited me here through Code S? Because Cyrene asked you?”

Caelus flinched, and Dan Heng let out an exasperated sigh, staring at Caelus as if he demanded him to take responsibility. Caelus, in return, gave Dan Heng a puppy eyes, as if he was asking for help.

“We’re very sorry, Phainon,” Dan Heng finally said, clearly losing whatever silent argument he’d been having with Caelus. “Cyrene called us to check up on you. We were going to drop by your place, but… *someone* didn’t want to break our so-called method acting. If I had known sooner that he called you, I would have stopped him.”

“Yeah, sorry I didn’t tell you,” Caelus said, pouting and raising his hands in surrender. “We were worried, you know? And you’re always so quiet when you’re sad. Back when we were kids, you always played pretend in the cave to make yourself feel better, so I thought, why not invite you here? We were building a method acting cave, and you can join us to play pretend, yeah?”

“*Caelus*.”

“No, Dan Heng, please, don’t be mad at Caelus. Honestly, it’s alright, I get it,” Phainon cut Dan Heng’s scolding with a smile. “And I do appreciate it. I was honestly really bored at home, and hanging out with you is exactly what I needed. But you shouldn’t worry about us. Mydei and I are fine. You can’t tell anyone yet, but Mydei and Robin are collaborating on a project. So they’re just… spending time together to work on it. It’s nothing new, right? Mydei spent some time with Misia too, back when she was featured in one of the band’s songs.”

“But Misia did not wear Cherry Red!” Caelus huffed. “Isn’t that… your thing?”

Phainon chuckled, despite the squeeze in his chest. “It’s just shoes, Cae, it’s not that deep,” he said. “It’s probably just a coincidence on Robin’s part, too. Besides, it’s not our exclusive thing or whatever. I haven’t even used mine in forever. Look, still looks good as new.”

Caelus was staring at him as Phainon had just grown another head, while Dan Heng remained neutral, like he was trying to gauge something out of Phainon’s answer.

“Still,” Caelus hummed. “All of that gossip, and you’ve been so quiet. Man, if it were me, at least five of our friends would hear me cry over everything in detail!”

“It happened, trust me,” Dan Heng nodded solemnly.

“Oh, I thought you vent to me, too, back then,” Phainon said, and then, suddenly, something dawned on him.

Wait.

Caelus had actually experienced a similar thing before.

He had been suffering when Dan Heng was also rumored to be dating his castmate.

“Cae, wait, remind me, this was the time when Dan Heng was playing in that High Cloud Quartet movie, right? Dan Heng’s character has um… a complex relationship with that Yingxing character?”

“Yeah, that’s the one!” Caelus replied. “Remember when Dan Heng was asked to be all flirty with Blade during the promotion? Man! Worst days of my life! I mean, Blade’s hot. *Totally hot*. I give him that. Still…”

While Caelus listed the things that distressed him about Dan Heng and Blade's marketing in that movie promotion, Phainon could see Dan Heng observing him. Then, he raised his brows. An understanding dawned in his face so clearly that Phainon could almost see a lightbulb pop up above his head.

Phainon could feel his heart sink. Oh, no. Danny boy, you’re too smart for your own good.

He wasn’t supposed to talk about it. He had promised not to tell a single soul outside of the production circle, too. Aventurine was going to kill him.

But—

But Dan Heng’s an actor. Perhaps he could be considered a part of *the person in the industry*. He was also subjected to a similar marketing ploy. So maybe it’s okay to vent about these things to them? Maybe he could ask Dan Heng for advice on dealing with the noises?

Or maybe not. He promised to keep it a secret.

Phainon sighed, feeling dejected that he couldn't even talk about it with his closest friends. But maybe… It was okay if he deflects the question from himself and asks about their experience instead. Technically, he wouldn't say anything.

Maybe he could try that. Maybe he could at least get some advice to soothe this uneasy feeling that refused to lift off his chest.

"Um, but I don't think I've ever heard the end of that story," he said, slowly, almost unsure.

"About how Caelus overcame the thing about Blade and me?"

Dan Heng's eyes narrowed just slightly, as if catching something in Phainon's expression.

And then he smirked.

He fucking smirked.

Oh, Dan Heng, the beautiful mind of the Amphoreus, The Xianzhou, and across the galaxies above, he must have understood what's implied in Phainon's words. The question that Phainon did not ask.

This wasn't cheating, right?

Phainon did not tell him anything. Dan Heng was just assuming.

A very spot-on assumption based on his own experience.

"Yeah," Phainon said, almost too weak to be heard by his own ears.

Dan Heng nodded. "When Caelus raged, we came up with a quiet signal between us whenever I had to do something overly romantic with Blade or my co-stars in promotions or other events," he said, poking Caelus's cheek to get him to stop talking. "I will always conclude with a laugh and clap twice. It was a safe signal because people would think I was having fun

with the promotion, while only Caelus would see it was just another act for me. It was to… *break the immersion*. To know I think about him all the time."

Caelus nodded. "Oh yeah," he said happily. "That was *my* idea, too."

"A very good idea for once."

"My ideas are *always good*!" Caelus narrowed his eyes.

"So long as it involves taking a shower, I agree," Dan Heng said, back to his annoyed face. "Also, Caelus avoided social media like crazy."

"Yep, best decision ever!" Caelus nodded. "Like, literally did not look at it, cause the fans are crazy. Some of them like to say mean things. So I just go off-grid and enjoy my life with Danny boy outside of his job. I remember one time when this person edited me out of our public pictures, replacing my face with Arlan's. *Arlan*! They were only in one scene together, and Arlan even shot Danny in that scene! How do people even ship that????"

Phainon couldn't help but laugh at Caelus' exaggerated expression. Dan Heng chuckled softly, looking at Caelus in an endearing amusement.

"Yeah, I think it's wise that you build walls around you when dating a public figure," Dan Heng said. He was talking to Caelus, but he leered from the corner of his eyes towards Phainon, as if letting him know that he knew, he saw right through the marketing plot.

Phainon pressed his lips, staring down at his Cherry Red shoes.

Maybe they were right. He should not let public opinion influence his personal views, but rather view them as what they truly are: noise. The real moments, the ones worth keeping, were the ones nobody saw. Those were safe, walled in behind the home they'd built together—a private sanctuary where Mydei was not a rockstar but an incarnation of a very lazy, extremely insatiable big cat that was his alone. That was still untouched. Private. *Theirs*.

And nothing can take that away from them.

It helped. Even if just a little, it helped, he thought to himself. But still, *the problem with walls was that sometimes they had windows. And all it took was one careless glance outside for the whole world to pour in.*

No, that's not impossible. Phainon only needed to close that window. Seal it shut, and just live inside it—like this morning in the studio.

"That's uh…" he paused. "That's cool. Thanks, guys."

"You're welcome," Dan Heng nodded with a smile.

"Yeah, now it's my turn to ask a question," Caelus said, looking very adamant in giving Phainon *the talk*, like an overprotective uncle. "We gotta address that situation of yours before it gets out of hand! You know all about them, right? Mydei's been keeping tabs on what he does? Do you have spies in the band? Someone who's totally on your side! Just in case. I mean, I don't doubt Mydei's love for you or whatever, but there's no harm in being careful."

Dan Heng's eyes narrowed, his amusement quickly changed into a glare that screamed, *"Are you serious right now?"* while Phainon laughed out loud.

"Nah, I don't think I need to go that far, Cae," he said between his laughter. "But yeah, I'll try to keep that in mind."

"No, no, no, listen to me, Snowy!"

Caelus continued to talk, and Phainon listened to it wholeheartedly, and laughed so hard his stomach hurt. Maybe if he laughed long enough, he could forget about that little sting in his heart that still refused to go away, about the crack in his window that still refused to seal shut.

-

Phainon excused himself to go home after Caelus insisted they order Mediterranean food for dinner, to celebrate their reunion after a while, Dan Heng finally beating that boss he had a hard time with, and… Phainon and Mydei's relationship?

Phainon wrinkled his nose. "But I told you we're fine," Phainon said, confused.

"Exactly!" Caelus snapped his fingers, already pressing the buttons to call his favorite Mediterranean restaurant. "That's worth celebrating, don't you think? We can also celebrate my relationship with Dan Heng. We've been together for almost eight years! Man! Time does fly fast like Captain Khaslana."

And so, Phainon resigned to Caelus' whims once again and ordered a Fig Stew while Dan Heng popped a bottle of non-alcoholic wine, like he knew that this was what was going to happen before Phainon even agreed on it. Phainon wondered if he should order one for Mydei, too. It was his favorite food, after all. But he decided against it, knowing that Mydei might come home really late, and since he was staying in Anaxa's studio, he had probably eaten before he left. Anaxa rarely let anyone who entered his studio leave without a full stomach.

When Phainon's back is to the quiet of his own home, it already feels less suffocating. Phainon's mood had improved significantly, and he had a newfound determination not to look up for Robin and Mydei on social media again and mute them.

Still, as the thought came back, the fading bitterness stubbornly stirred in the back of his mind.

The taste of the non-alcoholic wine still lingered in his mouth, and Phainon thought that maybe he could use a little bit of alcohol now that he didn't have to drive.

A bath sounded nice, too.

The wine was a strange craving, honestly. Phainon was never a fan of alcohol, keeping only a few bottles of wine on hand for Mydei's cooking or to welcome guests. But he poured a glass anyway, placing it by the side of the jacuzzi as he dipped into the warm, bubbly water.

A sigh escaped his lips when he was finally thoroughly soaked. The water was warm enough to unknot the muscles in his shoulders, and the faint fizz of bubbles was a steady hush against the glass walls that framed the city landscape. Outside, Okheman Street shimmered with its thousand lights. It's always so weird looking at the city from this height.

It felt so close, and yet so untouchable.

Phainon took a sip of the wine, wincing when the taste of alcohol bit his tongue back, but the warmth that spread across his body and the buzz that started to crawl to his head was a lovely welcome. He let his head fall back, eyelids growing heavier with every lazy ripple of comfortable warmth.

His gaze softened until the city blurred, the lights bending, stretching into impossibly long streaks of color. The faint scent of chlorine from the jacuzzi mingled with the air, and for a moment, Phainon felt like he was floating out of the water.

And the next thing he knew, he stood in a room that looked like their kitchen, but there was nothing there; no Mydei's numerous jars of spices, bottles of sauces and syrups, just three walls surrounding him, and a glass door to the patio…

Where Mydei was standing, in the Greek God regalia that Gerald had mentioned just this morning.

He looked so good in that fit. The gold that burned under the warmth of the rising sun, red fabrics spilling down one shoulder like molten silk… every inch of him gleamed: the sun catching on the edge of a shoulder plate, the metallic thread woven into the blood-colored cape, the swirls of his chest and shoulders tattoo, splayed on his smooth, pale, beautiful skin.

He looked so… *ethereal,* like the incarnation of Holy Nikador himself.

No, far more beautiful than that.

Phainon's chest ached with want. He stepped forward, reaching for him—for the warmth of his skin, for the soft lips that delivered the rough, hungry kisses, for kissing that special spot under his jaw, one that he knew Mydei loved so much.

But then, Phainon hit an invisible wall.

He pressed harder, leaving blurred prints where his fingers slid. Mydei didn't seem to see him—only turned slightly, the light sharpening along the curve of his jaw.

Phainon slammed his fists against the barrier, shattering it to the ground. But then, another wall rose between them, replacing the first. He broke it again, but another appeared. And another. Each one clearer, thinner, yet still impossible to pass.

No matter what he did, he couldn't go beyond that invisible wall that separated them.

Phainon called for Mydei. Quiet at first, but with each new barrier, his voice grew louder, his desperation clawed on his heart, clutching it tighter and tighter until it was hard for him to breathe.

Mydei!

Mydei!

MYDEI!

"HKS!"

Phainon's eyes shot open, and he saw Mydei—*the real Mydei* in front of him. He was seated in the water bare-chested, flushed, and exhausted. No Greek God regalia, no ethereal golden color, no empty, distant stare—just his Mydei.

Phainon’s heart pounded wildly. He blinked a few more times and held on to Mydei’s shoulders to ground himself and realized that it was just a dream.

Just a dream.

And yet, the claw in his heart did not let up. It was still there, taking hold of Phainon’s heart like it was just waiting for a moment to destroy it. His head spun, and Phainon briefly forgot how to breathe.

“You’re half-cooked, how long have you been her—oof,”

Phainon quickly tackled Mydei into a hug, holding onto him as if he were just a second late; Mydei would disappear to the other side of the glass window where he couldn’t reach him. He reached for Mydei desperately, his fingers reaching for his skin, his face buried in Mydei’s hair, inhaling as much natural scent as mixed with the faint remnant of his cologne.

The desperation was fading as the smell of Mydei’s cologne grounded Phainon, but the fear remained there, as real as the water that felt too hot against his skin.

Phainon was so pressed close against Mydei that the reverberation of Mydei’s laughter felt like it came from his own chest.

“I’m here, I’m here,” Mydei said with a soft chuckle. But there was still worry there. He pressed a gentle kiss to Phainon’s cheek. “Dreaming of me?”

Phainon hummed, but he did not say any words. He kept clinging to Mydei, blinking away the blur in his eyes before Mydei could get a chance to see them. He wouldn’t, for the life of him, allow Mydei to see the tears that came from his nightmare. He clenched his fists, feeling the remnants of the burn from smashing the glass walls in his dream linger there.

How did it even—

How could he—

Phainon could feel his tense body gradually relax with each of Mydei's soothing rubs on his skin.

"*Fos mou*," Mydei pressed his lips on the corner of Phainon's sun tattoo, as if physically planting the sweet whisper of his favorite Kremnoan word to his skin—*my light*.

The word he said was only for him, in the sanctuary, only their own. This was the real Mydei, and he was *his* alone.

"Yours," Phainon let out a breathy whisper. His voice was still shaky, but confidence was taking root now.

He pulled away from the hug, giving himself enough distance to see Mydei's face. A mist of desire clouded his half-lidded golden eyes; his face was exhausted, but he looked content. A gentle smile was on his lips, but there was a tiny furrow on his brow; a silent disbelief that *he's capable of such love.*

His Mydei.

Phainon cupped Mydei's face with his fingers, flushed from the heat and wrinkled from how long they had been soaked. His thumb brushed the tattoo under Mydei's eyes.

"Yours," he repeated again. "*Kotik*,"

Mydei reacted to that pet name almost instantly. His eyes were dark with desire, and he leaned into his touch with that feline ease, teeth grazing his palm in a playful bite that made Phainon laugh—short, breathless, breaking on the edge of something sharper. And in that moment, the clench in Phainon's heart, the acid that sat in the pit of his gut, was gone without a trace.

The desperation in his chest dissolved, but what replaced it was no less consuming.

Phainon kissed him before the thought could form, crashing their mouths together with a hunger that had been pacing behind his ribs all day. Mydei met him without hesitation, lips just as eager, just as desperate. Phainon poured every unsaid thing into the kiss—every ache from the glass walls, every quiet promise from the sanctuary only they owned, and he held Mydei in his arms so tightly, as if his life depended on it.

Maybe that was the truth.

Maybe Phainon would die if Mydei decided to let him go one day.

Phainon was far too deep in his own lust to mull over that morbid thought. Whatever happens tomorrow, he'll leave it for tomorrow. Tonight, he would love, he would live, he would love this man so deeply while he still had him.

When they broke for air, Phainon's voice was raw, his plea unguarded.

"Hold me," he whispered. "Let me touch you now, now. Please,"

Phainon pressed his lips on Mydei's skin with frantic, uneven movements, each sound that tore from his throat ragged with desire. Phainon knew how desperate he must look, how needy he must be, but there wasn't room for shame.

Not tonight.

Tonight, he needed to feel alive, to selfishly claim Mydei for himself, to touch his body and hold him so tight until nothing existed beyond the two of them.

Not even a thin, invisible glass wall.

Mydei's mouth twitched, torn between a smirk and hunger. "Alright, let's get to…"

"No," Phainon gasped, nails catching hard against Mydei's shoulder, afraid to let him go. "Let me fuck you here."

“No, you’re half-cooked, c’mon, I’ll get you out of…”

“Now.” Phainon’s voice cracked into half-growl, half-plea. His hands raked down Mydei’s back, pulling him closer, keeping him pinned in place. “Don’t let me go, Dei. Please, please…”

“*Quiet*,” Mydei growled back. His voice was dangerously low. It was the tone that carried the lust to conquer, the kind that didn’t allow argument. “If you’re so desperate, then do it on my terms.”

Phainon whimpered, the fight draining out of him in an instant, replaced by growing hunger. He didn’t resist when the younger man pulled him from the now too-warm bath. The shock of the cool air made him shiver, every nerve suddenly awake and waiting. But Phainon was a man on a mission. He dragged Mydei to the bedroom, holding him close as his mouth trailed heated, claiming kisses down his jaw, across the curve of his neck.

The walk to the bedroom was short, but it stretched out in a haze of heat and anticipation. He was desperate, so, so desperate, and he couldn’t even blink. He couldn’t even get his eyes off Mydei, afraid that a glass wall would rise between them, separate him from the man he loved so much.

There was something about Mydei when Phainon was being needy like this —an intoxicating shift from the lazy kitten he usually was. Sure, he always looked so smug even in their most private moments, but whenever Phainon was a needy mess, Mydei would look more confident, feral, like a lion claiming his prey. Commanding, like a king who knows that he could ask for the world and beyond.

The shift was always satisfying, as if Mydei was finally allowed to be completely himself.

And usually, Phainon would want nothing more than to allow him. To be a servant who would answer to every demand of his king.

But tonight, he wanted *more*.

He wanted to meet Mydei in that throne, to stand beside him as his equal. And here, within the walls of their sanctuary, he could.

Even the glass wall that stretched across the wall could not take that away.

Mydei was his to claim, and he was Mydei to claim. No one could take them apart.

They were invincible.

Still, it wasn’t enough for him.

Phainon pushed Mydei toward the window, claiming him for the world to see. He could hear Mydei’s groans, his giddy laugh mixed with pleasure, rumbling so close as if it came from his own chest. His blurry vision could barely make out the puffs of their mingled exhales.

It was one-sided glass, and they were so high above the streets that no one could possibly see or hear them. And yet, Phainon couldn’t help but feel the erupting joy, the absolute thrill at the thought that the whole world finally witnessed who Mydei truly belonged to.

Mydei was here, on the same side of the glass wall, submitting underneath him for the skyline, the skyscrapers, and the half-hanging moon to see.

That he was Phainon’s, and Phainon’s was his.

Nothing outside of these walls mattered anymore.

-

Mydei had fallen asleep the moment they crashed back onto the pillow, and now that Phainon was finally free from his horny haze, he only realized how exhausted Mydei looked just by the dim sight of his slack, peaceful face.

A flicker of guilt tugged at him.

Phainon had probably tired him out even more with his demands.

But between watching Mydei's completely relaxed face and the contentment that sat deep inside Phainon's own chest, that feeling quickly disappeared, replaced by the love that filled his heart to the brim as Phainon pulled Mydei closer into his embrace, spooning him and pressing him so close in a way he knew that Mydei would appreciate when he woke up in the morning.

With Mydei's presence all over him, Phainon drifted off to sleep easily, without dreams slipping through his subconscious.

It was always easy to feel relaxed when he got his sanctuary in his arms.

Even as morning came and Phainon was alone in bed, Mydei's presence still hovered all around him; in the mess of the sheets next to Phainon, and in the smell of coffee, butter, and perfectly burnt toast filling the air. Phainon smiled to himself, feeling a bit silly about how uneasy he had been yesterday, when everything on this side of their wall was the same: Mydei still loved him, and their morning routine remained uninterrupted.

Everything is okay.

Everything would be okay if he stayed off the grid, just like what Dan Heng said.

Phainon pulled up a pair of boxers and wore Mydei's shirt as he got up from bed, almost skipping his steps when he saw Mydei in the kitchen, preparing something on the counter that Phainon couldn't see, with Mydei's back facing him. Phainon wrapped his arms around him from behind—one hand on his waist, the other tipping his cheek for a kiss.

"Morning, princess," he whispered. "What are you cooking today?"

Mydei flinched a little. Probably startled by Phainon's presence. He could get lost in his own mind when he was cooking, sometimes.

“HKS…”

“Would you let me help?” Phainon asked, giving another peck on his lips. “Let me do the…”

“HKS get off me,” Mydei hissed, pushing Phainon away from him. “We’ve got company.”

“We’ve got comp… who?”

“Ahem.”

A woman’s voice rang out behind him. Phainon jolted so hard he nearly sprang away from Mydei like he’d touched a hot stove. Mydei burst into laughter, and *Robin Gopherwood* laughed with him, closing her mouth with her fingers out of grace.

Robin.

What is *Robin* doing here?

“Why are you so surprised?” Mydei asked. Apparently, Phainon had said that out loud. “I told you this morning that Robin’s gonna drop by for breakfast, and you said, ‘Hmmm, nice’.”

“Oh?” Phainon managed a weak laugh. Not even Mydei’s terrible impression of him could distract from the fact that *The Robin*™ was standing in their kitchen.

“I didn’t know. I must have… uh, not heard? Or not awake enough to remember. Sorry Robin, didn’t see you there.”

“Hi, Phainon, it’s okay, it is me who has to apologize for intruding so early in the morning,” Robin waved from the stool on their kitchen’s island gracefully. “Our schedule today was not far from here, and I thought since Uncle Krateros couldn’t come to pick Mydei up, I’d do that instead. Mydei offered me breakfast so… here I am.”

Uncle Krateros.

“Oh, that’s so nice of you, Robin,” Phainon said. “Also, you’re not intruding at all. Uh… Mydei’s cooking breakfast, so… do you want something? Coffee? Milk?”

Robin shook her head. “Thank you, Mydei made me a coffee just now,” Robin said, pointing at the mug on the island in front of her.

“You take this,” Mydei said, placing a glass of what smelled like banana and coconut water on the table. “You were drinking last night. This is good for a hangover.”

“Guh, I’m fine,” Phainon laughed. “It was just a little sip of wine. I didn’t even drink anything in Cae’s house.”

“Yeah, drink it anyway,” Mydei insisted. “You’ll feel better going to work later.”

“Yeah, you know who will go to work feeling bad? You, if you insist on doing all the cooking and not letting me help!”

Mydei continued to try to banish him to the stool next to Robin, while Phainon insisted on helping with breakfast. Their bicker fell naturally, just like any other morning, but with Robin taking a front row seat, smiling and chuckling in endearment, like she was enjoying the show.

It felt so strange that Phainon thought that it was natural for her to be here, like she always belonged.

“Is it always like this? Does Mydei always cook breakfast every morning?” Robin asked Phainon, when he finally sipped that hangover-cure drink (which he didn’t need), and Mydei finally stopped pestering him.

“He would die of starvation if I’m not,” Mydei was the one who answered. “That guy has a thing for unhealthy eating habits. I didn’t see the Pad Thai from yesterday. Did you throw it out like I said you should, or did you eat them?” he then asked Phainon, narrowing his eyes menacingly.

“Mydei likes to cook,” Phainon told Robin, ignoring Mydei’s question entirely. “He likes to feed people he loves and their mother. Like, seriously, he cooked for my parents once.”

“Aww,” Robin cooed dreamily, alternating his gaze from Phainon to Mydei. “May I ask how did you two get together? I… I mean, if it’s not too much to ask! If it intrudes, then…”

“Nah, it’s fine, Rob,” Mydei answered, finally taking off his apron and sitting next to Phainon, just in front of Robin. “It’s not that much of a story anyway, I was being a dick, giving Aglaea’s secretary attitude and shit, and HKS here really went all the way to scold me. Challenged me in a duel and stuff.”

Robin gaped, looking super invested in the story as she leaned forward. “Duel,” she murmured. “Like… a real duel?”

“Yeah, totally,” Phainon laughed, taking a bite of his salad before continuing. “Not so much, at first. Mydei invited me to his concert first and I dared myself to come in without his invitation. Then, after that, he challenged me at boxing, then a sprint, then another boxing session, and before we know it, uh…”

And they made out in the back of Mydei’s car, but Robin did not need to know that. It felt too private to share because, as kind, polite, and brilliant Robin was, she was not a friend.

Not yet.

She was barely an acquaintance. She was a person from the other side of the wall, slipping into the side where his sanctuary lies, where Phainon felt safest and was not ready to share with anyone just yet.

Not especially *Robin*.

“... and then somehow we kissed and Hyacine caught us, and she suddenly told us that she lost a bet. All this time, Aglaea and Anaxa had hosted a bet

on how long we would meet before we realized we wanted each other *in that way*."

Phainon let out a smile, glancing at Mydei while his gut felt like it was pulled in four different directions.

But of course, Robin was Mydei's friend. She was an important part of his life, now. Of course, he would tell her.

Phainon swallowed his salad. The taste of Aedes Elysiae, cooked by the man he loved most, now felt even a little bit… strange.

"Oh," Robin laughed. "Madame Aglaea started it?"

"She won it," Mydei said begrudgingly, shaking his head with the littlest scoff. "Cheated a little too, she kept egging me on to challenge HKS over and over again, so we could *accelerate our progress*, and she could win. If you ask Anaxagoras now, I think he would still hold a little grudge against her."

And as the conversation rolled into a more casual chit-chat about their day, Phainon started to drift off into the other side of the glass wall again, watching Robin and Mydei go back and forth about the music, the schedule, about how they could bring a little bit of memorabilia of Queen Gorgo…

And Phainon couldn't touch it. He could never be a part of that world. All he could do was smile with his mouth while his chest felt like a glass splintering from the inside.

So close, and yet so untouchable.

Phainon tried to squash those feelings away because like Mydei, Robin was just another Aventurine's pawn. She did not actually like Mydei in that way, and had been respectful of Phainon and Mydei's relationship until now.

And yet, Phainon felt a little bit like a stranger in his own house.

A third wheel in his own relationship.

That thought made him feel sick, because Phainon actually hated it. He hated that he felt jealous of something that wasn’t real, that he felt threatened by the ghost of what could never be. He hated the fact that he could never hold Mydei’s mom's legacy like Robin, to treasure it the way Mydei could only dream of all this time. That he locked away a massive potential from Mydei's life, because he came from a different side of the wall.

Because he would never understand how to unlock it.

The thought made him so sick that he could not even look Mydei in the eye.

Phainon excused himself to go to the shower, to which Robin replied with a wave of goodbye, a ‘see you again soon!’, and Mydei only grunted, his eyes lingering a little bit longer on Phainon before he got distracted with whatever celebrity stuff Robin spoke that Phainon could never hope to understand.

But Phainon did not go to shower. He sat on the bed instead, his finger scrolled past his work schedule idly as he stared at the smudge of his own body on the windowpane, the outline of last night’s desperation. He should wipe it away before the cleaners come to save himself the shame, but he couldn’t bring himself to move.

The door to their room opened, jolting Phainon from his daydream, and Mydei slipped inside their room.

“Hey, I’m going in ten minutes,” he said.

Phainon hummed, forcing a tug of a smile. “Here for your goodbye kisses?”

Mydei did not answer. He stared down at Phainon, his jaws clenched, and his eyes narrowed in a way that he was bracing for something, and—

Oh, that can’t be good.

Phainon shifted, but before he could get up from bed, Mydei sat next to him, holding Phainon by the thigh to keep him from moving.

“Don’t bother,” he said. “I know you’re not going to shower. You never shower in the morning if you’ve taken a bath the night before.”

Phainon gaped. He tried to open his mouth, but Mydei did not let him.

“You also don’t drink the night before work, no matter what time you fly the next day. You don’t dip into the jacuzzi without waiting for me. You don’t dream, Phainon. You never dream, much less talk in your sleep. And you never cried when you fuck me. And you *always finish your breakfast*.”

Mydei’s fingers gripped a handful of Phainon’s boxers as his golden eyes hardened into a glare.

“Do you really think I wouldn’t notice how uneasy you are?” he asked. “Do you really plan to send me away without saying anything? Do you think I’m that dumb?”

Phainon let out a sigh. “Mydei, you know I’m fine, I’m just…”

“No, don’t fuck around and give me a half-assed answer that ‘I’m fine’ because I fucking know you’re not,” Mydei hissed. The grip on Phaionon’s thigh tightened a little, and his gaze hardened.

Mydei looked furious, no, desperate, no…

He looked so restless.

Phainon pressed his lips, idly entwining his fingers on Mydei’s, and even though he knew he had to answer, the truth lay heavy on his tongue. It felt silly to even talk about his insecurities when Mydei’s here, caring about him and paying attention to Phainon’s discomforts, because he knew that it was all nothing but a product of his own mind.

“I’m sorry, ‘Dei,” he said quietly. “It was just… I just… I think I was just caught off guard by that shoes trend you got with Robin,” he continued. “I mean, I know it’s just a pair of shoes, and it’s stupid, I should have muted it and moved on with my life, but—”

Mydei gripped Phainon's hand, muttering a Kremnoan curse under his breath. "*Phainon Khaslana*, I swear to Nikador's wrath," Mydei groaned. "I only allowed it because I think you were okay with it. You didn't say anything, back in the studio. You were encouraging Robin! How would I know that you're not okay with it? I thought you even forgot about the shoes. You never wear them anymore."

"I don't get any chance wearing them anywhere, work was crazy," Phainon said. "When we do have free time, we always stay at home or work out at the gym. I couldn't wear it either way."

Mydei sighed, looking absolutely dejected and guilty. He cursed in Kremnoan once again.

"You were there yesterday! Why didn't you say anything? Didn't I say that you should tell me for every smallest thing you were uncomfortable of?"

"Because *it is* okay!" Phainon hissed, afraid that Robin would be able to hear it. "Like I said, I was just caught off guard because it went viral, and for a while, I think I'm sad that the shoe thing wasn't ours anymore. But I'm fine now, *it's fine*. I'm over it, I promise!"

Mydei shook his head, looking disappointed, and it made Phainon's heart clench. A string of apologies was already heavy on his tongue, but then Mydei pulled his phone from his pocket.

"That's it, I'm calling shit off," he said. "The contract's over. I'm not allowing Aventurine to do…"

"'Dei, fuck, come on, are you crazy?" Phainon snatched Mydei's phone, but Mydei gripped it tight, not allowing Phainon to take it. "The campaign has already launched. They already sold out the shoes everywhere! Aventurine probably got the contract. You can't just cancel it, you…"

"Yes, I can," Mydei interrupted him. "I can, and I *will* shut that down. Because I mean it when I said that *I will stop* the moment you feel uncomfortable, HKS. Because *something like this* is what I was talking about when I asked you to tell me what you feel throughout the campaign."

“But it’s done anyway, so what’s the point? You will only get people in trouble!”

“*Fuck people*, Phainon,” Mydei said, his voice raised a bar, and Phainon flinched. He pressed his forefinger in front of his lips, asking Mydei to tone it down lest Robin hear them.

Mydei closed his eyes, took a deep breath, and held both of Phainon’s shoulders, as if trying to ground himself. “Seriously. Fuck people. Stop thinking about them for once, HKS. Fuck people. Fuck everything. I said that once, and I’ll repeat it now. The music, the legacy, they’re not more important for me than *you*.”

Phainon could feel his heart clenched.

“I know, I heard you. But the music is important for me, too, ‘Dei,” Phainon said, cupping Mydei’s jaws to calm him down. “Your music, your mom’s legacy. Those are the things that make you happy. That’s the things that make you who you are. They’ve been there before I met you. And I saw how it makes you feel. I saw how alive you become with that music, and I want that for you. It’s *absolutely important* for me that you get to have those moments, a chance to bring your Mom’s works to life. To grow as a musician while respecting your legacy. So please, don’t ruin it just because I’m being a little bit silly one day, okay?”

Mydei stared at Phainon, like, looking right into his eyes, as if he was searching for something. There was a little spark of pain there, and fear, and Kephale knows what else. Mydei then shook his head. He closed his eyes, as if trying to squash those thoughts away from his mind.

“But what about me?” he asked. “I want to respect you in the same way, too. Making sure you feel the safest with me. It’s *absolutely important* for me that you take such discomfort seriously and not brush it off as silly, Phainon. I want to spare you from that burden. What are we gonna do about that?”

Phainon sighed, a little chuckle on his lips. Of course, Mydei would challenge him for that, too.

“We’re going to treat it as a first warning, then,” he said. “A warning for me not to take it lightly again, and not doom-scrolling on Aventurine’s circus again.”

“And a warning for me to double-check if you’re okay with Aventurine’s plan?” Mydei offered. “Even if you said *you’re fine*.”

“I’m always fine with it,” Phainon huffed. “It was just because that particular improvisation actually touched our personal stuff that it caught me off guard.”

“Mmm,” Mydei hummed. “That’s not good enough.”

“What’s not good enough?”

“I want to make sure you feel absolutely safe and comfortable with everything,” he said. “But you always ignore your feelings. You always think about other people, and I can’t always ask you and look at your eyes and tell if you’re being too generous. I need something to help us with that. Like… um…”

“… A quiet signal,” Phainon said quietly, his mind wandered back to Dan Heng’s advice.

“Hm?” Mydei asked. “Quiet signal?”

Phainon told him about Dan Heng and Caelus’ discreet way of communicating during promotions. To his surprise, Mydei listened intently, chin propped on his hand, humming at all the right moments. When Phainon finished, Mydei suddenly rose, rummaged through one of Phainon’s drawers, and came back kneeling in front of him. He set something gently into Phainon’s palm.

It was his choker. The double-band choker Phainon had always used when they were first dating. The one that Mydei always liked to tug at when he kissed him roughly.

“Put it on me,” Mydei said. His tone left no room for protest.

Phainon blinked, startled. “What?”

“You heard me,” Mydei said. “Put it on me, HKS. This way, whenever you see a picture of me, you will always remember who I belong to. I will make sure this stays off Aventurine’s list. No merchandise based on this, no matching gimmicks. This is mine. *Ours.* A quiet symbol that I belong to you.”

Phainon’s throat went dry. “You’d wear it? All the time?” he asked. “Will… Aventurine… allow it?”

“He will,” Mydei said confidently, his voice was so stern it was almost a growl. “Now, please.”

Phainon’s fingers trembled at first, but he steadied them with a quiet breath as he fastened the clasp. The leather sat snug around Mydei’s throat, stark black against his pale skin, sharp as ink across parchment. For a moment, Phainon just looked at him, heart hammering. He had worn this choker countless times himself, but seeing it on Mydei—*his Mydei*, shifted something inside him. It wasn’t just an accessory. It was a vow. A quiet signal only they understood.

When Phainon’s hands lingered there, Mydei caught them, kissed his knuckles, then pressed them against his chest.

“Now,” Mydei said. His golden eyes were wild, like a forest fire. “Do you like it, *fos mou*?”

Phainon’s heart squeezed. “Yeah,” he stammered. “You’re… uh, amazing. Always.”

Mydei’s mischievous smile was back. “Mmm I’m sure you like it. Your little friend there seemed excited, too,” he said, patting Phainon’s groin. "Please give him my regards. This is all I could do for him until we meet again.”

He kissed Phainon’s right hand, then parted his lips, dragging his tongue in a slow, deliberate line from the base of Phainon’s palm to the tip of his

thumb. A playful bite lingered there, like an eager little cat asking to play, before he finally let go.

Mydei then got up to his feet, chuckling. “Safe flight, *Phainon.exe*,” he whispered, brushing kisses over his nose, his cheeks, his jaw. “Call me when you land.”

Phainon could only nod, still dazed, still trembling. When Mydei left, the silence was thunderous, but it was gladly welcomed, this time.

When he came back from the haze of Mydei’s departure, Phainon realized he was flushed, half-hard, and undone simply from fastening a clasp around Mydei’s neck.

Maybe they would have to unpack this—Phainon’s sudden obsession with his accessories on Mydei, and that new goodbye Mydei just did, and the sexy implication that goes with it.

Yep, he would do that. But not today.

Today, Phainon decided he could let go of his unnecessary fears. Because now, more than ever, he believed they would be fine.

He needed to clean up and get ready for work, too.

…Well, right after he handled a far more urgent matter in his pants.

Chapter End Notes

... Guess what will blow up on Phainon's face later :D

I feel like Phainon is a little bit OOC in this chapter because "My Deliverer Can't Be This Sulky™" but please do let me know what you think >.<

-

For anyone not familiar with the word 'Kotik', it's actually Russian pet name means "little cat". and 'Fos mou' is Greek for "My light", as

stated. In this AU, I have Aedes Elysiae as a Slavic country and Kremnos as part of Greece lol.

A shameless friendship offering on my social as always! Pls holla @ me on X, @mydaymousee

Chapter 5: Ghosts

Chapter Summary

> Phainon finally understand the weight of his decision; the ghosts that come along with the fame that he pushed Mydei to.

Chapter Notes

> Hi hello! It's me again with... the angst I didn't even see coming? T.T I feel like I must apology in advance.
> But this is a chapter where everything got worse (before it gets better! This is an angst with happy ending after all)
>
> also this was beta-ed by very kind Norii from X! thank you for dealing with my ramblings and annoying self-doubts!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The week’s flying schedule was brutal.

Phainon always hated both ultra-long-haul and multiple short legs, but if he had to choose, he would rather choose the former in a heartbeat.

Because multiple short legs always consist of a blur of airport-briefing-cockpit-report with so few breaks in between, like a marathon that he must finish on his own. The layover cities were often reduced to airport highways and hotel rooms.

His favorite joke about running short legs was comparing it to being thrown into a hamster wheel and being forced to run as fast as possible. He could only focus on putting his foot in front of the other, keeping the wheel spinning while the world blurred around him.

Except when he stepped out of the wheel, nothing was the same anymore.

Phainon only realized it when he flew the last flight before his mandatory rest. He was supervising the descent into Styxia Airport when Plionis, his First Officer, hummed a melody that he knew too well.

Goddess. Robin and Mydei's song. There's no denying it.

"Catchy," Phainon commented off-handedly. "What song is it?"

"Oh, it's Goddess, Robin's new song with her new boyfriend," he replied. "Out only yesterday."

Wow, two punches in a single breath. *Boyfriend*. *Yesterday.* Phainon didn't even know that the first song was already released. He really lost track of time with all the back-to-back flights.

Mydei must have forgotten to mention it, too.

He must have forgotten that his song's release date had always been important for Phainon. He liked to see the first twenty-four hours of Mydei's song perform on the chart, watching as the number crawled up. Mydei called him out one time, saying that it was a bad habit. He didn't really care how his song performed on the chart, and Phainon shouldn't either.

But Phainon did anyway, brushing Mydei's protest off with a tease about him sucking at math and numbers in general.

His lips curved into a smile, thin and tired. He'd check the charts later. Now, he gotta land the plane first.

"Alright, hummer, you want to call tower for clearance now, or should I do that while you hum to the next chorus?" he asked, teasing the now flustered rookie. Plionis stuttered to answer him that yes, he'd contacted the tower, and while the aircraft descended, Phainon couldn't help but wonder how tough the past few days had been for Mydei.

The release of a new song and album usually meant a really tight schedule for him. It must be even worse with Aventurine's crazy timeline as they

tried to sell the Summer Tour tickets. It must be a cycle of shooting - studio - promotions - interviews for him; the same hamster wheel that Phainon endured too, only that Mydei's wheel is a more glamorous one, filled with limelights and cameras.

This was always the toughest part of their relationships; with their communication reduced to voice notes and short messages, only enough for sweet dreams, close-up selfies showing each other's exhaustion, and very rarely, brief recaps of their days. And between the exhaustion, white noise, and the choppy signals, Mydei often fell asleep on the phone as soon as his head hit the pillow.

It's crazy how fast the world outside of his flight plan moved.

As the plane made the final part of taxiing to the gate, Phainon wondered what it would be like if one of them had chosen a different career path. Maybe if he had accepted Aglaea's offer to model for her men's clothing line, his life would have turned out differently. He might have been in the same industry as Mydei, orbiting closer, crossing paths more often. He could have understood Mydei better, perhaps even offered genuine input on his marketing or artistry, instead of just cheering him on from the sidelines.

Or maybe, and this was a very strange thought to think about, if Mydei had pursued culinary instead of music, perhaps he could be home more often. Phainon could come home to Mydei in an apron; he would have a more regular schedule, and his biggest challenge would be a flirty coworker smitten over how perfectly he could roast a Peking duck.

The mental image made Phainon scoff at himself.

Stupid.

There's no way it could ever happen. Mydei always loved music. It was literally running in his veins, with both his parents being musicians. And Phainon couldn't imagine being anything other than a pilot. He loved flying and keeping people safe and comfortable as they flew across the world with him. It was always his dream since he was a little boy.

He didn’t know where those thoughts even came from. They had made it clear from the start of their relationship that neither of them should change careers or anything about each other. They would make it work somehow.

Phainon could still remember his first proposal to move in together after they had dated for several months.

“I mean, it doesn’t have to be now*, now. But I’m always game if you do, Mydei,” Phainon said, feeling utterly nervous in the face of Mydei’s poker face. “Time, distance, they’re trivial compared to my love for you. I will always try to make it work with you. But being in the same house does have its benefits, right? I can kiss you goodbye before you go, I can keep the house clean for you, and I can snuggle you. I can give you the world!”*

Mydei snickered. His stoic face was cracking into a cheeky smile. “You’ll hate me the first months I don’t come home from tour,” Mydei teased. “You’re a horny freak. You’re gonna fuck someone else in my own house in the third week I don’t come home.”

“I will NOT!” Phainon shot back, brows furrowed in genuine offense. “I’m only a horny freak when it’s you! And I swear I’ll be the best boyfriend ever. Besides, yearning is part of the game, y’know? It spices things up. We’re gonna have the kinkiest phone sex and the hottest one whenever we’re reunited.”

And they did. For four years, they had built a rhythm that worked, filling every corner of the house with their presence, carving their own sanctuary on weekends, loving each other even in their absence. So really, nothing changed—nothing was out of the ordinary.

So why was he even thinking about it?

Phainon must have been more exhausted than he thought, and maybe he missed Mydei more than he actually let on.

When the plane finally landed, Phainon quickly grabbed his phone and called Mydei. Sadly, it went straight to voicemail. Mydei must be somewhere he couldn’t use his phone. Maybe a radio interview, or perhaps

he’s in the middle of a shoot. Phainon lost track of his schedule, barely keeping up with his own, due to the madness of it all.

But he did not have to wait long to hear Mydei’s voice, because as soon as Phainon stepped out of the aircraft, Mydei’s voice was *everywhere*.

It poured from a portable speaker slung at a teenager’s hip as she skipped through the terminal, singing along with Robin’s *oooh lalala*. It floated from the duty-free shop, blasting over racks of perfume. It bled through the waiting room TVs, synced with glossy commercials. And along his walk to the cab station, Phainon saw Cherry Red shoes everywhere; worn by a trendy couple who took selfies, by a group of girls, another couple…

And as he got into a cab to his layover hotel, the taxi radio also played that song. Mydei’s voice was rougher in the poor-quality signal and the half-assed stereo.

And when his taxi slid past the city center, there he was—Mydei, ten stories tall, blazing across the largest LED billboard in the square, illuminating the night city streets with the red and golden light from his image.

The Royalty is Throned
Get Ruled This Summer
Pre-Order Now

After the text, another photo popped up. This time, it was Mydei with Robin.

Oh, it’s the album art of the EP.

Phainon gazed at the image. The background was bold red, Mydei’s kind of Red, and he was sitting in a crystal throne in the color of blood—the same throne that was seen in Queen Gorgo’s last album before she went on hiatus. His white shirt, accented in gold, hung half-open, revealing the chest tattoo, paired with black leather pants and Arcadia boots. His hair was loose and messy, his hand balancing a golden glass like a king in the middle of his coronation.

And then there was Robin. Perched sideways on his lap, her black-booted feet dangling from the throne's arm, her swan-fur dress glittering under diamond shoulder pieces. Fingerless gloves framed her hands as they hovered above Mydei's cheeks, tilting a crown above his head. His own fingers, just barely visible behind her, held a tiara over her updo hair as if to complete the picture. Together, they looked straight into the camera, their blue and golden eyes fierce and untouchable, like royalty from Dollywood, daring the world to challenge them.

And on Mydei's lips, there was that smug tug of a smile he only wore when he was winning.

Royalties.

Phainon could feel his chest constrict at how crazy incredible that album art looked.

He had seen it before, of course. Mydei had sent him the raw results of the photoshoot, as well as behind-the-scenes images. He had known all about it since that first creative meeting in one of Aventurine's mood boards. He knew what every color represented, what every gesture meant, what Aventurine's team hoped the audience would read.

Yet, it still stunned him how… *real* the actual execution was.

It was polished to perfection, every hue and contrast sharpened into meaning, every expression sharpened into narrative; the glamour they tried to convey, the burning, rebellious passion of two young musical royals shared in the five songs of the EP.

It was meant to sell the idea that they're *so good together.*

And Phainon was sold.

Had he not known about it, he would have thought they were actually together, and Phainon would have rooted for them because, aesthetically, they were flawless. Golden to silver, black to white, red to lavender—a

pairing so seamlessly woven together it had no room for any other color—for any other person.

And they're perfect for each other, too, in a prolific way that Mydei was the prince of rock and Robin was the princess of pop.

He knew, yet it did not stop him from being struck by the polished final image.

Seeing Mydei live into that role with Robin, sitting on a symbolic throne that once belonged to his mother, Phainon felt as if Mydei were a different man entirely. Like this couldn't be the same Mydei that curled into his embrace in the morning, hissing like a spoiled little cat at the threat of a cold shower.

He looked so surreal, in the same way the stars were surreal for Phainon; he could see them, but could never fly high enough to reach them.

He could, technically. However, that opportunity had passed many years ago. If Phainon were a model, maybe he could've made it into the album art. The music video. Up there in Mydei's world, if only as a dim background light.

No, bad thought, Phainon, no.

Even if you are a model, you can't always be with Mydei.

You know what you're dealing with, dating a rock star. There's always part of him that belongs to the rest of the world. You can't always have all of him for yourself.

He stared at the digital billboard one last time. Somehow, looking into Mydei's pixelated eyes on the LED screen made it feel like all their years together had been nothing more than a vivid dream—no more real than the kind Nereia might have. No more real than an average fan's fantasy.

Phainon was so close to being swallowed whole by that thought, if not for the fact that Mydei was wearing a choker in that album art.

His choker.

Remember who I belong to.

Phainon's breath caught, then escaped in a shaky scoff, feeling relieved in a way he almost fell to a cliff in a dream and jolted awake from the sensation.

Yeah, don't fall for it, Phainon. He's still the same Mydei. This couldn't be any more different than any of Mydei's promotional albums; just a spectacle.

Oh, Kephale, he's so, *so* exhausted.

He couldn't wait to get to a proper bed and sleep.

"That Gorgo boy finally does something good, huh?" the taxi driver suddenly murmured, distracting Phainon from his own thoughts.

Phainon raised his brows. "Hm?"

"Yeah, the Gorgo boy," he said, nudging at the Radio playing the song. "He's been musically stagnant these past few years. Good songs, no actual fire. Almost sounds like a sellout. This song is the first time he actually broke through. Guess all he needed was a talented woman backing him up, huh."

Phainon did not react. He did not know what to say or think, but he felt the sting he could not describe flicking at the edge of his exhausted mind.

Ouch.

"I don't know, I kind of like him," Phainon said, quietly thanking Kephale that he was far too spent to strangle an unsuspecting old man. "His music is so good, and people love it. Even Robin herself. His band is one of the most popular rock bands in the world, too, isn't it?"

"True, but popular doesn't mean good," the old man insisted. "You'd understand if you listened to Gregoria Gorgo's original material. She was the real talent. A total hit. Too bad she got knocked up so early. I had high

hopes for her son, but—" the old man tsked. "He was so uninspired until they paired him with a good woman. They even brought back one of Queen Gorgo's songs on the radio with that release! Do you know how rare it is for a twenty-year-old song to get airtime outside the Nostalgic Segment? He finally makes his mama proud."

Phainon did not know what to say to that. He was too exhausted to think, or to be offended, or even to fake a laugh. He only hummed, deciding that agreeing is far easier than arguing.

Can't even defend your man in front of a stranger, his mind shouted. *Best boyfriend that ever lived, my ass.*

The old man seemed to be more interested in rambling than having an actual conversation, because even without Phainon saying anything more substantial than a hum, he went on to talk about Queen Gorgo in her prime, and how Robin brought back her spirit with Mydei supporting her. He also mentioned that Mydei often looked inspired when collaborating with female singers, including Misia. This man must be a hardcore Queen Gorgo fan to keep such a close eye on his son, only to compare him to his mother. Completely forgetting that Mydei, with all the testosterone inside him, could never reach a range the female singers could.

Still, the fact that *Mydei needs a talented woman around him* lingered a beat too long in his mind.

He dragged a hand over his face. Titans, he was so, so exhausted.

And as if the fate was tempting him, the check-in process in his hotel was stuck. Apparently, the airline staff who booked him a room entered his information incorrectly, and the hotel reception had to call his office to sort it out.

Until then, Phainon was stuck on the lobby's couch.

Phainon groaned, plopping on the couch and deciding that if he ended up falling asleep there, he wouldn't mind at all. He stared at the quiet lobby, thinking to himself that at least he had a nice view of the sea—the lazy

waves lapping to the shore, sparkling under the warm lighting from the hotel.

He automatically grabbed his phone and took a quick photo to send to Mydei.

You
Wish u're here. So beautiful. (✧Д✧)
We shld go2 the beach next time.
When was the last time we had a proper vacation?
I guess never, huh.
That week in Aedes Elysiae did NOT count.

Phainon stared at the quiet chat room, thinking whether he should take another picture.

But instead of hearing back from his boyfriend on the phone, he heard it on the television in the lobby.

"... the pleasure's ours, Owlbert. Thanks for having us here."

Phainon shot his eyes up to the TV so fast he almost experienced whiplash.

There, in the *Owlbert's Night Live!* His boyfriend was sitting on the loveseat, wearing his rehearsed smile for live interviews, with one hand on the back of the couch, disappearing behind Robin, who smiled so brightly that she was literally glowing. It was the smile that always made Phainon smile, too. Back when he was a starstruck teenage boy.

The audience in the studio just cheered, even at the mere sight of Mydei and Robin. Owlbert leaned forward to speak, then paused as the audience roared. When Owlbert tried again, Robin let out a soft chuckle—and the audience erupted once more.

Owlbert closed his mouth with an exaggerated sigh. Then, as the cheer died down, Mydei laughed along with Robin, and the audience cheered again, leaving no room for Owlbert to speak.

"Alright, alright," Owlbert finally said, interrupting the cheer. “Fine, just admire them, guys. Let’s just scrap the idea of a talk show and stare at them for thirty minutes without ads. Do we all agree? I’ll bring my chair there to the audience’s section to join you, in that case.” Owlbert asked the audience jokingly, prompting much laughter.

“Please don’t, that’ll be hella awkward,” Mydei said. “Shush, guys. Let Owlbert do his job, please.”

The audience finally quieted down, and Robin pressed her lips, trying not to laugh.

“Sorry, guys, they just love you so much. But hey, aren’t we all?” Owlbert said to Robin and Mydei when he finally had the chance to speak. “The Cherry Bomb couple, finally on live TV! Speaking of, no Cherry Red Shoes tonight?”

Phainon scoffed.

Yeah. So much for those shoes.

Robin chuckled. “No, I don’t think it’s appropriate to wear it to such a proper talk show like Mr. Owlbert’s, so we gotta keep those home,” she said while winking. The audience in the studio laughed, and Phainon tried to smile through that *we* Robin implied.

It’s just a ruse, Phainon. That’s still your boyfriend.

“Aww that’s too bad, I’d really love to see those iconic shoes that got Dr Markenz sold out in a matter of hours! I had to pre-order for weeks to get a pair for my wife and me. Mydei, any chance I can borrow yours in the meantime?”

Mydei chuckled. “No. They’re very comfy where they belong.”

Phainon smiled along with him. Good boy, ‘Dei.

Owlbert nodded knowingly. “Right,” he said. Then, to the camera, he made a scandalous whisper. “The possessive man.”

The audience laughed again, and Mydei's smile faltered. He scratched his neck, right on the skin between the two bands of his choker, and Phainon had to stifle his laugh.

A quiet signal, he thought to himself.

Mydei did not even know whether Phainon was watching this live show, and yet he still did it. Phainon couldn't help but feel the warmth filling his chest.

Message received loud and clear, honeycake.

"So," Owlbert started again. "You two have been busy being the talk of the internet for a couple of weeks now. I have to say, with you two being musicians, it's no surprise that we got a song and an EP born from this… this… can I say it's a relationship? Okay, relationship. But I gotta ask, how did it happen? Which comes first, the EP or the relationship?"

"It's definitely the EP, yeah," Robin answered. "You know, I always admire Mydei, and during that break after the winter tour, I wrote a few songs which I showed my producer, who later showed them to Mydei's producer. And long story short, Mydei agreed to the collaborative EP."

"Oh yeah, you've always been a fan of Mydei," Owlbert nodded. "So how does it feel working with him? Is he better than you think?"

"Oh, he's *amazing*," Robin sighed, almost dreamily.

She glanced at Mydei, her eyes sparkled with adoration, while Mydei gave her an easy smile. Robin held her gaze for another second before returning her eyes to Owlbert.

"Like, I don't think anyone could help it, you know? Being in the presence of someone so talented and so… um… handsome, I guess I can't help but feel a little starstruck. The first day I was in the same room as Mydei, I was just stuttering almost the whole time because he's there, he's real, and he's very gentle, too. And I can't help but be a little bit smitten."

Robin pressed her lips coyly, a faint blush tinting her skin as he glanced back at Mydei. The studio cooed, and Owlbert smiled endearingly.

“Aww she’s in love,” Owlbert cooed again. “But what about you, Mydei? What does it feel like to work with this diva?”

“Um… the same for me, I guess?” Mydei replied. “It’s kind of surreal cause most of the time I only see Rob on TV, advertising, and from a friend I know who really likes her. So she always feels like a fairytale. Having her in a studio and working on a rock project felt a bit… weird, you know? The good kind of weird, cause Rob’s always in that pop genre, and I never imagined her ever interested in *my* genre of music specifically. But seeing her rocking to the new song… I think it’s insanely cool. And I respect her a lot. She’s just amazing. Totally amazing.”

A friend. So that’s who Phainon is in this narrative—*a friend who really likes Robin*.

Shut up, Phainon. At least he referred to you, even vaguely. It’s him saying he’s still thinking about you.

“So, who confessed first? You? Robin?” Owlbert asked again.

Mydei and Robin shared glances, and they snickered to each other.

“I don’t know, man, it just happened?” he shrugged. Mydei licked his lips, as if knowing that his answer was not enough. He scratched that part of his skin above the choker again. “It’s a bit weird to tell this cause, for me, the thing about working with Rob is she’s a package deal with Ratio. And you know how Ratio is. There’s this pressure when you’re in a room with a super-talented perfectionist who knows specifically what hits. He was so demanding, and Rob was a breath of fresh air. She was always sweet and bright, making the studio feel less intense without losing professionalism. So I am naturally drawn to her energy. We start to hang around each other a lot and… well...”

Naturally. Of course. It’s always been easy for Mydei to change things—his tone, his words, even the way he says her name. From ‘Miss Robin’, to

‘Robin’, to just ‘Rob.’

“... And thus she became your Goddess, huh,” Owlbert continued, clearly looking pleased at himself for connecting Mydei’s unfinished answer to the title of their song. “That song, guys. It’s absolutely stunning. It’s catchy, it’s fun, and you two sound like you have a great time making that song. Can we expect to have more in the rest of the EP?”

“We did have a great time experimenting, but the EP consists of five pieces that blend together Mydei and I…”

The discussion then shifted to what truly mattered: music. Robin told Owlbert and the studio about the songs, the inspiration, and the process, which was also mixed with a few anecdotes of Mydei calling her cute royalty puns, like “clock it up, Princess”, and how one day, when Mydei fell asleep in between the guitar records, Robin dressed him up with Brother Hanu’s hat and sunglasses.

They showed the studio images. They showed how Robin and Mydei hang around each other, a clip of them in the recording booth, of Robin sitting with Mydei’s jacket draped over her small shoulders. She looked gorgeous in Mydei’s jacket.

The story was so fun and engaging, and between Robin’s enthusiastic eyes and Mydei’s easy smile, Phainon forgot that half of those things had not actually happened, while the other half was pre-planned on a PowerPoint deck with stock images as pose references. Their deal started in Mnestia Tower, not Ratio’s studio. Phainon was actually there, allowing it to happen, and yet…

Phainon found himself nodding before he could stop. Even his body was buying the lie.

Everything felt so believable.

Phainon had lost track of which parts of Robin and Mydei’s story were fake anymore because everything had felt so real.

“... I think what people would really like about this EP is how crazy talented Rob actually is,” Mydei said, answering Titans know what question Owlbert asked. Phainon must have zoned out. “I can’t say much for now, you’ll have to find out when the EP is released, but I’ll say that she has insane range. When I saw her in the recording booth, I was thinking, ‘Holy Strife, Mom would have loved meeting this woman.’ And the whole band, Hep, Dikkas, and Leon, anyone who has met Mom at some point, they agreed with me. She’s *that* amazing.”

The studio let out a loud, excited cheer, followed by a round of applause. It rang out like confirmation of what Phainon didn’t dare define. Owlbert cooed again, and Mydei blinked, as if only realizing what his word meant to the audience. Robin only smiled, patting his thigh and making a small, coy laugh.

And Phainon couldn’t help but compare himself to her.

Mydei had never once said anything about Gorgo in that context. Would she love Phainon? Would she accept that her son is dating him and not some talented female singer who could inherit *her throne*?

And if she’s still alive, if she’s still here, would Phainon even have a chance with Mydei at all?

Phainon, get a grip.

What were you thinking?

No, no. He’s just exhausted. Mydei did not mean it that way. He just admired her as an artist, and only referred to his mom in a way that she would have loved to meet Robin in *an artistic way*.

Don’t read too much into it, Phainon.

You’re just too exhausted.

Turn around. Go somewhere else.

Don’t watch anymore.

Phainon debated whether to sleep on the hotel's lobby couch. However, the next segment of the interview caught his attention.

"... Ro, Mydei, did you know that long before this, people have been like… shipping you two together?"

Robin and Mydei paused, glancing at each other. Mydei is looking a bit confused.

"To where?" Mydei asked.

The studio laughed, and Robin chuckled. "Shipping is like pairing two people together. Like rooting for us as a couple??"

Mydei raised his brows. "Really? I didn't know that."

"Yeah, figured," Owlbert added. "It had been circling around on the internet for years now. One of our creative team members, who has been your longtime shipper, recently noticed something someone brought up online. I'm sure everyone has seen that thread about Mydei's choker."

The audience made an excited *oooh* sound, as well as a laugh.

Phainon could feel his heart plummet; almost at the same time, Mydei straightened in his seat.

"What about it?" he said, his voice was flat and almost robotic.

"Right, so it's been your constant accessory since you went public with Robin. And we're dying to know. Is that choker a sign of your loyalty to Robin?"

Phainon's eyes went wide, and his shock must have been mirrored in Mydei's too. He blinked rapidly, completely losing his composure for a split second before forcing himself into the smile he reserved for the public.

"Um… pardon?" he said, voice catching on the edges of hesitation.

“You know,” Owlbert leaned in conspiratorially, lowering his tone as if sharing state secrets. “Every hardcore Robin fan knows about her bullet-sized scar on her neck. And recently, someone made a side-by-side comparison. Turns out, the metal stud on your choker sits exactly where her scar is. Same spot. Same angle. We actually have the picture. Can we show it?”

The screen shifted. Owlbert, Mydei, and Robin’s image shrank to one corner, and a meticulous fan-made graphic appeared in the main frame. Robin’s neck scar was circled in neon pink, Mydei’s choker stud highlighted in bright green, with lines, angles, and degrees crisscrossing the display like a crime board.

“…and it’s been the talk of the internet,” Owlbert continued, his grin widening. “That you wear the choker to match her. Because Mydei, you’re known for your symbolism, aren’t you? So… anything to confirm for the curious fans?”

He ended with a chuckle, throwing it out lightly, but the effect was anything but. Mydei sat frozen, completely flabbergasted. His eyes flicked once toward Robin, once toward the screen, before landing back on Owlbert. He hesitated, looking as though he had run out of words entirely.

Phainon could feel the warmth in his heart freeze entirely as he watched how their quiet signal, the safe, secret code that they agreed on, the very last line that he could hold onto, got rewritten by the public once again, and Mydei must have been just as shocked. He must not have known what to say without breaking the ruse.

And even if he could think of something in that short time window, he was not fast enough. Because in the next second, the audience had already erupted in a long, knowing “ooooh.”

Owlbert flicked his fingers. “Folks,” he said, solemnly. “I think we got the answer.”

The audience laughed, shouted, and erupted in another round of applause as Mydei’s face turned a little red. Robin held his hand, letting a soft chuckle,

and apparently, decided to step in.

“Oh, Owlbert, I think we’re all just reading a little too much into it,” she said, answering for Mydei as if shielding him. Her hand slipped over his, a light squeeze—supportive, almost protective. Maybe that’s what it was. Robin jumped in to save the day.

“I mean, everyone knows Mydei likes to wear things fans have given him, right?” she went on brightly. “So I think it’s just that. It’s not… It’s not that deep?”

She was trying to defuse it. She was trying to save the whole situation, because Mydei still looked too startled to answer, even as he forced himself back into that practiced smile.

It’s not that deep.

No, she was just trying to help and not make it any worse.

It’s not that deep.

Phainon could feel his stomach drop, his throat close up. He could still feel the leather of that choker between his fingers. He remembered the morning he put it on him. The quiet signal, something Mydei wouldn’t let be corrupted by anyone else.

It’s not that deep.

The lies flowed so smoothly, so naturally. The story was flawless, polished, perfectly believable. Sometimes Phainon himself struggled to believe it was fake. What if Mydei struggled too?

What if he woke up one day and thought he deserved someone better than Phainon?

What if he woke up one day and decided he was sick of the distance that was constantly stretched between them? The short, delayed messages, and yearning for someone who could go with him on tours, understand his world, and lift him to his full potential? Mydei had always wanted that,

right? He always wanted someone, *a house husband* who could go with him everywhere.

What if he no longer wanted this kind of relationship?

Mydei always thrives better when there's a talented woman by his side.

And what if it was better for Mydei? What if that's all he needed to be the superstar he was destined to be?

The talk show carried on, laughter and applause rising and falling in the background, but Phainon no longer heard any of it. Mydei's voice was gone, tuned out into static.

The hotel receptionist finally handed him his key. He muttered a *thank you* he didn't remember, dragged himself down the silent corridor, and collapsed onto the queen bed without even removing his shoes.

His head throbbed. His body screamed for rest. But even as his limbs sagged into the mattress, his mind refused to shut down—circling, gnawing, replaying the image of Robin's hand over Mydei's and the audience's "ooooh."

You're thinking too much into it, Phainon thought. *You're exhausted. It was all a ruse. Only half of it was true.*

But which part? Mydei could lie seamlessly in the camera. Where does his performance end and the truth begin?

Are you seriously thinking about it right now? He loves you. Nothing was real about him and Robin.

Which part of it wasn't real?

You agreed to this, Phainon. You said so yourself. Nothing would surprise you with how clean Aventurine planned it.

Which part of it wasn't real?

Mydei's words rang in his mind. "*As if you're okay with the idea of me being in a relationship with someone else.*"

Is it really a bad thing if you do? So long as it makes you a happier, better man, why would I object to that? I love you, Mydeimos. I love you enough to let you go.

No, I will die the moment Mydei lets me go.

Then don't. He wanted you to tell him. He was angry that morning before he left with Robin.

So you'd rather rob him of what he truly deserved? The destiny he should have lived? How selfish could you be?

I love him.

Then why are you still holding him back?

"Stop!" Phainon rasped to himself. "I'm so exhausted."

He crumpled a handful of sheets in his fist, whimpering to himself. His head felt so unbelievably heavy with the overlapping thoughts.

"Mom, I'm so *so* exhausted."

His phone was ringing nonstop, the high-pitched sound banging on his skull so painfully that Phainon decided to put it back to airplane mode just to silence it. He cried into the sheets. He was hungry. His throat was dry. There were two bottles of water on the nightstand. They were too far to reach. He had to eat. Phainon had to call room service to get food. The landline was too far.

Why was everything so close, and yet too far for him to reach?

Phainon wanted to go home.

He would go home. Just one more two-hour flight, and he'd be home.

He closed his eyes, trying to imagine his mom’s homemade Suncake. The freshness of her homemade Olive Juice. Maybe even a warm meatloaf from Galba. He missed those so much. Why did it feel like he hadn’t been home in months, when he’d only been flying for a week?

Oh. Aedes Elysiae was no longer his home.

He had built his own home in Okhema City.

But that wasn’t his home either. The three-bedroom, full kitchen, patio penthouse in the heart of Okhema City with direct highway access to the airport, was far beyond Phainon's salary. That was Mydei’s home.

Not Phainon’s.

He closed his eyes and imagined that he was in Aedes Elysiae.

He really really wanted to go home.

-

To his delight, he was back in Aedes Elysiae.

Phainon lay in the wheat field, warm sunshine gentle on his face as he stared at the endless blue, watching a silver jet slice the sky in two like a blade of iron in amazement.

“That’s a Concorde,” he said, pointing his finger at the sky. “The supersonic jet. The coolest, fastest, best passenger plane ever built. I’ll fly it one day.”

Piso, his childhood friend, laughed beside him. “That plane’s so big, Phainon. Could you really handle it?”

“Of course,” Phainon puffed his chest. “I’ll try my best!”

“So you promise you won’t hold back its full potential,” Piso’s voice shifted, warmer, deeper—“like you do with me, *fos mou*?”

Phainon’s head snapped to the side. He expected to see Piso’s smile. Instead, he braced for Mydei’s face—

And found only a hotel wall.

Phainon could hear his heart pound in the same rhythm as his alarm.

Just a dream. Just a dream. Just a dream.

It was just his evil thought playing tricks with him. The room was too cold. He was too exhausted. There’s no way Mydei would say that. His using the nickname he reserved for Phainon during intimate moments was also wrong. That name was reserved for specific moments, spoken in a particular tone, behind a locked door.

He’s just tired, hollowed out from the inside out, and he needed to replenish so he could think straight again.

Phainon rolled off the bed and realized he was still in his uniform, his shoes still on, and his throat so unbelievably dry he had to get up and reach out to the water bottle on the nightstand to relieve him from the pain. He checked the clock and, realizing he still had a few hours until the flight to home base, he quickly took a shower, brushed his teeth, and went down to the ground floor for the buffet breakfast.

All while ignoring the hollowness that persisted.

The clink of silverware and soft hum of morning voices filled the hotel dining room. Phainon barely registered any of it. His mind was focused only on the day's schedule, and as he tried to access his email, he realized his phone was still in airplane mode.

Oh crap. A full nighttime airplane mode. Mydei would have his head.

That is, if he still cared about Phainon.

When he switched off airplane mode, his phone blew up with messages and missed call notifications that overlapped each other, and Phainon couldn't even catch up anymore. They mostly came from Cyrene, Cae, Stelle, Dan Heng, and…

And Mydei.

Phainon had Mydei's number pinned on top of his message app, so it was what he saw first. There were fifteen new unread chats that clawed harder on the hollowness in Phainon's chest.

He took a deep breath, swallowing the rest of his hash brown and pomegranate juice before he finally pressed *open*.

My Day Mouse <3
That's a nice hotel.
Yeah we should
When everything ends.
HKS call me when u land
Pls call me.
Dont watch ONL.
Dont open social media.
Call me.
U cant fly this late
R u sleeping?
U must be sleeping
Good night. Swt dreams x.
By Kephale, call me.
HKS
Call me when u wake up x.

And then there were five missed calls underneath the last message.

Mydei must have been really antsy after that live interview. He sounded really panicked, and Phainon felt really guilty that he couldn't even pick up the phone. Mydei must have thought about it all night. The last time he fired this many messages at once was when his father suddenly called him.

As if summoned by the ache in Phainon’s chest, the screen lit up again.

Mydei was calling him.

Phainon’s reflexes were faster than his thoughts, because the next time he knew was that his phone was to his ear, and Mydei’s relieved sigh was heard.

“Thank fuck you finally pick up,” he said. “Where have you been? I was worried.”

“Um… Styxia?” Phainon said. His voice was quiet, flat, almost like he didn’t cry himself to sleep the night before. “For work. I thought I already told you.”

“You did, but you said you’re gonna land at eight Okhema time, and your phone has been off all night,” Mydei said. “Did you see my messages? Did you watch Owlbert Night Live?”

Phainon hummed. He didn’t want to talk about the live interview. He wished to continue pretending it had not happened, even if only for one more day. But Mydei sounded desperate. He sounded panicked, and Phainon knew how bad it felt. He did not want Mydei to go through that.

“Mmm, I went straight to sleep when I got to the hotel,” he said, before his brain even registered the white lie. It was so smooth and innocent, it almost terrified him. But again, if he’s being technical, it wasn’t completely a lie. He slept as soon as he hit the bed.

That white lie eroded him regardless, burning on his teeth like molten lava, and Phainon wanted to die because he hated lying, much less to the person he loved the most.

But isn’t that how things worked in Mydei’s world? You smoothed over the truth with something easier to swallow, then left deliberate gaps for others to fill in with their own assumptions.

He wanted to fit into Mydei's other side of the wall. Might as well do as they do.

Mydei did not seem to bat an eye while doing it on camera.

"Should I watch it?" Phainon added.

"I can't stop you if you want, but I gotta warn you, it's a fucking mess," Mydei said. There was a tremble in his voice, like he was trying to hold himself back from cursing off Aquila and the entire sky. "I messed up so bad, HKS. I'm being fucking stupid on live TV and I gotta apologize to you because I promised I would make it right and I ruined that in the first chance I've got."

He sounded so desperate, and Phainon didn't know how to behave, as if he didn't know what to, causing him to sound like that, when he knew exactly why.

So he only let out a weak chuckle, trying to downplay it. "Calm down, 'Dei," he said. "Whatever it is, it couldn't be that bad."

"No, *it is* that bad," Mydei answered, sounding really devastated that Phainon actually felt his heart break alongside him. Phainon couldn't imagine what it felt like to be under so many eyes, a bright light, and a few cameras pointing at him, recording everything he said to be broadcast to millions of people. The weight of it alone could crush him.

Mydei sometimes still had nightmares about it, and he had been in the industry for years.

"I'm such a total idiot, HKS. I'm sorry I'm being so fuckin' naive that…"

"Hey now, 'Dei," Phainon said gently, trying to soothe Mydei as if he were there with him. It was a rare moment where Mydei would ramble about how stupid he was, a crawl into a panic if he allowed Mydei to continue rambling. He had to interrupt now. " It's just a choker, don't worry. I know you must have tried your best. You don't have to beat yourself up about it, okay? Calm down."

There was no answer on the other side of the phone. It grew so eerily quiet that Phainon had to look at his screen to ensure the line was not cut.

"'Dei?"

"Phainon," Mydei said. Quietly, coldly, warily.

And Phainon had known that he had messed up, even before Mydei continued.

"I've never said anything about the choker."

Fuck.

The silverware in his other hand slipped and fell onto the fine china as Phainon felt the heat rise to his cheek; the shame of being caught quickly consumed him. His breath hitched, and Mydei must have known that. Even though he didn't see him, Mydei must have noticed because then he spoke again.

"Did you see the Owlbert talk show, Phainon?"

Phainon's heart raced so fast he felt like he was gonna combust.

"You did, didn't you?"

He's so *so* screwed.

"Khaslana!"

"Okay, yes, I watched it a little!" Phainon finally choked out. He clenched his jaws, breathing through his mouth. His heart continued to race, pounding inside him like a rabid rabbit. "It's not a big deal. Titans, 'Dei! Calm down."

"And yet you lie to me about it," Mydei said. His voice was low, cold, still, like the dead sea.

“Because I don’t want you to worry about me, okay?” Phainon snapped with a sharp hiss. “You’ll treat me like I’m made of glass and pull away from this… this… million credits worth of campaign. I’m fine. I’ll manage. We’ve been doing this for four years, you gotta believe in me more.”

“*Believe in you*. Right. Bold words, after I just caught you lying,” Mydei let out a humorless scoff. “I can’t even tell which part of your words was the truth, HKS. It’s all the same for me.”

Phainon could feel his heart sink. His jaws clenched, and shame burned his throat like a fire. Mydei’s mockery bounced in the hollow of his chest, filling it with the ghost of desperation that echoed in his mind just a few hours ago.

I’m only following your lead. I’m sorry. I just wasn’t comfortable talking about it when you were just a choppy voice on my speakerphone.

Which one of them was true? Phainon did not know anymore.

“And you’re not gonna tell me about it?” Mydei asked. His voice was so cold that it almost sounded flat, and it hurt Phainon because it felt like Mydei had decided that Phainon no longer deserved his emotions: his anger, his love, *none*.

“What’s the point?” Phainon asked, voice just as weak, cracking on the edges, as he stabbed the remaining part of his hash brown with his fork. “You’re just going to say that you’re quitting everything. You know I don’t want you to do that, ‘Dei. There’s too much at stake and—”

“And nothing,” Mydei insisted. There was a spark of anger there. “I never want any of this to happen. I told you. I told you times and times again, Phainon. I’d rather just quit.”

Quit what? The relationship? The collaboration? The ruse? Phainon couldn’t be sure anymore, and at this point, he was far too afraid to ask. He did not want Mydei to quit the collaboration for his sake; it could hurt the band. He did not wish Mydei to stop the ruse. It would hurt his reputation. He did not want to lose Mydei…

Except… what if it had happened?

Phainon had already lost Mydei to the world, anyway, to the narrative built by the public. For them, Phainon did not exist. And now, Mydei had been disappointed in him. Soon enough, he'd known that Phainon was not the right fit for his world.

Not the right person for him.

"Khaslana, for fuck's sake," Mydei barked. His voice broke; with pain, with desperation, with anger. Phainon wasn't sure. "Talk to me."

Phainon closed his eyes. "'Dei, can we not discuss it over the phone? Let's talk about it when I'm back, okay? I'll be in Okhema in six hours. I…"

… I want to do this right. I want to see you. I want you to know that I'm fine. I could keep up with your world. I could rise to your sky, too. But I can't do it here in a city I am not familiar with. I'd rather we do it in the safety of our sanctuary, where we're invincible and no one could touch us. Please, please…

He couldn't say that out loud, not after his betrayal.

"... Please."

There was a sharp inhale, another pause, and a flicker of unspoken heartbreak that Phainon could feel filling in the silence. He could feel his chest burn. His shoulders were heavy with the weight of his own lies.

"I can't be home until Monday," Mydei said. "I'm in Epsilon. There's a typhoon forecasted tonight."

Epsilon. Eight-hour flight, not including the delays that could possibly happen in typhoon season. The Southern Hemisphere was always weird. Phainon would know. He got weather reports of it every now and then.

"I'll… be back on Wednesday," Phainon said. "I've got a short regional on Monday afternoon. I'll be back Wednesday morning."

There was another sharp, defeated intake of breath. “Fine,” he said. “But if you’re ready to talk before then, call me. Alright? If I don’t pick up, call Krateros. If he doesn’t pick up, call Hephaestion. He’s always on his phone. Please do that, *Phainon*. Please. Talk to me.”

“Okay,” Phainon said. “I promise.”

Mydei hummed, and Phainon could see the scoff underneath that.

What good was a promise now? He’d already lied. What’s another?

“Alright,” Mydei said. “See you then.”

“See you, ‘Dei. I love you.”

The sweet words he said with his whole heart tasted the same as the lie he just told Mydei.

“Love you, HKS.”

There was another stretch of silence from Mydei’s side, like he was waiting for something. But then, exactly five seconds later, he hung up the phone.

Phainon wondered what that was about until he remembered it.

The kisses.

Phainon always demands kisses before they part. Now, he was so fucked up he even forgot that.

Phainon placed his phone back on the table, staring at the unanswered messages, and realized how easily he lied. How easily he offered something that he dreaded, so that he could put off that uncomfortable feeling of having to talk about it.

As he cleaned up his plate, went back to his room, and saw his flight plan for Okhema City, he felt even more hollow.

Although he was flying home base, he felt he was drifting further away from home.

-

Phainon had tried to follow Dan Heng's advice to stay off the grid and avoid the news about Mydei.

He tried.

Still, even though he had his phone sat deep in his pocket, even though he actively did not look at the news or social media during his journey to and from the airport, Phainon couldn't seem to escape the #LionDove.

It was *everywhere*.

Phainon could even piece together what happened during the rest of the talk show just from overhearing about it here and there. Mydei and *Rob* sang Goddess live. Mydei got so flustered that he avoided *Rob*'s eyes. Mydei stared at her like she was a goddess. They're such a couple goal. *Rob*'s so in love. *Rob*'s so lucky to have Mydei.

Rob completed Mydei perfectly. They're truly a couple of royalty.

And as he glanced at the TV, watching their duet on repeat, he couldn't even argue with it.

They looked so great together.

Their chemistry was so great that they could even revive the spirit of Queen Gorgo.

Together, there was nothing that they couldn't do.

Those words echoed in every corner of what little world Phainon passed by between his flight and his home. Their presence was so massive that by the time Phainon was finally back at their apartment, Mydei's absence was so palpable.

And without him, the house felt too large, too empty, matching too perfectly with the hollow that sat deep inside Phainon's chest.

This felt like a place of abandon, with Mydei's spices, cooking utensils, his boxes of meal prep in the refrigerator, the painting he bought at a charity auction, his perfume, his boxes of sponsored shoes…

This was Mydei's home. The evidence of his presence was everywhere, and yet, this house was so void of him.

Phainon sat on the kitchen's stool, staring at Mydei's last chat. He had stopped pestering him about the talk show, only messaging Phainon about his schedule and his day, hinting at it in a short message: *"Tell me if you're ready.*"

Phainon had replied with '*Wednesday, okay?*'

And that was another lie.

Because Phainon had just received approval to switch his short regional week for an ultra-long-haul flight, which meant flying two 16-hour legs and spending three days on a layover.

He wouldn't be back to Okhema until next Wednesday.

Technically, it wasn't a lie.

He'd still see Mydei on Wednesday. Only a week apart from what he promised.

It felt like a foul play, like another lie. But Phainon really couldn't face Mydei when the burning shame was still eating his heart. He closed his phone, and as the night crawled deeper, Phainon could no longer stand the quiet of their apartment.

The isolation of not being able to talk about his worries with his friends, the alienation of not even being able to access his phone in the risk of Mydei - Robin exposure, the looming guilt of lying to Mydei, the burning shame of getting caught, the crushing weight of seeing Mydei anywhere but here in their sanctuary…

No.

He couldn’t do this.

Phainon packed his suitcase and decided to book the cheapest flight he could find. He didn’t care where it went. He wouldn’t even board the plane. He just wanted to get a boarding pass to use his perk on the VIP lounge—the only place he could think of getting rest without having to bear the quiet of the empty room. At least there, there would be strangers, noise, and fluorescent lights.

If he had to sleep on another recliner to get that, then so be it.

When morning came, Phainon went to clock in to HQ, volunteering his day off to train new cadets. This was a nice plan. Those young kids care more about the Okhema Gladiators game than they do about celebrity gossip. The simulators were time-consuming enough to distract him from the hollow in his chest, and the nap pod near the training room was a perfect place to sleep at night.

This was a safe place to be off-grid.

Some Ground Crew Members who knew him eyed him with questions, while others directly wondered why he was there. Phainon only smiled. He lied through his teeth.

He was surprised by how easy lying had become.

And so, as Monday came, he jumped back into the hamster wheel that was his job.

While multiple short legs felt like a marathon, ultra-long-haul flights offered a different kind of torture—a sixteen-hour game between keeping his eyes on the throttle, lulled by the stagnant, hypnotizing hum of the machine during his rotation, or half-sleeping in a coffin-sized crew bunk during his off time.

Between the hassle of takeoff and landing, there was so little to do, and so much time to think about the impending doom of his relationship.

His life felt too much like cruising on autopilot, now. There are so many people on board, and yet he felt so alone. Phainon had stopped replying to his friends' messages asking about his well-being, beyond an "I'm fine, how are you?" He used what little remained of his energy to respond to Mydei's message, who was still telling him about his days, sending him selfies, and sharing everything he had done to fill the gap during his absence.

Which, honestly, felt more obligatory now.

He returned with the same dry enthusiasm. Maintaining his jokes, teases, flirtations, all the sweet things that felt like a love letter from Icarus to the sun. It was nice while it lasted, but soon enough, as Icarus flew any closer, he would burn.

Because he never meant to be in the sky.

It was stupid enough for Icarus to think he ever belonged in the sky.

He still loved Mydei, sure. But Phainon knew his place. He knew that he wasn't enough for Mydei. He never would be enough, compared to Robin or Misia or whoever celebrity out there. Mydei would be better off with them. He didn't know it yet now, but soon as Phainon was out of his sight, he would see it.

But he couldn't give that thought, away now. Because then Mydei would be stupid about it. He'd threaten to stop everything, and the collapse of the whole campaign, the PR disaster that would follow, the fall of Chrysos Records and Sons of Gorgo and everything, would be all Phainon's fault.

Phainon couldn’t allow that to happen.

He couldn’t drag Mydei down.

It would hurt both of them, but Mydei would move on.

He would be alright.

Over the past few days, Mydei has asked multiple times whether Phainon is ready to talk about it. Phainon only said, “later. We could talk about it when we meet. It’ll be alright.”

A lie he repeated so often, he started to believe it.

Because soon enough, the bombardment of the PR stunt did not even faze him anymore.

The mention of Robin as Queen Gorgo’s future daughter-in-law, as the universe will. He was alright with it.

The image of Mydei and Robin on the billboard. The tabloid cover of them together, the Blow Me Away music video that was played everywhere, showing Mydei and Robin holding each other, gazing at each other’s eyes, with Robin as a goddess and Mydei in his Greek Regalia that was once inhabited in his fantasy…

It was alright.

He didn’t feel anything anymore.

He walked past everything like an average person watching another celebrity on the screen.

Because that was what they were—he was an average person, and Mydei a celebrity.

Mydei’s choker was still there, latched to his neck despite the fashion he wore. But it meant nothing for Phainon now. His story was overwritten, and with how much it was shoved to him, how much he lied about it, Mydei

would soon believe it too. He would soon fully integrate into that world on the other side of Phainon's metaphorical glass walls.

And the Mydei he knew, the Mydei he betrayed with his lies, was reduced to a couple of pixelated words on his phone screen, occasional blurred selfies, and choppy calls tainted with exhaustions and unspoken accusations.

The line grew quieter and quieter between them, but Phainon had made peace with it, too.

He had mentally prepared for that possibility so that he wouldn't be completely pathetic when it happened. He would hold his head high, smile through it, and perhaps, if Mydei allowed him, give him the last hug, before they forever part ways, and Phainon would be a nameless face among many —a ghost in Mydei's private history.

It was hurt, at first. He cried whenever he thought about it. But Phainon ran over that scenario in his mind over and over again, until it no longer stirred his heart.

On the second day of his rest in the layover hotel in Sigonia, Phainon got a call from Cartonus, who said that his commissioned rings, the ones he had matched with Mydei, were ready. He just had to come to the shop for the final fitting on his own ring.

Phainon was so caught up with all the fake-relationship stunts that he completely forgot about the commission. Forgot about his intention to actually propose to Mydei.

He stared at the photo Cartonus had sent: a set of rings he had commissioned for Mydei featured a blue gemstone, the color of Phainon's eyes, a metaphor for the world, because Phainon would carry it for Mydei. Give him the world, as he promised.

And his own ring had a golden gemstone in the exact shade of Mydei's eyes —a metaphor for the sun. A reminder of the name Mydei gave him, the name whispered to him in the most intimate moment. *Fos mou*—my light.

Why did he even call Phainon *my light*? Why did Phainon never ask?

He pondered that question once, but decided that it was far too late to even think about it. He continued to admire the rings. They were beautiful. It was Cartonus, after all. His craft was always great. But even then, it felt like a mockery to Phainon's pain.

He mourned and was grateful in equal measure for the missed chance to propose to Mydei.

What would Mydei be, if he stuck forever with someone like Phainon?

Phainon paid Cartonus the remaining bill, asking him to keep the rings for him in the meantime. He didn't know how long *the meantime* would be. He didn't know if he'd ever picked them up. He wouldn't know what to do with them if he did.

He put his phone down, asking Velite, his fellow pilot, the cost of a 1 LDK apartment rent near the Okhema Airport while Mydei and Robin's music video played on the pub's TV screen.

Phainon didn't even turn his head. He was too busy thinking about the probability of moving.

The world spun around him so fast, and suddenly, he was dragging his suitcase across Okhema Airport.

Strangely enough, despite the numbness that had clouded his mind for the past ten days, he still dreaded coming back to that apartment. He didn't know what he feared more: seeing Mydei… or the suffocating emptiness of home. The skeletons of the trust they once had, or the ghost of what once lived there.

But he braved himself. It's where most of his stuff was, after all.

As he opened the door, he walked into Mydei sitting on the couch of their living room, with a half-empty bottle of Ambrosia in front of him. He bowed his head so deeply that his wild blond mane covered his face. Most

of his clothes were scattered on the floor around him, leaving him only in his black silk pants.

He looked vulnerable. Like an angel with broken wings.

Mydei shot his head up when he heard the door open, his flushed face lit up as their eyes met.

“HKS, is that really you?” his voice was deep, hoarse, slurred. Relief washed over him when he blinked and saw Phainon like he saw the sun. “Oh, thank fuck it’s you.”

Before Phainon could say anything, before he could even say hello, Mydei pulled him into a hug, chuckling as he scattered butterfly kisses across his face.

“I miss you, I miss you, I miss you, *fos mou*,” he whispered. His voice was shaky, like he was crying.

Phainon chuckled. “You always call me that,” he said. “But I thought I never ask what it means.”

“Because sun,” Mydei coughed, the tips of his fingers brushing on Phainon’s tattoo. “Eyes. Soul. Heart like *the sun*. *My sun*."

Phainon’s smile faltered while Mydei whispered more words in Kremnoans, the ones Phainon didn’t know. He pressed his lips on Phainon’s sun tattoo, then he stopped.

“Oh,” he sighed. “I forgot. Here. Look at me.”

He pulled something from his pants pocket. A black tiny tube that turned out to be a bright red lipstick, once he pulled the cap. Mydei let out a cheeky sneer as he put it on him.

He looked so carefree, so tipsy, that Phainon almost felt like this was one of his better dreams, if it weren’t for the sharp musk of Mydei’s perfume mixed with his sweat.

“Remember that photo of Samoyed with red lipstick all over his fur?” he chuckled. He looked a little like Queen Gorgo now. Blonde hair, confident sneer, wild eyes, red lips. He looked too much like a celebrity. “Watch me remake that now.”

He pressed his lips all across Phainon’s face, on his hair, on the corner of his eyes, leaving a sticky, oily feeling on Phainon’s skin like airport stamps. And it would have been cute, it would have been sexy if it weren’t for the fact that Mydei’s face was red.

And not in a way that he’s flushed by alcohol.

Mydei, like most Kremnoans that Phainon knew, had a high tolerance of substances. Half a bottle of Ambrosia wouldn’t get him this bad.

His cheeks and eyes were red, as if he had been crying.

“‘Dei…”

“Ssh,” Mydei chuckled. “You’re so pretty, *fos mou*.”

My light. And Phainon should answer it with *Yours, Kotik*.

Could he? Did he still have the right to say so?

“I missed you so much. ‘t feels like you’re there in the sky and I can’t fucking reach you. Why are you always so far away on the other side of the world?”

The accusation and the nickname somehow pulled out the dread from Phainon’s stomach. He tried to pull away, but Mydei caged him on the spot, burying his face on Phainon’s nape.

“By Strife, your smell,” he whispered. “It’s been so *so* long. Do you want to feel good? Let me make you feel good, ‘kay? Let me take care of’ya.”

Mydei dropped to his knees before Phainon could stop him, struggling to loosen Phainon’s belt with his head half clouded. He gave up halfway and just mouthed on Phainon’s pants. He chuckled when Phainon shivered.

“I can make ‘im red too now,” he cupped Phainon’s bulge. Mydei looked so childish, so innocent, so wrong. He pressed his nose to Phainon’s pants’ zipper. Oh, no. He’s not…

“‘Dei! No,” Phainon hissed, trying to haul him back up. “Don’t do that. You’ve got a tour coming on. You’ll hate it when you’re sober and your throat is busted.”

“Fuck the show,” Mydei growled, eyes flashing as he clung harder. “Please, for once, let me have this, please, please, *fos mou*.”

The plea in his voice, the desperation in Mydei’s eyes as he tried to mouth Phainon’s bulge, it broke Phainon’s heart. But he couldn’t do that. Mydei’s throat could go sore. He had a tour coming up. He couldn’t let ruin Mydei’s career because of his drunken antics.

“Yes, *Kotik*, sure. But not tonight—”

“Is it b’cause the lipstick? You hate it? We’ll ditch it,” he wiped his lips with his hand roughly, smearing it further across his cheek. He started to look wilder now.

“No, it’s not that. You’ve got a show tomorrow, right? We could just—”

Mydei’s eyes flickered with something raw: like a mix of hurt, shame, and betrayal.

As if he couldn’t believe that Phainon had rejected him.

Phainon’s breath hitched. But he did not even have time to speak as Mydei pushed to his feet.

“Fine, get the fuck off me,” he growled, the red color of shame smeared over his cheeks as he grabbed the Ambrosia’s bottle back. “If my career is more important to you than me, then fine, I’ll get the fuck out.”

“‘Dei, c’mon, I’m just taking care of you.”

“Yeah, cause that’s all you do, isn’t it? *Taking care of me*. You’ve used that reason to lie to my face. Why not deny me with such heroic reason, too, right?” he chuckled bitterly. “All for Mydeimos Gorgo’s sake. For his career. Cause he’s nothing without all of that crap.”

Phainon clenched his jaws. “You’re rambling now, ‘Dei,” he said. “Please, we’re both exhausted. Please don’t do this.”

“Then *when* are we gonna *do this*?” Mydei barked back, mocking Phainon in his own words. “You think I’m gonna let you run away from me another week? Another month? Another year? Are you gonna keep lying to me? Punishing me for my slip-up, even though I fucking hold the end of my deal?”

Phainon’s brain scrambled. What the fuck did he mean by slip up? He didn’t make any sense. Was he more drunk than Phainon thought?

“You’re drunk, ‘Dei,” Phainon said, in the absence of a better thing to say.

“And you’re a coward, Khaslana!” Mydei shouted. “You lied, and you ran away instead of facing me. You think I didn’t know you swapped your schedule for a sixty-two-hour round-trip flight? You signed in to your email on my phone! I see every request you send to the scheduler!”

Phainon gaped. Mydei still glared at him with the fierceness of a lion. But there was a hurt, kicked little kitten in the fire of his golden eyes, the pain that Phainon could feel in the marrow of his bones.

“‘Dei…”

“Did you think you’d got me fooled, huh?” he scoffed. “What’s in it to you anyway, Phainon? Why is it so important for you that I keep this collab? What is it with that obsession to ‘live my mother’s legacy’? Am I not worthy to even look at without her shadows over me?”

Phainon’s eyes widened, and his mind flashed back to the taxi driver’s mention. To Mydei’s self-deprecating words in the studio when they talk about the music video.

My entire career is built on a woman's legacy. People already call me Mama's boy, anyway.

He's nothing like Queen Gorgo. He's not as talented. Too bad she's knocked up so early…

"No, 'Dei," Phainon croaked. His throat tightened. "I've seen you in the studio. You were beaming. Happy. Alive. That's all I ever want for you. To be happy."

"Right, and it gets you a free pass to decide what happiness is for me?" Mydei shouted. "Because only you get to decide what I should get for happiness, O Holy Deliverer?"

His condescending voice tasted so bitter in his throat that it hurt him so bad that Phainon clenched his jaws. "No, shut up, you fuckin' brute. You dragged me to Mnestia Tower, not giving me any damn clue what you'd asked. I wasn't prepared! You dove headfirst into this idea of collaboration, knowing that I would not have the heart to reject you in front of those people. You only wanted me there to nod along!" he gritted his teeth. "You've done it anyway with or without my permission!"

"Fuck you. I was hoping that the idea of me being in a relationship with someone would make you stop me," he said. "But no, of course not. You didn't even flinch at that idea!"

"And I've suffered for it!" Phainon shouted. "I've gotten what I deserve with every pain I see you walking around with a goddamn pop star, if that's what you want."

"You didn't have to!" Mydei retorted. "We could have put a stop to it. And then you act as if nothing happened and instead decide to lie to my face. Because my dead mother's legacy is far more important to you than *our relationship*."

"Stop saying like you know shit about me, Mydeimos! Stop saying shit about me not loving you because you know damn well that's not true," Phainon shouted now. He could feel tears streaming down his cheek. "I'm

sorry if I make mistakes. I’m sorry I can’t love you right. I’m sorry, I don’t fucking know how to love a Concorde. I’m sorry I keep you on the ground instead of flying you high like you meant to be, cause I suck. Cause I come from the other side of the wall and can never understand you!”

His words hitched by the fresh wave of tears. Phainon did not know how to say it in the non-aviation analogy. He’s tired, confused, and his heart is breaking into a million pieces he couldn’t begin to comprehend.

“You’re rambling, Khaslana.”

“And you’re better off with someone else!”

Phainon’s words echo in the room, and Mydei flinched. His eyes widened. His clenched jaws, his balled fists, everything was let loose in the face of Phainon’s words.

No.

“Mydei—”

“Tell me you don’t mean it,” Mydei said. “Look at me and tell me, Phainon."

He wanted to take that back. He wanted to apologize, kneel, and do anything to take that back. But Phainon froze where he stood, his words hanging in the air.

And Mydei took his silence as an answer.

“So that’s it?” Mydei asked. His voice was weaker, a sign of surrender. “So that’s how it’s gonna be? You’re just gonna give up?”

Phainon knew he had to say something. He had to fight for his relationship. But he had rehearsed this in his mind, and in all of his scenarios, he gave him up.

Because he never thought that Mydei would ever want him to stay.

He never thought that Mydei was insecure about his mother. He never thought that behind Mydei’s cool rockstar bravado, he hid that kind of feeling.

All he thought was that he didn’t deserve to be with someone like Mydei.

And maybe it was the truth, like the fact that Phainon didn’t know Mydei all that well was also the truth.

“Whatever happened with you being willing to make it work?” Mydei scoffed. “Coward.”

Mydei turned around, and Phainon knew he had to stop him. He had to speak now, or he’d forever lose him. Mydeimos Gorgo. The love of his life. The owner of the ring that Phainon had commissioned, Cartonus, the man for whom he would do anything in this world, was walking out without looking back.

“‘Dei…”

His voice was too weak.

“Mydei, wait—”

But he was a bit too late. Mydei slammed the door behind him, leaving Phainon alone, among the ruins of what once was their sanctuary.

Chapter End Notes

The better part is coming I promise!

Thank you for reading!

Chapter 6: Mirror

Chapter Summary

> Phainon dealt with Post-breakup hollowness and found his answer in an unexpected way.

Chapter Notes

> Hi! Apologies for the long, long chapter! I did promise that this will be the last, but then it got so long that I have to split it in two chapters so it's not too exhausting to read.
> Also, as always, a big thank you for my girl Norii for going through through this journey :D I owe you a wholleee lot for this! >.<
>
> I hope you enjoy it!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon froze where Mydei left him, gaze fixated on the polished wood of their door as the heavy silence stretched, tearing his heart in pieces.

He should chase Mydei, pull him back, apologize—they could fix this, because they’re stronger than any PR stunt, and Phainon promised to be the best boyfriend who ever existed.

And yet he didn’t move.

Seconds stretched, pulling Mydei further away from him. Phainon knew that it would be too late to run to get Mydei now, but he could still call him, beg him to stay, text him a string of apologies, send out voice notes, anything, *anything* to tell Mydei that he wanted to fix this. He wanted them to stay together.

Still, he didn’t move.

Phainon wasn’t sure if he still had the right to do it.

Because he was the one who pushed Mydei into the fake relationship, despite Mydei repeatedly offering to end it, he insisted on enduring it, even though he was troubled. He was the one who lied, despite Mydei begging him to be honest. He was the one who denied him, despite Mydei's desperation.

The image of Mydei's drunken smile automatically replayed by his mind in slow motion, how his expression turned into shock, into a shame that flushed his skin as he realized that Phainon rejected him, the anger that bubbled under his skin, and exploded in Phainon's face…

You're a coward, Khaslana. He was. He knew he was.

You don't even care. Wrong. He cared too much; he would give Mydei everything.

Am I not worthy to even look at without her shadows? Phainon never even liked Queen Gorgo's music. He didn't know who she was before he came to Okhema.

Get the fuck off me. Was that your wish, too? Because Phainon would do it. He would disappear if that were what Mydei wanted.

No, he was gone. They were done.

It was all over.

The realization punched air out of him. Phainon's vision began to blur as his mind replayed that word over and over.

Mydei wouldn't come back.

It crushed him, as if the world had collapsed onto his chest; how alone he was, how suffocating this room that was supposed to be his home. How foreign was this place where he once slept next to his favorite warmth and ate homemade food made by caring hands.

The caring hands were far out of his reach now.

Phainon had thought about this a million times over for the past week. He knew it would happen. It was just too obvious. Mydei was a star—born for the world to admire him. And Phainon was just… well, *Phainon*. A country boy from Aedes Elysiae who once dared to challenge him and somehow stayed.

It never mattered how much he tried to be worthy of Mydei, because they were not the same; they would never stand as equals.

And yet, why did it hurt so much?

Was it because his incompetence felt so public? Like, instead of a private confirmation of his inadequacy to be with Mydei, the whole world told him that there will always be someone who is better than him. The entire world reminded him how small and unimportant he was. No matter what he did, he would never be like Robin.

Were their endless words on social media hurt his ego so bad that it hurt so much?

Why did it bother him? They were not wrong.

Did it even matter? His ego? Their opinions? What did it matter now that Mydei's gone?

He's gone.

And he's not going away in a quiet aloofness that Phainon always imagined Mydei would be. He walked away, betrayed. Denied. His accusatory words bounced inside Phainon's empty head, the image of his angry face plastered on the back of his eyelids, burned there like a brand.

You hurt him.

He wouldn't hurt for long. Mydei would be okay. The whole world loved him.

Still, you hurt him.

Mydei was drunk. He was probably just pent-up, exhausted, and emotional.

You said you'd be the best boyfriend ever.

Phainon could be wrong. He could overestimate himself. He tended to do that. He was once convinced that he could fly a Concorde, only to have his dream crushed because he had to pack so many hours before he could even dream of taking the exam, and by the time Phainon could do it, Concorde was officially grounded forever.

What does it matter now, anyway? Mydei's gone. His promise meant nothing.

Nothing mattered anymore.

He's gone. *He's gone.*

Phainon walked to the couch where Mydei sat earlier, curling himself into a fetal position as he pressed his face to the soft fabric, engulfing himself in the remains of Mydei's presence. He could feel it gradually dampened by his tears. By the time he realized he was crying, his tears dropped uncontrollably, and Phainon screamed into the cushion, sobbing as he poured the pent-up emotions he had bottled up since Kephale knew when.

But even his voice was swallowed by the silence, reminding him how alone he was now.

How lonely he felt.

Phainon cried until the pain somehow numbed, reduced into a pulsing pain in his chest, a stinging pain in his eyes, and the paralysis that he couldn't quite understand. He couldn't remember when he stopped crying, or how time seemed to move in a strange velocity, because when he blinked and saw his surroundings, sunlight had filled the room with its bright light.

And everything stayed the same: the stillness, the emptiness, the pain that echoed in the silence.

Mydei had truly gone.

Phainon flipped so he lay on his back now, staring at the crystal chandeliers hanging on the high ceiling. The golden, branch-like frame resembled a tree limb, cascading into a dramatic array of clear crystal droplets that reflected sunlight from the window and mimicked the look of morning dew or icicles. The warm lighting looked pale compared to the sun, yet it cast a soft glow reminiscent of the first dawn of spring.

It was a chandelier that Mydei bought in Aidonia; its delivery fee nearly matched the price. Phainon had made a fuss, jokingly scolding him for not buying one from YAYKEA like a normal person.

“This reminds me of your Mom’s backyard tree in Aedes Elysiae,” Mydei said with a straight face. He stared at the lamp with his arms crossed in front of his chest, a slight tug of a smile on his lips. “I thought your Mom and Dad would appreciate it if they came over. It’ll help make them feel like this is their home, too, don’t you think?”

Whatever joke that Phainon meant to retort him, whatever word he thought, died on his tongue that day. He stared at Mydei, who looked so soft, at peace, gazing at the small piece of Aedes Elysiae in their apartment as if he were reminiscing about home.

Phainon was totally flabbergasted, totally moved by the view in front of him, and the question popped into his mind before he could even stop it.

Marry me, Mydeimos.

Because he thought it might mean that Mydei wanted permanence, that Mydei wished to build a family. Phainon was so in awe, so invested in that idea that he commissioned the rings from Cartonus. He spent the entire three days of his Mandatory Rest Day looking up the right reference for the rings.

But now that he thought about it again, maybe he was wrong. Maybe Mydei didn’t mean it that way at all. Maybe he was just so mesmerized by Aedes Elysiae's nature and wanted a little piece of it at home. Maybe Mydei was just trying to be nice to Phainon’s parents.

Ah, well, it didn’t matter now.

Mydei had gone.

Phainon stared and stared and stared and stared, his mind wandering everywhere. He wondered if they would still be fine if Phainon had said no to Mydei’s demand to be in a fake relationship, back in the Mnestia Tower. If they still had their sanctuary, safe and sound, without the unnecessary noises that push them away from each other.

But then again, he would never have seen Mydei’s face lit up, childlike and alive. He wouldn’t have a chance to hear Mydei talk about music so enthusiastically, and Mydei wouldn’t have any chance to see his mother’s legacy come to life. The great, talented Mydeimos Gorgo would be forever locked to the ground. The Concorde that was destined to reach greatness would never soar to the sky …

But they’ll still be together.

No, Phainon could never dare to do that to Mydei, even if Mydei thought that it was what he wanted.

Mydeimos Gorgo was destined to be so much more than just some nobody’s boyfriend.

“I’ll give you the world,” Phainon’s croaked voice whispered to the still air that swallowed his words into silence. “Even if I have to burn myself trying.”

Phainon let out a weak, defeated smile. It’s no use thinking about what could have been.

A new dawn had come.

All he could do now was just face the consequences of his choice and move on with his life.

Phainon got up from where he lay, not sure what to do. Now that the sun of a new day illuminated the room, he felt even more like a stranger in this

house. Everything he thought of doing felt intrusive; he didn't feel like he could eat Mydei's pre-made food in the fridge, or use his kitchen to make breakfast. It felt even more wrong to think of brushing his teeth or taking a shower in the master bedroom.

It felt like he was overstaying his welcome, cause this wasn't his home anymore.

So Phainon got up, picking up Mydei's clothes on the floor, every piece was a Dollywood glam that Mydei had stripped himself of—a mask he bared before he faced Phainon. He then picked up the shattered Ambrosia bottle, piece by piece, not caring that some of the sharp edges scraped his skin a little.

Mydei hated Ambrosia.

He hated the effect on his body, since he always treated it like a sacred temple. They only keep alcohol in the house to welcome guests. Why did he drink it now? What happened before he came home? Why did Mydei come home drunk and all over him like he was desperate?

Phainon's eyes locked onto the small black tube with a bright red tip smudging the floor. He picked up the lipstick, wiping off the half-crushed bullet, and noticed only a silver engraving on the base: a star and the letter R in a fancy font.

Robin.

Phainon remembered this lipstick, now. It was a special collaboration item. Phainon had seen the advertising for the lipstick so many times in the airport's makeup stores.

Why did Mydei want to mark Phainon in Robin's color? Did the ruse finally get to him? And he realized when he came home that he wished Robin instead of him, so he wanted to paint Phainon in her color. Was it Mydei's final attempt to make Phainon worthy in his world?

What happened?

Phainon sighed, placing the lipstick on the island between the kitchen and the living room.

As much as he wanted answers, it’s no use to cling to those questions now. It was all over.

He moved around the house, getting hangers from the guest bedroom to place Mydei’s Dollywood clothes: the red satin tuxedo jacket, white silk shirts, white cravats. Phainon would put it in the laundry, but he wasn’t sure how to handle it. Mydei’s costumes usually had a particular way to clean.

Another proof that Phainon couldn’t ever understand Mydei’s world.

Phainon left to take a shower in the guest’s shower room, and when he finally saw his reflection in the mirror, Phainon nearly burst back into tears.

He looked like a complete mess. His eyes were red and puffy, and there were still red stains in the shape of Mydei’s lips all across his skin; smeared and faded in a few spots, but the mark was so visible that it shattered the pieces he tried to put together.

The image of Mydei’s hurt and betrayal played in his mind again, but this time, Phainon allowed his heart to just break. He allowed himself to accept that he would live with that guilt for the rest of his life; he had denied Mydeimos Gorgo, the man with whom his heart ached.

He deserved it.

Phainon ran the shower and let the cold water wash off the last remnants of Mydei on his body. He cried as the red on his skin wiped clean, and when he stepped out of the shower, he had no more tears to shed; the pain had all washed off the drain.

It felt so utterly, completely hollow, like he was nothing but an empty shell.

But maybe it gave him room for a new beginning.

To move forward, start by leaving this place.

Phainon used the spare clothes from his work suitcase for the day and packed the rest. He glanced at the door to their shared room, wondering if he should go there to pick up another set of clean uniforms and some of his important documents; his flight certificates, some clean pairs of underwear and boxers, perhaps his shaving kit…

No.

He couldn't enter that room.

He had just lost Mydei. He couldn't lose the memory of his sanctuary, too.

Not now, at least.

Maybe much later, he could ask their cleaner to help collect Phainon's personal belongings. Maybe much later, he could ask Mydei to let him drop by to pick them up. Maybe much, much later, if enough time passed, they could become friends. Maybe Mydei would let him hang around the house again, even if only for a few hours.

The thought made Phainon scoff.

He was certain that he couldn't just be friends with Mydei. Their world was too different, and he loved that man too much. He couldn't even imagine seeing Mydei with someone else, even if he knew that it was inevitable.

Phainon zipped his suitcase and walked to the door. He looked back at the house for the last time: the modern living room with a contemporary lamp casting a warm glow. The kitchen with a complete set of utensils and spices, the wall-sized glass window that views the city, the dark wooden door to their room… a place he shared with the love of his life.

For the last time, Phainon smiled at the room, a quiet salute for everything they once shared.

Then, he walked out the door, feeling his heart shatter as the soft click was heard behind him.

Goodbye, sanctuary.

-

Phainon had no other place to go in Okhema that did not include Mydei in any way. Not his friends, not Aglaea's. So he decided to clock in to work, volunteering himself to help mentor young cadets in the simulation training.

He distracted himself from the gaping wound in his heart by standing at the edge of the simulator bay, watching as two cadets fumbled through pre-flight checklists on the overhead panel. Their voices echoed with too much energy for this hour.

"Checklist complete!" one young cadet said, a bit too proudly.

Phainon leaned in from behind the seat and pointed at the center console. "Uh-huh…" he said. "And what about the APU bleed?"

The cadet whipped his head so quickly and crushed quietly. *Haikas*.

Phainon short-circuited as his half-sutured heart was ripped off again.

"Hey, no cursing in my sim bay, young man," he scolded, before his brain could register it.

The young man looked at him, startled. "Sir, you… know Kremnoan?"

Yeah, from being called that affectionately for four years. But Phainon only shrugged.

"I've flown to Castrum Kremnos several times, kid. Of course, I know a curse word or two," he said jokingly, ignoring the metaphorical bleeding in his chest. "Now repeat from the beginning. Don't forget the APU Bleed lest we'll get a bad review from the *hot cabin*, okay?"

The young cadet shouted a loud ‘Yes, Sir!’, and Phainon’s day continued. Come nighttime, he slept at the nap bay again, and the next day, he volunteered to sim program again, much to the young cadets’ excitement. He was grateful for their enthusiasm. It could somehow help manage the persistent dull ache in his chest that refused to go away.

On his last Mandatory Rest Day, though, Eleanor, the HR manager, came to the nap bay herself to hand Phainon the permission to mentor the simulator bay, but not without a gentle reminder that his ground work will be accumulated to his work hours this month, and gave him a *very friendly reminder* to use his rest days by resting appropriately.

Phainon only nodded, but his mind said otherwise.

He didn’t need rest. He needed a distraction.

Eleanor looked like she knew she was being ignored, because she crossed her arms, ready to lecture Phainon about how important rest was for the sake of a safe flight. But Phainon excused himself before she could say anything. He had been flying for so many hours. He knew when he was rested enough to fly another short leg rotation without collapsing.

Besides, Eleanor shouldn’t be that offended.

She was not the only person Phainon chose to ignore.

He ignored voicemails from Caelus and Dan Heng, who told him they should really hang out (Caelus) and that they were super worried about him (Dan Heng). He ignored Stelle’s texts, which ranged from questions and demands to threats to pick up her calls. He ignored even Anaxa’s invitation to dinner together with Hyacine and Castorice the next time he was in town. All with many variations of the simple sentence:

Sorry, can’t. It’s a crazy time at work. Next time, yeah?

He couldn’t do that to Cyrene, though, so every time she asked for a call, Phainon would call her, as briefly as he could. He tried to keep the conversation about work and home, but of course, Cyrene was sharper than

that. She kept asking about Mydei, and Phainon answered as best he could without giving away their breakup.

He couldn’t bring himself to mention his name.

Maybe someday, when he could meet Cyrene in person. But in the meantime, he’d pretended that nothing happened.

“Phainon, you can’t keep avoiding me like this,” Cyrene said. Of course, he would hear the words he didn’t say. Of course, she would confront him about it. “Please, let’s meet up and talk? Tomorrow is my last day in Okhema. Who knows when we could see each other again?”

“I have a rotation tomorrow, Cy,” Phainon said, staring at the dull roof of the nap bay. “I’m sorry. I’ll come home the next time, okay?”

There was a silence on the other side of the line, the kind that Cyrene usually liked to hold to make Phainon feel like he had to fill it with additional reasons. But Phainon was ragged by suppressed sorrow and exhaustion. He‘d let the silent stretch as long as she wants.

“Phainon,” Cyrene finally submitted. “Don’t be like that.”

“Don’t be like what?”

“You’ve been avoiding *everyone*. Caelus. Cas. Hyacinthia, and Stelle, and Mydei…”

Phainon could feel his heart leap. He could feel it skip a beat, hearing Mydei’s name being mentioned. But he held it in. “What, you’ve been talking about me?” he chuckled, but no humor was heard from his exhausted voice.

“Phai, we don’t live in a cave. We know what’s happening out there with Mydei and Robin,” Cyrene insisted. “The news is everywhere, and suddenly you’re too busy to meet anyone or even to call anyone. So I gotta call Mydei and…”

Cyrene sighed, as if weighing her next words.

Phainon raised his brows. “... And?”

The line went silent. Phainon had to look at his phone screen to see whether Cyrene had hung up or if the line was cut.

“Cy? Did he tell you?”

There was a sigh, a sign of surrender and frustration. “Snowy, you’re my little brother,” she said. “Why are you doing this to me? Don’t you even want to talk about it to your big sis?”

Oh, Kephale, no, he did not need this.

Phainon could feel a lump in his throat. No, he didn’t want to talk about it, cause then it would feel too real, and Phainon wasn’t ready for that. Not now. Not today.

Maybe not ever. But Cyrene wouldn’t let his silence linger that long.

So he would hold what he could right now.

“I uh…” Phainon let out a long, shaky sigh, swallowing the sob. “I’ll tell you later, yeah? I can’t do it now. I have an early flight tomorrow.”

“Snowy, please,” she said quietly. “I’m worried about you so so much.”

“What did he tell you?” he asked, half-hoping that Cyrene wouldn’t tell, half-hoping that she would. Phainon didn’t know what he wanted anymore.

“It doesn’t matter. You’re my little brother, I want to hear it from you,” Cyrene said firmly. “Come on. Talk to me.”

Phainon bit his lips, pressing his eyelids shut to keep the tears inside. He really couldn’t do this. He couldn’t talk to Cyrene because if he started now, he would cry his heart out. He couldn’t do that when he had work so early the next day.

“Sorry, Cy. I’m too exhausted to talk right now,” he said. “I’m sorry, I’ll tell you when I’m ready, yeah? I just… can’t be distracted right now. Work’s

really crazy."

Another pause from Cyrene's end, before she finally sighed. "Alright, fine," she said. "But please promise me to talk to someone, okay? If you can't talk to me, talk to Cae. Or Mom. Please call Mom. Don't be stubborn and handle everything on your own. Sometimes a hero needs another hero, too, remember?"

Phainon couldn't help but let out a little chuckle, and a drop of tears along with it. He wiped his cheek, smiling bitterly at himself as he heard the catchphrase their Mom constantly repeated to them when they were young, when Phainon still loved to play pretend.

It's too late now.

He had already destroyed his relationship and himself along with it.

Only time could heal him.

"Okay, Cy, I promise," Phainon said weakly. He didn't mean it, but no point in making Cyrene even more worried.

"Alright," she said. "Come home soon, City boy."

Phainon hummed a goodbye, and then, he closed his eyes, trying to sleep off the guilt and broken heart. He thought he had gotten used to it. But each time he was alone, he could feel the cut, fresh as the night Mydei left him.

But a new dawn always comes, and he walked back into the hamster wheel that was his work again: flying regional leg, sleeping all day on standby days and layovers, another regional leg, volunteering for the sim programs or log-keeping on his Rest Days, on and on again. He kept his day moving as busy as possible, while the world spun around him, sending him a few passing news of the Royalty Tour. With every dawn, every conversation he overheard from total strangers, Mydei felt a distance further away from Phainon, going up and away to the unreachable heights.

By the time their first concert of the tour started, Mydei had skyrocketed to the sky beyond what Phainon could reach.

It stung, still. But this time, Phainon no longer had time to stop and cry.

He always had the next flight to catch. Next simulator to supervise.

In the third week since he broke up with Mydei, he was assigned an ultra-long-haul flight to Sigonia, which he gladly accepted. Phainon loved flying to Sigonia. They always have the opposite season with Okhema, and honestly, with the humid summer almost peaking in Amphoreus, the cold winter wind was a welcome change.

Since Phainon was assigned to the second shift, he practically had nothing to do until the later part of the flight. He was stuck sitting in the crew rest compartment, staring at the roof while thinking about how strangely contradictory time flies these days. He flew more miles than he could think, and somehow, that night with Mydei still felt like yesterday. The dull ache in his chest still pulsed as if it had a life of its own, yet the distance made it feel like his happier moments with Mydei were nothing more than a vivid dream.

“Captain Khaslana, you’re up,” Velite nudged him out of his daydream. “ATC just relayed light turbulence ahead. Weather’s shifting, too.”

“Roger that,” Phainon replied, heading toward the cockpit. With a wall of switches and screens before him, there was no room to mourn his lost love. He had four hundred passengers in his hands now. He had to keep them safe.

It was just another ordinary flight. The cruise, the landing, and the post-flight routine were all buttery smooth—nothing much to report, especially with the clear weather around Sigonia and the relatively quiet air traffic.

As passengers began to deboard, Nymphas stepped into the cockpit, offering him a polite smile as she asked if a little girl and her fathers from First Class could come to the cockpit and take a picture.

Phainon nodded, and while Nymphas went to get the passengers, he reached into his bag to grab a small golden wing pin he always kept for this exact situation. He always loved meeting little aviation enthusiasts who wanted to take a picture in the cockpit. It reminded him of himself when he was younger, so he always kept the pin as a keepsake of their flight—something they could wear proudly everywhere, and that would remind them of the joy of flying.

The door opened, and the girl bounded inside with an innocent enthusiasm. Blond hair in soft waves, violet eyes wide with awe.

She reminded Phainon of someone else he had met, that somehow made his heart feel strange.

Before he could recover, however, the girl's parents entered the cockpit. It was a blue-haired man and a blond-haired man who looked so much like the little girl that Phainon wondered why he didn't make the connection any sooner.

Phainon's blood ran cold as he realized who exactly this man was who stood in front of him. His knuckles whitened on the pin, and his fingernails dug into his own palm.

Dr. Ratio and Aventurine.

Aventurine.

Of all people.

Upon meeting Phainon's eyes, Aventurine's eyes sparkled with recognition. He let out a lopsided smile that made Phainon's stomach turn. Phainon gritted his teeth quietly while his mind spoke; this was the devil that set up the whole fake-dating thing. The man who took a glance at Mydei's shoes and made it a global campaign. The man who reduced Mydei into moodboards and narratives…

The man whose ideas made Mydei bowed in their living room, drunk and crying.

If it weren't because of you… If it weren't because of your stupid idea…

"Oh, surprise, surprise," Aventurine grinned, wiping the surprised expression he wore just now. "If it isn't…"

"Hello, little one!" Phainon forced an awkward smile as he crouched to the girl's eye level, ignoring Aventurine entirely. "Is this the little flyer who's ready to be on duty this morning?"

"Good mo'ning, Cap'ain," the little girl's voice broke Phainon from the anger boiling under his skin. She let out a confident smile, which looked exactly like Aventurine, just with zero cynicism. It was either that Aventurine was the sole surrogate donor, or Ratio's genes did not even bother to fight. "Juliet Rrratio repowting fo' duty! Juliet loves planes!"

Phainon chuckled. "You and I both, kiddo," Phainon said, trying to ignore the burning in his chest. "Alright, Captain Juliet," he continued, opening his palm to reveal the golden wing pin. "Would you do the honor of flying Okhema Air this morning?"

Her gasp was genuine, her small hands trembling as she accepted the pin like a crown. She struggled for a bit to place the pin on the left side of her chest before asking to be picked up. Ratio placed her in the Captain's Seat, snapping photos from every angle. Phainon then showed her the radios, the throttle, the overhead panel, his voice softening despite the anger that still ate him alive.

But he did hold it in, if only to respect the innocent child in front of him.

She laughed, bright and unguarded. For a fleeting second, Phainon let himself breathe in that lightness, ignoring Aventurine's stare burn the back of his mind.

After a while, Ratio told the kid that they had to leave; that Phainon still had to do his job. Juliet seemed to be quite mature for her age, because despite throwing a tantrum like a kid usually would, she only nodded and asked if she could take a picture with *Cap'n Kasslana*.

Phainon nodded eagerly.

“Thank you, Captain Khaslana!” she exclaimed.

“Thank you for your service, Captain Juliet,” Phainon gave her a salute, to which she gleefully returned before circling her hand back around Ratio’s neck.

Phainon could feel his heart pounding faster, the burning anger at the bottom of his gut set aflame as he shifted his gaze to Aventurine, acknowledging him for the first time since they had come into the room.

“Actually, there’s still something I want to give to Captain Juliet for her service today. But I need to take it in the galley. Can one of the Dads come with me?”

Aventurine’s smile grew wider, as if he already anticipated it. “Of course,” he said, nodding to Juliet and Ratio. “Please go right ahead, honey. Daddy will assist *Captain Khaslana*.”

Phainon did not know how Aventurine could make him hate the sound of his name so much. But he breathed through his nose, trying his might not to let it show on his face. Ratio glanced at them, looking a bit wary for a while, but nodded regardless. Juliet waved excitedly at Phainon before they exited the room.

“Please follow me this way, Sir,” Phainon said sharply, guiding Aventurine out. He clenched his jaws, gritting his teeth so hard that his gums hurt. What was he thinking? What would he ask Aventurine? He couldn’t just punch him for orchestrating the campaign. He couldn’t even shout at him. He didn’t know what to do. What to say. He just knew he wanted explanations for why Mydei was crying that night.

Thankfully, the galley was already empty. The rest of the cabin crew had headed out, and the ground crew who were supposed to collect the log hadn’t arrived yet. Phainon grabbed the mini plane plushie from one of the souvenir drawers to give to Juliet. But before he could say anything, Aventurine beat himself into it.

“Well, now that it’s just the two of us, no need to be so formal, Captain Khaslana,” Aventurine grinned. “Appreciate you keep it civil around my daughter, but go on, shoot the curse.”

Phainon’s jaw locked. Something primal clenched in his chest. He didn’t even realize he had stepped forward until his boots thudded louder than necessary on the floor. His voice, when it came, was tight and bitter. Almost shaking.

“What happened to Mydei on Wednesday, the 17th?”

Aventurine raised his brows. “Hm? The 17th?” he hummed. “What about it?”

Phainon did not answer. He held his gaze, waiting for the answer while trying not to combust.

“A guessing game, huh? Okay, let me think… that was the day we garnered ten million credits of PR value alone from… huh,” Aventurine flicked his fingers. “The accidental kiss on stage,” he paused, his smile faltered as he stared at Phainon. “That might bring a little bit of trouble home.”

Accidental kiss.

Phainon could feel the air being punched out of his chest. His eyes were spotted, and the skin of his palm was broken from how deeply he dug his nails. He didn’t even want to know what happened in that scenario. He gulped, swallowing the anger that lumped in his throat, and gritting his teeth.

“Mydei came home drunk that day.”

“It would be strange if he didn’t,” Aventurine hummed. “Mydei got off stage even more furious than that love interview with Owlbert. He was *livid*. I was sure he was seeing red, with how chaotic he was backstage. He kept shouting to cut that scene. But there was nothing we could do about it. It was a live concert.”

Phainon still didn’t answer. He tightened the hold on the plastic that carried the plane plushie, still pressing his lips, not trusting himself to stay civil if he made any move.

“You want to know the whole story,” Aventurine tilted his head, starting his words slowly like he was testing something. No, like he was *gambling* with Phainon’s emotion. “Fine. You see, it was truly a chaotic night. In the middle of Net Gala, too. I had to apologize to Mrs. Idrila for ruining her backstage. And apologies to Idrila are expensive, I’ll tell you that. But anyway, in the middle of that chaos, Robin begged me to terminate the campaign. She said she was afraid this could break the relationship between Mydei and you. We were all ready to deploy the termination plan. But the next day, Mydei came to the pre-tour briefing very obedient. He insisted on continuing. I thought maybe you’ve tamed him. Maybe you could somehow manage to put some sense into—”

Phainon pushed forward, grabbing Aventurine’s collar and pulling him up. “Stop,” he hissed through his gritted teeth. His breath was ragged. His other hand twitched—desperate to strike, but not stupid enough to do it here. His body shook from restraint. “Stop talking about him like he’s your puppet.”

Aventurine didn’t even flinch a little. He only smirked, looking a mix of amused and… sympathetic?

“Now now, calm down, don’t ruffle your furs just yet,” Aventurine said, but he didn’t make any attempt to get himself out of Phainon’s hold.

He looked unbothered, and deep down, Phainon was reminded again of his wariness when he first saw Aventurine, about his eerie calm and fearlessness.

“You think I pull his strings? No, Captain. Mydei’s the only one who’s ever pulled mine. Fifteen years in this business, and no one, not a single person, ever gave me more headaches than Mydei. He frustrates me, impresses me, and costs me money, all for the sake of you. To shield your feelings. It was very impressive, too. Your little lion got a good head on his shoulders; he always gets me running around to serve what he wants. But nevertheless, I

enjoy our little game. Imagine my shock when suddenly he just… stops resisting. I thought, huh, maybe *The Phainon* had finally tamed him."

Phainon's grip trembled, his throat raw. He let go, stepping back as if burned. His voice cracked despite the steel he tried to force into it. "He's not mine anymore. We broke up on the 17th."

At that, Aventurine raised his brows, looking genuinely surprised. "And trotters can fly, yup, I'm not buying this narrative. My interns could joke better than that."

Phainon clenched his jaws. "Fuck you. Not everything in this world is a *narrative*, Aventurine," he slammed the metal behind him. Aventurine still didn't flinch, but there was a narrowing in his eyes, now. A clear sign that he didn't appreciate Phainon's suppressed aggression. "Not everything is a lie. We're done. Mydei left me. I have not been in the picture since the 17th. Whatever he does since then, it's just what he wants."

Aventurine tilted his head. "And yet, I spent hours every day with that man, and he never once failed to mention you in front of my face. That man is so whipped it costs both of us a lot of money, there's no way he just *left you* after all of that expensive hassle."

He hummed, looking at Phainon as if he were analyzing him.

"Come on," he said, as understanding painted his face. "Get fuckin' real with me, Captain."

The silence stretched between them as Phainon still refused to answer him. He didn't know what to say.

"Mydei terminated the four-million-credit contract with Dr. Markenz, following the success of the Cherry Bomb shoes. He rejected every live interview and made the ones we already planned to sign a formal pact just to ask pre-approved questions—no spontaneous questions, no audience prompt. And just a few nights ago, he still insisted on fighting everyone in the wardrobe department to keep that ugly choker on his neck at all costs. Are you saying that's all just *what he wants*?"

He paused, giving Phainon space to argue. But when Phainon stayed silent, Aventurine scoffed.

“C’mon, Captain. Don’t tell me half of my projected earnings are in chaos because Mydei was just deliberately being a diva. I know no shit about that man, but I know he’s not an asshole. Whatever he does, he does it for *you*. So don’t fucking bull me with cute stories as *he left you*.”

The fact that Aventurine broke somehow sank Phainon’s heart even deeper, pulling out air from his lungs like he was in the stratosphere without a mask. He chewed on his bottom lip, mind reeling at the lengths Mydei went to *control the narrative*, which he never told Phainon.

That can’t be true. It had to be Aventurine twisting the facts again.

But a tiny part inside of him tells Phainon that it was just the Mydei thing to do. It all matched with their private conversation about the shoes, the talk show, and the choker. And it matched how Mydei would always go to great lengths to keep what matters to him, just like the chandelier.

Now that he thought about it, he never actually tried to listen from Mydei’s side. Sure, Mydei told him a better part of his days, and he always complained about exhaustion and Aventurine being an unbearable piece of shit. But he never offered further details.

But again, Mydei was never a man who announced what he would do.

And Phainon never asked… because he never knew what to ask. He never asked Mydei what he should expect. He just rolled with it and got caught in the middle of something he only pretended to understand.

Because he was so worried that if he admitted it, Mydei would see that Phainon didn’t actually understand his world.

He was always afraid that Mydei would see that he could never be good enough.

And while Phainon allowed himself to drown in his own insecurities, while he was swept away by a stream of words and pseudo-psychological analysis in his own head, Mydei had tried to keep his promise even harder than Phainon could imagine.

Oh, Kephale.

Aventurine smirked, looking half-amused, half-baffled. “Holy shit, you’re the one breaking up with him,” he said. “My dear Captain, you’re so oblivious, aren’t you?”

Phainon scoffed. “It doesn’t matter now.”

Even in his own ears, he sounded so broken, so hurt that it silenced Aventurine. It’s strange to see this taunting master at a loss for words.

“Oh, I’m sure it matters a lot for Mydei,” Aventurine said. “Is the kiss really making you uncomfortable, Phainon? Did you really go and date a celebrity without even a single thought that he’d kiss someone else for *the art?* Are you really so naive?”

Phainon’s heart almost imploded in his chest. *It’s not even about the kiss,* he wanted to scream. He had only known about it just now. He didn’t know to make a fuss about it because…

… by the time of that gala, he had already turned away from Mydei-related news.

He had completely turned away from Mydei.

And not because he wanted to go off-grid, as Dan Heng suggested. But because deep down, he had already been so convinced that they were over. He had already distanced himself from Mydei while he was still fighting tooth and nail for it. Mydei was still throwing a fit about the accidental kiss, worrying about what Phainon would think, while Phainon was rehearsing his goodbye.

But was Phainon even in the wrong? He was only thinking he was doing Mydei a favor. That removing himself from the picture was what was best for Mydei's happiness and career.

… And it gets you a free pass to decide what happiness is for me?

Mydei's angry words bounced inside Phainon's skull, so loud that it almost deafened him. Phainon pressed his eyes shut, pressing the bridge of his nose.

"Look, Mydei's free now. He can be the star he's meant to be without me dragging him down," Phainon said, his voice brittle. "I just came here to tell you—don't ever do that to him again. Don't push him into something that sends him home drunk and crying. You promised you'd stop the moment Mydei got hurt."

"Oh, Captain, but it's not my plan that hurt him that day," Aventurine said calmly. "He went completely livid because he thought he hurt *you*. He yelled at everyone to cut that scene, to make it disappear ASAP, but it already went viral, and he still went on a rampage, yelling about how to *fix it*."

Aventurine narrowed his eyes, and the smirk faltered as he continued.

"He had been excessively annoying about the plan since Owlbert's show. Still smart, but even *I* sense desperation in his actions. Like he was taking a shot in the dark about what might upset you, and cutting it out preemptively. It's almost sad, really. Like you *never told him* what you were actually uncomfortable with. So he had to guess on his own."

Bullseye.

It hit right on the spot that Phainon couldn't even deny it. Even his dismissive scoff sounded weak.

And Aventurine seemed to know that, too.

“Wow, damn, Captain,” Aventurine laughed, but there was no humor in it, just disbelief twisted into something cruel. “I can’t believe I thought Mydei had everything. Brawn, beauty, brain, and a chill, understanding partner to boot. Boy, I hate it when I’m wrong.”

“I endured it for him,” Phainon said. “I endured everything, so I don’t hold him back.”

“And nobody said you should,” Aventurine retorted sharply. “Don’t you remember? The deal was that this would all stop the moment you’re uncomfortable with it. It had happened with the Dr. Markenz campaign. Mydei asked us to stop, so we did. I paid half of the penalty, too. You have that kind of power, Phainon. Mydei had declared it to everyone that day. Yet you chose to endure it instead. And look where that *unnecessary self-sacrifice* got you.”

Look where it got Mydei, was implied. But Aventurine was kind enough to hold his tongue.

Phainon gritted his teeth; his jaws hurt. But he couldn’t retort to that, because Aventurine was right about him. He was right about Mydei, too. Phainon couldn’t help but rewind what Mydei said in their car, back after the meeting in Mnestia Tower.

I want you to know what we’ve gotten into, and you have to be honest about how you feel about this entire situation. The music, the legacy, they’re not more important than you.

But Phainon just wanted to make Mydei’s life easier. Make his career smoother.

“All of that, and you still push him away,” Aventurine scoffed.

He was just trying to be kind. To be understanding.

Why was he so wrong?

“Well, I’ll leave you to mull over it, then. If you’ll excuse me, my daughter is waiting,” Aventurine said, when it was clear that Phainon was too paralyzed to continue the conversation. “Also, I don’t know you, and I don’t give a damn about your feelings or your relationship. But I respect Mydeimos, so I’ll give you a little advice in his favor. Remember, there’s a reason they’re called *a star*. They burn in the dark—surrounded by worse devils than me, men with lesser morals and higher ambitions. So maybe tuck that insecurity back in your ass and next time, start talking like a man who knows the odds before the dark swallowed you both.”

Phainon watched as Aventurine straightened his position to leave. But before he disappeared behind the door, Phainon stopped him.

“Wait,” Phainon called, his voice rough. Aventurine stopped, glancing over his shoulder with the faintest smirk. “If Mydei had refused that day… if I’d said no to your collaboration plan, who else were you going to approach?”

The blond chuckled, tilting his head. “Truthfully? No one. Mydei was my all-or-nothing for this plan. If he had refused for any reason, I would have thought of another way to help Robin. And even if he’d quit midway, it wouldn’t pose much of a problem for me either. I’d always find a way to keep going. I’m very good at placing my bets in the right hands.”

Aventurine let the words settle, then added, almost gently.

“I do feel bad that this campaign cost him the relationship he was hell-bent on keeping. My poor little lion. But hey, maybe we could all learn our lessons here. In love, no good intentions are ever a better bet than the truth.”

Another strike to Phainon’s ego. He dug his nails so hard into his palms that he could feel a crescent shape of pain there. But he didn’t say anything.

“Huh, ain’t that something, coming from *someone like me*?” Aventurine laughed again before giving Phainon a salute and a wink. “Good day, captain. May your skies always be clear.”

Phainon’s breath hitched. His stomach dropped like an aircraft in sudden turbulence. For a moment, he couldn’t move, couldn’t speak. There was a

flare in his chest that came from the remnants of his broken heart. But this time it wasn’t anger—just a hollow ache gnawing at him.

And as Aventurine’s footsteps fade, he could see the images of Mydei’s hurt face again, now mixed with fear, the emotion that Phainon had missed entirely the first time he saw it.

-

Phainon didn’t even wait until he reached his layover hotel. He sat in one of the airport seats, pulled out his phone, and typed *"Mydei Robin Kiss"* into TabTube.

The top result was a thumbnail close-up of Mydei’s lips brushing Robin’s. Even from the still, Phainon could see the shock in Mydei’s eyes.

It was a very fancy stage. Net Gala, considering how fancy Robin looked. Mydei was wearing the red satin tux that Phainon picked up from the floor after the fight that led to their breakup.

Their performance was excellent; they sang with such fiery intensity that it was no wonder the crowd cheered so loudly. Robin and Mydei played the part of the singers who adored each other, with Mydei occasionally leaning into Robin, and Robin brushing her hands on Mydei’s shoulders every once in a while. It was all straight out of Aventurine’s moodboard.

But then, as they ended the song and Robin greeted the Dollywood elites who attended Net Gala, one of the famous producers, whose name Phainon couldn’t remember, suddenly shouted, “Now Kiss!” to which the rest of the audience parroted in a unified chant. Robin only laughed, while Mydei was busy adjusting something in his ear while looking at someone under the stage, clearly too distracted with something. He must have an issue with his noise-reduction earplugs. The shape of Mydei’s inner ears was always too big to fit some of the plugs on the market.

Robin tried to defuse it, tried to say it was inappropriate, but the audience kept roaring, kept chanting that one word.

Kiss! Kiss! Kiss! Kiss!

“Just on the cheek, yeah?” she said, finally, leaning to Mydei. She placed one hand on his shoulder and whispered something, but Mydei tilted his head in the last moment, probably to hear Robin better.

And then, it happened.

Robin’s lips brushed against Mydei’s. It was quick, subtle, even far too quick to be called a peck. But the audience roared all the same. They shouted, laughed, whistled, and clapped their hands as if they were crowning new monarchs.

But Phainon did not have the time to feel jealous. All he could see was Mydei’s face looking beet red, biting his lower lip. When they finally broke the kiss, much to the audience’s roar, Mydei looked everywhere but the camera. He could at least maintain his smile, which could be seen as a little coy, but he knew that it didn’t reach his eyes.

And Robin… she handled it better than Mydei. She laughed shyly at the camera, but Phainon could see that with every glance at Mydei, she must be quietly worried. She kept denying another kiss until the MC for the next segment had to push Mydei to kiss Robin like he meant it, to which Mydei only shrugged.

“Robin got so many young fans, Elba, come on. Let’s not teach them excess PDA, yeah?” he said. His voice trembled, but it could easily be blamed on the effect of his post-performance.

The audience laughed, and with one last wave, Mydei and Robin exited the stage.

It had fifteen million views and thousands of comments. The netizens were cheering on them with more caps locks, more #LionDove hashtags, and as

he scrolled through, he could see the #shydei and #simpdei hashtags—painting Mydei's suppressed anger as the shy smittenness.

But no, that couldn't be the reason why Mydei was coming home drunk.

Phainon typed *Mydei Net Gala red carpet,* and clicked on the longest duration he could find.

The video was a montage of multiple angles of Mydei and Robin walking on the red carpet. From their arrival in the limo to their walk, the poses in front of a bunch of cameras, and even a few interviews with him and Robin. The double interviews talked about their album, their relationship, and their outfit inspiration, which were mainly rehearsed versions of what Phainon already knew.

But as Mydei got to his solo interview, the interviewer paused, like she didn't know what to ask now that Robin was out of the picture.

"So Mydei, that outfit is clearly Gorgo red, yeah? Is that inspired by her, too?" she asked, finally.

Am I not worthy to look at without her shadow over me?

Mydei nodded. "Yeah, definitely. The blue flowers also represented her spirit. Aglaea added it because it aligned with the Wild Hunt theme of the year. It's from House of Goldenweaver, as usual. Aglaea did an amazing job, didn't she?"

The interviewer asked a few more rehearsed, typical questions, which Mydei answered with ease. A short answer that he deflected to praise other parties; Ratio, Robin, his bandmates, Aventurine, all in a professional tone. But then, in the middle of the interview, someone entered the camera's field, and the man quickly put his hands around Mydei's shoulders.

"Look at my son looking so damn good."

Mydei's shocked face was only there for a second, but even then, it looked a fracture too long for his usual stoic face. He glanced at Eurypon Soos, his

father, and let out a rehearsed smile.

“Hey, old man.”

The interviewer looked thrilled, probably didn’t expect that her segment would turn into an exclusive moment with Mydeimos Gorgo and his famous, legendary producer father, Eurypon Soos, in one frame. Eurypon dominates the interview for a bit. He mostly talked about how Mydei could finally live up to his Mom’s legacy now that he collaborated with Robin, how proud he was, and so many other bullshit that Phainon chose to mute.

He didn’t like Eurypon.

Mydei had briefly mentioned his relationship with Eurypon when they first started dating. Eurypon was a shitty husband to Gorgo, and even a shittier father. When Gorgo passed away, Mydei cut off relations with his father, deciding to stay with Krateros and take his mother’s last name.

“That’s a nice move,” Phainon had said then. “Mydeimos Gorgo does sound more badass than Mydeimos Soos, anyway.”

Phainon still remembered Mydei’s laugh right after he said that. His head thrown back, his mouth open, and he looked carefree, as if for a moment, he allowed himself to free himself from the weight of his parents' name.

He skipped Eurypon’s part, unable to see how exhausted Mydei looked next to his father. As Phainon fast-forwarded the video and skimmed through the interviews, he saw that most of them asked the same things: Robin, the collaboration, the outfit he wears, and his Mother’s legacy.

But never about him. Never about the music he so fantastically made.

Am I not worthy to even look at without her shadows over me?

Phainon suddenly remembered the feeling he had back in the studio on the listening party of the EP. He felt helplessly out of place, being surrounded by big names in the industry he wasn’t a part of. He remembered feeling

small, how he was just a normal human among giants, with the only reason he was there being his connection to Mydei.

What if Mydei felt the same, too?

What if he felt alone and small in such a prestigious event, because his only reason for being there was that he was Gorgo's son?

My entire career is built on a woman's legacy. People already call me Mama's boy, anyway.

Mydei had said it in a flat tone, almost as if he were used to it.

Like it was a bitter truth he was forced to swallow.

Phainon pursed his bottom lip. Then, he typed another search, Mydei's Bonk or Debunk interview. It was a talk show hosted by a comedy duo who often roasted their guests. Cyrene and Phainon were absolutely furious when they watched it together, because the comedians were particularly rude to Mydei.

"Mydei, we got someone here that says, 'Mydeimos will never have a career without the Gorgo'."

Mydei only laughed. "That's true. I don't think people will give two shits about me if not 'cause of my Mom's name and my bandmates' talent."

"Here's another: Mydeimos doesn't even sound good."

"Also true, I scream better, and Peucesta sings clean better. But Peu got a condition. He couldn't sing on stage for two hours straight for the whole tour period, so take it or leave it, f(beep)ers."

"A son of Eurypon Soos, yet signed with Anaxa and Chrysos Records. Even your own blood doesn't want to do anything with you."

"That's very rude, you should call him Anaxagoras. That's the name he preferred," Mydei said, much to the hosts and the audience's laughter. "But also, Anaxagoras was a huge fan of my mom. No one understands her

vision better than him. I only want to work with those who know her best, blood or not."

He had always said everything flatly, even with a mix of humor, like he wasn't bothered by it.

Every album, every interview—Queen Gorgo was there, hovering like a ghost. Mydei's voice, his lyrics, even his rage—all of it smothered under her name. Phainon realized, with a sick twist in his gut, that if the last name was removed, Mydeimos would never have existed at all.

It was always Gorgo's son, or Mydeimos of the Sons of Gorgo.

But never just Mydeimos.

Never the man.

And only now did Phainon realize that maybe Mydei was drowning, too—but in a different kind of noise. Not in the words of gossip or tabloids, but in the impossible weight of legacy. Maybe his mother's name was both a crown *and* a chain.

And Phainon, blinded by his own fear of not understanding Mydei's legacy, had unknowingly tightened the chain.

He remembered what he said that day, right before Mydei asked for the choker: *"Do it for your mom's legacy. It's important for me too."*

Maybe that's why he was crying that night. That's why he was furious.

Not because of Robin, or because he was disappointed. He must be exhausted by the pressure, by his father, and maybe by the hurt because Phainon had vanished for a week after he made false promises. Told him they'd meet on Wednesday—then took a flight to avoid him.

What if Mydei had come home hoping for sanctuary and found it empty? Mydei always hated waking up to an empty room. He must have been feeling so lonely, even amidst the noise. Because, sure, there are so many people who love him. But not because of him.

Because of the legacy he carried.

What if he saw Phainon and hoped that he could finally be just somebody's boyfriend?

Not his mother's successor, not his father's son.

Not even *Mydeimos Gorgo.*

But Phainon's 'Dei, Honeycake, *Kotik*.

What if that was why he clung so fiercely to intimacy? He just wanted to be held as he was.

And yet Phainon kept urging him to rest, to think about the tour, kept reminding him of the career he couldn't screw up. Even if it came from love, even if Phainon thought he was just doing his duty as a good boyfriend, it only made Phainon one more voice pushing him back into Gorgo's shadow.

Phainon had never asked about what the legacy meant for Mydei. He only saw Mydei carrying it and pretended to understand. He generously offered to help carry that legacy, without even asking Mydei first.

And when he realized that he didn't know how to hold it, when he thought that someone could hold it better, he chose defeat, without fighting for Mydei first. Thinking that he was doing Mydei a favor.

How stupid could he be?

Aventurine's words rang in Phainon's mind again. *No good intentions are ever a better bet than the truth.*

Phainon could feel his heart pounding faster as he realized the weight of his rejection that night.

Stupid, stupid Phainon.

He had lost count of how many videos he watched. He even watched the oldest ones when Mydei was still a child singer. When he ran out of videos, he went to the most recent ones with Robin, wondering whether they still asked about Gorgo when Mydei wasn't the only one in the frame.

Not to his surprise, they did.

But strangely enough, Mydei was chattier in these interviews. He often shifted the conversation about his mother to praise Robin, how similar she was to the late Queen Gorgo, how she could even hit Gorgo's signature gritty scream, one that no one had ever managed to pull off. Every praise he said pointed at Robin as his mom's successor. The next queen of rock.

Wait.

That was all too deliberate to be random praise.

Mydei had never been so passionate like that, or talked about his mom in that way.

Phainon repeated that part over and over, where Mydei was saying that Gorgo would have loved Robin. She would have loved to place her literal crown on her instead of on him, had she ever had the chance.

People in the comments gushed over how Mydei was so in love. But Phainon could see how… strange it was. Mydei wasn't just praising Robin's talent, wasn't he? It wasn't that he fell in love with her, per se. It was—

It was as if he was projecting his Mom's light on her, placing her legacy on Robin…

So he shouldn't anymore.

That was a crazy theory. All the years Phainon knew Mydei, Phainon had always known how much Mydei cherished his mother's legacy. He built his career on it. He was very careful about her legacy. He loved Gorgo so much. There's no way he could just place it on someone else.

And yet, it clicked so well that everything seemed clearer for Phainon.

Mydei had carried it throughout his career as a child singer. And then, as he grew up, he hung out with the guys from his Mother's philanthropic music school—the same guys she helped raise with her scholarships. That's why they called the band *Sons of Gorgo*. Because Mydei saw those guys as his brothers.

Maybe that was the first sign that Mydei realized that he couldn't carry her legacy alone.

Maybe he tried, and failed, and he finally got tired. Maybe he wasn't as nonchalant as he let on. Maybe he saw the critics and felt even more guilty that no matter how hard he tried, he *could never* be her.

And maybe, with the praise and good reviews from the campaign about Robin's role in reviving Queen Gorgo's spirit, Mydei was glad to finally find someone to properly carry on his mom's legacy without being thoroughly lost in that identity.

That Gorgo boy finally did something good, that taxi driver told him. And he was a huge Gorgo fan.

Maybe Mydei felt that, too. That he was finally doing good. Doing the right thing for her.

Phainon dragged a hand to his face.

Oh, Kephale.

He was so, so stupid.

His phone almost ran out of battery, but his eyes caught sight of one last thumbnail showing Mydei and Gorgo's image, edited to be side by side despite the photo being taken in a different era. It was a clip from Praho Winfree Show, and the thumbnail was titled *"Mydeimos Gorgo Reacts to Queen Gorgo Pregnancy Interview."*

Phainon pressed play.

The video started with the old clip of Gregoria Gorgo's interview with Praho, when she was definitely pregnant with Mydei. The clip was a bit blurry, but it was still of good quality.

“One question, Gregoria,” Praho said. “If your child doesn’t have an interest in music, if this child decides to pursue something else, what will you do?”

“Then to hell with music, Winfree,” Gorgo cackled. The audience in the studio laughed along with her. “My baby can be whatever he wants. I’ll support him. This child is my prince, he’ll be king, and kings don’t bow to Queen Mother, am I right, people?”

The camera went back to Mydei when the same interviewer, now almost a decade older than when she interviewed Gregoria, asked. “So if not music, what are you going to pursue, Mydei?”

Mydei paused, thinking for a bit, before shrugging. “I can’t really imagine doing anything else. Music’s always been important to me — just like it was for Mom, Mrs. Winfree. But maybe…” he paused again. There was a slight tug on his lips. “Maybe a chef? I know this one guy who’s absolutely sucked at cooking. He survived solely on a goat diet, only salads and greens, so I’ve been trying to help and… I think I like that feeling, you know? seeing people eat the food you cook, it’s kinda the same as seeing people listening to your music.”

Phainon could feel himself smiling. He didn’t remember ever watching this interview before, but he remembered that Mydei’s bandmates had called him GOATnon for a short while after, for reasons he was still confused about. He rewinded the video and stared at Mydei’s expression when talking about Phainon in the interview, glowing, alive, free.

Phainon closed his eyes.

Oh, sweet, sweet Kephale.

He really, really should talk to Mydei.

Phainon opened Mydei's chat room, pinned to the top, but had been silent for three long weeks. He tried to type in something: *Hello*, *Hey, I'm sorry, we should talk, are you well?* But nothing felt right.

No, *stop*.

Phainon had to stop thinking about what felt right. He had to start thinking about the truth.

Talk about *his truth.*

You
'Dei, hi. I know you're on tour, and I understand if it takes some time, but I'd still like to talk to you if you have a moment.
I mean, I could type it here, but I need to talk to you. In person. Through call. I need to talk to you.
I'll fly wherever you are if I have to.

Phainon sent the message and stared at his phone like a man possessed.

He waited, and waited, and waited, but no reply ever came through.

He waited until he fell asleep, waited as his battery was full and he had to leave to his layover hotel, waited as he stayed over the three-day layover, and glanced at his phone before he boarded the plane back for the ultra-long flight back to Okhema.

Still, no reply.

None.

Phainon tried to leave another message. He typed, and deleted, and typed again, and deleted…

And decided that maybe it's done.

Maybe Mydei truly hated him and didn't want to have anything to do with him anymore.

So Phainon boarded the plane, counting the 17-hour flight by the second, wondering if, in one of those passing seconds, Mydei had replied to his message.

But as he arrived at Okhema, he saw that nothing.

His chat remained the last in their window.

Phainon swallowed the lump in his throat and decided to get off the aircraft. He still didn't dare to go home, so going to HQ would be his best bet.

When he arrived there, however, Eleanor greeted him with a smile. She passed a neat envelope to Phainon with such a smug face that it made Phainon suspicious. He opened the envelope, and when he saw the words written in the paper tucked inside it, Phainon's eyes shot up so fast he almost had whiplash.

"No," he said.

"Yes, Captain. I did remind you that your hours in the sim program would be counted to your working hours," she said. "You've exceeded your working hours. Any more hours in this building, and you risk getting us fined and losing your license. Now we wouldn't want it, don't we?"

Of course, he didn't want that. Phainon gritted his teeth.

Ten days off.

What was he going to do in ten days? Where was he supposed to go in *ten fucking days*? He gritted his teeth, opening his mouth to argue again. But Eleanor shook her head, looking sympathetic.

"Maybe you should go home, Captain," she said, patting Phainon's shoulders before turning to leave. "You look like you really need a time-out with your loved ones. Visit your family, maybe? I'm sure they missed you."

Phainon sighed.

Family.

He thought about that dream about Concorde and wheat fields, about a lonely night in Styxia, about Cyrene, and about the facts about Mydei that he had just discovered, and thought that maybe Eleanor was right.

Maybe he should go home.

But before he went back to his apartment in the heart of Okhema City, he had to make a detour to his parents' home.

To Aedes Elysiae.

Chapter End Notes

yes, I know, I'm sorry! The happier part is in the next chapter! :D

Chapter 7: Paradise

Chapter Summary

Phainon come home, and find his paradise again.

Chapter Notes

This is the final part of the two-parts last chapter before the epilogue of the story! To avoid confusion, if the last part you read was mydei and phainon breaking up, then you wanna see chapter 6 first.

Sorry I have to split it in two! It's quite a long chapter >.<

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon didn’t want to sit another hour in an aircraft, so he took the overnight bus to Aedes Elysiae, hoping to fall asleep in their sleeping pod. He needed a break from his own mind, and waking up refreshed sounded really nice.

But he was restless the entire journey, not getting a wink of sleep.

He tossed around in the cramped pod, only to give up halfway, and decided to stare at the dark blur outside his window, replaying the scenes from the TabTube, thinking about Mydei, about their fight, about Aventurine’s words, about everything and nothing, all while still holding his phone, waiting for a message he knew wouldn’t come.

Too late.

He was far too late.

He probably hurt Mydei too much, beyond forgiveness. After all, Aventurine said that Mydei was trying his best to keep this relationship with Phainon. He tried, fighting the battle alone while Phainon and his stupid low self-esteem decided that he was not good enough for Mydei.

Stupid, stupid Phainon.

He savored the pain by scrolling through their old chats, the better time before they fell apart. The selfies, the random pictures, the teases and jokes… Phainon frowned at his own cold replies after that Owlbert interview, the poor facade he put that he realized now wouldn't fool Mydei.

Well, he deserved every bit of pain he was experiencing now.

If only he hadn't run out of tears, Phainon was sure that he would cry again now.

But he was hollowed out, and he didn't know if he could even feel something with his exhaustion.

When the bus finally entered Aedes Elysiae, dawn only began to rise from the horizon, washing the wheat field with golden color. It was beautiful, familiar, and Phainon let out a relieved sigh before he could even think of anything else. The view lightened the weight in Phainon's chest, and he was so, so glad that Eleanor forced him to rest and visit his family.

Maybe this was what he needed.

He strolled slowly, enjoying the view while walking towards his parents' home. There were so many sounds he missed: the bugs, the gentle breeze waving the leaves, the sound of his suitcase being dragged along the rocky road, and the sound of a morning bird chirping.

It all felt nice, though it didn't soothe the sting of the silence of his phone in the back pocket.

His house was just like the last time Phainon left it, washed by the gold from the rising sun. It looked too warm, too quiet, and as Phainon arrived on the porch, he could hear the sounds of activity inside; the people he loved were starting their day.

He closed his eyes and knocked on the door of his parents' home twice.

There was a muffled *wait for a minute* from the other side of the door, and in the next five seconds, Phainon was face-to-face with Audata, his mom.

Her smile faltered when she saw Phainon, and she shifted into mild surprise.

“Phainon?” she blinked. Phainon could see questions flicker in her eyes, but then, the first thing she asked was, “Are you okay?”

His automated answer was already in his tongue. *Yes, I’m fine. Sorry, I didn’t call.* But he couldn’t say them. He couldn’t speak those answers, because he knew it was a lie.

He couldn’t lie to his mother.

As if knowing Phainon’s turmoil, Audata opened her arms, inviting him for a hug.

Phainon rushed into her arms, and suddenly, he wasn’t feeling hollowed out anymore.

Emotions filled his chest like a flood, and then he cried again.

A silent sob at first, but as his mom hugged him tighter, as she soothed his back with circular motion, Phainon sobbed harder, inviting rushing footsteps from the kitchen; his father and Cyrene joined them at the door, worriedly asking *what happened, why Phai was here,* and then, the questions subsided, and he received more touches instead—Cyrene’s hand on his own, and his father’s pat on the back of his head.

They were surrounding him, engulfing them in their warmth, and Phainon felt a little bit stupid for not thinking to go to them sooner.

They guided him back to the dining room, patiently waiting for Phainon to stop crying. Cyrene offered him a warm milk, and his father, for some reason, insisted on baking him his signature goat-milk cheese meat pie. Hieronymus was always like that whenever he was confused about what to do: Keep moving, keep himself busy.

Phainon couldn’t help but smile at the parallel.

He was truly his father’s son.

And when he could finally be calm enough, Phainon told them *everything*.

The fake relationship, the social media posts, the listening party, the shoes, the nightmares, their inevitable breakup, and finally, his accidental meeting with Aventurine.

Audata paid him undivided attention and didn’t even interrupt him with questions. Cyrene did that in her stead, and his father cursed right as he burned his hand on the oven. Suspiciously, that timing lined up with the parts about Aventurine.

And as his stories rolled, voiced out loud for his ears to hear, Phainon could finally admit the parts where he could do better; he could have asked why Mydei said that the legacy was not more important than their relationship, when it was what he was living for the entire time Phainon knew him. He could have asked detailed updates on how Aventurine was annoying the heck out of Mydei, and he could have asked more about Robin to judge their friendship. Their actual partnership from Mydei’s real perspective, not the distorted speculation spoken by faceless names on the internet.

“No, don’t do that, honey. You cannot punish yourself for not knowing where to start,” Audata finally spoke, when Phainon finally finished. “I can’t imagine what it must feel like, being with someone whose world is entirely different than ours. I think it’s partly Mydei’s fault, too. He always kept you in the dark. He never let you in or helped you understand his world. It’s no surprise you stumbled.”

“But Mydei said it’s for the best,” Phainon said, feeling strangely defensive. “He wanted to protect me from the Dollywood Circus.”

“Which is kind of him,” Audata said gently.

She reached to brush Phainon’s hair, which felt sticky and damp from sweat.

“But honey, when two people decide to be in a relationship, they ought to have known that everything about them would affect each other, in one way or another. Protection doesn’t always mean shielding you from the bad and ugly in the world. Sometimes, it also means telling you all about it, so when he couldn’t protect you or Titans forbade, protect himself, you could do that instead for the both of you.”

Audata paused, glancing at Hieronymus when she continued.

“Love, protection, all are supposed to be a mutual exchange between two people who choose to be together. If one person tried to do everything, even in the name of love, it would end up being a disaster.”

His father placed the piping-hot meat pie in front of them, grunting and mumbling something that Phainon couldn’t quite hear, then continued to wash the dishes. Audata shook her head, smiling.

“It applies to you, too, honey,” she continued again, circling a thumb on the back of Phainon’s hand. “As much as Mydei had to tell you about the ugliness of his world, you also have to say to him about the ugliness in yours. The jealousy, the insecurity, they’re ugly, and messy, and maybe unbearable. But that’s the ugly Mydei had the right to know. Mydei never minded you walking around with bright yellow and tacky purple all around the village. Why do you think he’d be bothered by mere jealousy?”

“Mom,” Phainon groaned, to Cyrene’s snickers.

“Mom’s right, if anything, I think Mydei would consider it cute?” Cyrene chimed in. “You always look like you’re so chill about anything else. I’d say you’ll make him feel special with that little jealousy.”

Phainon let out a weak smile, slumping his shoulder as he idly circled his finger around the cup.

“I know, but I mean… I feel stupid even to feel that way,” he mumbled, suddenly feeling so small. “It’s not like it’s the first time. Mydei’s worked with Misia before. One of their old videos even had a female model sitting

on Mydei's lap. I didn't care then. I just don't understand why I'm like this now."

Cyrene hummed, propping her chin on her hand, and the room went quiet alongside her, as if everyone was thinking with her. Audata fixed her gaze on a specific area of the table, as if she were thinking about something.

"Is it possible…" she started. "That it's because you love Robin too, honey?"

Phainon raised his brows, looking at his mom, confused.

"Hm?"

"I mean, you always adore her. Robin is your favorite singer since you were a child," she said. "Back when Robin first played her first musical film, you walked out of the movies beaming. She's all you talked about the whole week. You watched her shows religiously on Clockie Channels. You even sang her song in your high school play, right? You grew up with her music. She's like the *Songstress Little Fairy* that always keeps you company. Do you remember that?"

Phainon gaped. He couldn't believe his mom remembered all that. Sure, he liked Robin—but was it really that intense?

He only remembered saving his pocket money for her CDs, working hard to get good grades just so his Dad would drive him to Janusopolis to watch her movies.

But the beaming? The nonstop chatter? Did he really do that? Phainon didn't remember it like that. He always thought that he liked Robin as any other of her fangirls would; humming her songs in the shower and in the car often enough that his partner started memorizing the lyrics.

Cyrene raised her brows. "Oh, I think it makes sense."

"But… how?" Phainon squeaked. "I mean, I like her as a singer, and I like Mydei as… a boyfriend. It's different, right?"

“Yes, but that difference is exactly what makes it hard, honey,” Audata said softly. “Maybe… you’ve always seen Robin not as a person, but as a star. Someone behind the television glass—dazzling, untouchable, not quite real. Maybe you never imagined her as a real person like the rest of us, let alone being in the same world as her. Then, Mydei stood next to her, and suddenly, she was real. Not just a face on a screen anymore.”

Audata paused, watching Phainon closely, carefully studying whatever expression Phainon was making.

Oh.

She must have seen something in Phainon’s eyes, because her eyes softened, and her fingers found his cheek, brushing at his damp skin gently.

“Then she visits your house, and she touches his arm, and she hugs him. And you realized that Mydei belongs in that world, too. So you start putting him in the same category as her—dazzling, distant, untouchable.”

“And because you’ve always admired her, it feels natural to believe he might admire her too. She’s a star. What’s not to like, right?” Cyrene added that she was apparently catching up with their Mom’s train of thought. “And when you see the way she looks at him, when you hear that she’s always been a fan of Mydei, you can’t help but think it mirrors your own feelings. You started to see her as someone who likes Mydei in that way, too. That’s where the lines blur.”

Audata reached for his cheek and patted it lightly, as she used to when he was sulking.

That… actually makes sense.

Phainon couldn’t help but think back at the glass walls nightmare, the ones he couldn’t reach.

Maybe that’s where his insecurities stemmed from.

“Mmm, I mean, you never really had competition for Mydei before,” Cyrene added. “And suddenly, he’s with *Robin*. Even if it’s fake, you’re watching the whole world *agree* on it—thousands of people saying she’s perfect for him. When it’s repeated everywhere, loud enough, your mind doesn’t get the space to resist it. It just starts to believe it.”

Phainon hummed. “Maybe,” he said. “That’s so lame, though.”

“Nah, it makes sense, Phai,” Cyrene shrugged. “It’s always you and him this whole time, and then… you’re suddenly outnumbered. And you give up not because you’re lame, but cause you’re always so kind. You always put others’ happiness before yourself. You’re far too generous that way.”

“And I guess your Mom was right,” Hieronymus said. Apparently, he had finished doing the dishes and sat on the other side of Phainon’s chair. “Sometimes loving honestly is far, far better than loving generously.”

Phainon opened his mouth, almost protesting.

But now that they were saying it out loud, he realized—he had never felt like he *couldn’t* be good enough for Mydei… until the fake relationship.

Until the anonymous random people on the internet tell him that she’s perfect for him. Like, sure, he had these fleeting thoughts of Mydei leaving him for someone else, but he never thought that he would be measured against *The* Robin. The most popular singer in the world, the child singer he grew up with, watched every news, who turned out to be just as talented, just as adorable, just as kind as Phainon always heard her to be. He never thought that his competition would be someone of that caliber.

And it hurt, because before this, there was no standard. No public consensus. He always knew he wasn’t in Mydei’s league, but he was trying—trying to be good, trying to be worthy, trying to stay by his side.

And that used to be enough.

Because no one had ever told him otherwise, no one had ever told him what’s actually good for Mydei.

Heck, not even Mydei himself.

Phainon pursed his lips, feeling as if, if he weren't so spent, another wave of tears would come. But he's exhausted, he's drained, so he could only smile.

"Damn, I should have talked to you sooner. I… guess this is just really what I need."

Cyrene huffed. "I told you so so many times that you should talk to me, you stupid, altruistic, self-destructive gigantic gremlin," she said with a raised voice, getting up to pinch both of Phainon's cheeks. "I was so worried about you! What's with all the silence anyway?"

"Ow ow! Aventurine told me I shouldn't tell anyone!" Phainon said, words garbled through pinched cheeks. "What was I supposed to do?"

"Ignore him!" Cyrene almost shouted.

"We're not just *anyone*! We're your family!" Hieronymus nodded, hands on his hips like he was actually mad, disappointed, and… well, vengeful. "It's really cruel for that man to ask you to keep it to yourself. I swear to Oronyx and all the Titans above, if I ever cross paths with that man, I will chase after him with a scythe."

Phainon chuckled. "Oh no, you wouldn't," he said. "That man is crazy rich and powerful. He even flies first class to Sigonia! We could buy three tractors with that kind of money."

"Then I'll chase him with a scythe straight to his tractor-sized first-class seat," Hieronymus huffed. "No one puts my son through that and walks away clean."

Phainon laughed, and so did Cyrene and Audata, at how silly that sounded. Hieronymus' serious face cracked with a ghost of a smile painted on his lips, and suddenly, Phainon felt like himself again. His heart was still hollow, and the pain still pulsed in the same rhythm as his heartbeat. But for the first time since his breakup, he thought that maybe he could be alright.

He was broken into so many pieces, but he'll be fine.

-

Phainon ate breakfast with his whole family, catching up on everything: the treatment for Audata's arthritis, Hieronymus' friends in the city whom he always sold his farmer's goods to, the village gossip, and even Cyrene's writing job. She was looking to get her second novel published, and Dan Heng had recently recommended that her novel, The Flame-chase Journey, be adapted into a TV series. That's why she was in Okhema a few days ago; she and Stelle were talking to Dan Heng's producer friend.

But even in such a beautiful, domestic setting, Phainon couldn't help but notice a slight change in the house compared to the last time he had visited. The dining table now had six chairs instead of four. He could imagine that perhaps Hieronymus had it replaced to accommodate more people—possibly Stelle, and… well, Phainon's partner.

Mydei, his heart whispered.

But Phainon only swallowed it down, averting his eyes from the empty chairs.

Now that he had stopped insisting on moving and keeping himself busy, Phainon could feel physical exhaustion catch up to him. He took a shower, changed into an old shirt that he kept in his own room, then lay on his bed, the bigger one that he bought the first time Mydei visited.

Phainon stared at the wall with his high-school photograph and memories, a sticker from the Robin-starred Clockie Studio movie he had watched with Caelus, Stelle, and Mr. Yang, that first time he was finally old enough to drive them to Janusopolis. Mr. Yang was wearing Queen Gorgo's shirt. It meant nothing to Phainon then. He always thought of it as just another band shirt with no emotional value.

Well, it’ll soon return that way, because he and Mydei were over.

Phainon grabbed his phone again, trying to push down his hopes.

There’s still no reply from Mydei.

Well.

That was his answer.

Phainon pressed the corner of his phone to his lips, closing his eyes, taking a deep breath, whispering soft prayers to Kephale before typing in another message to Mydei.

Not to beg, now.

But to get his closure.

You
Hi, ‘Dei. Sorry to disturb you (again).
I know this is out of nowhere, and far too late, and maybe you don’t want to do anything with me anymore. But I do think I owe you apologies.
Yes, plural. Cause I have so many things to apologize for.
I’m sorry I didn’t keep my promise to tell you about my discomfort right away.
I’m sorry I keep pushing you to your work and career. I thought that was what you wanted, you know? You always talk about your Mom so dearly, and so I want to give you as much space as you want to express that feeling.
I’m sorry I never asked you how to love you better and chose to pretend I know.
I’m sorry if I’m not there for you.
I’m sorry I didn’t listen more closely to your worries and fears.
Sorry I never asked.
I know it means nothing now, but I just want you to know that everything I did, I did it out of love. Even the lies, the rejections, I thought I was doing you a favor. I thought I was loving you the right way. I never meant any malice or bad intentions toward you.
I love you as you are. Not because you’re a Gorgo. But because you’re a

hot man with a damn powerful punch, damn good cooking skills, and a kind, gentle heart.
Good luck on tour. Have a good life. Eat well, always (´∀｀ゞ

Phainon allowed himself a little smile before he pressed send. He watched the checklist logo in the bottom corner of his messages, and then he went to sleep.

He must have been more exhausted than he let on, because he slept the whole day. No dreams nor nightmares, just a stretch of quiet void that allowed him to finally rest. Audata woke him up at dinnertime, telling him to eat since he had skipped lunch. Phainon whined, but once he was conscious, he realized how hungry he was.

So he dragged himself back to the kitchen, nodding in his chair while Hieronymus scolded him for falling asleep on his meal.

“Snowy, don’t sleep now. You should wait at least half an hour before going back to sleep,” Hieronymus said, poking Phainon’s hand while he was asleep in the living room.

“Mmm, sleepy.”

“I know. You can sleep again in half an hour. Stay awake a little while longer.”

“Dad…” Phainon drawled.

“Dad, just let him be just this once,” Phainon could hear Cyrene’s voice, sounding amused. “Tomorrow’s gonna be a huge day for Phai.”

“Mmm, why’s that?” Phainon yawned, still half asleep.

“I don’t know, just feel like it,” Cyrene chirped. “Come on, if you’re gonna go back to sleep, at least get comfortable in your own bed. Don’t sleep here, you’ll wake up with a stiff neck.”

Phainon dragged himself back to his room and fell asleep again to the sound of owls' hoots and cicadas. It was a dreamless sleep again, a peaceful kind that left Phainon waking up fresh in the morning, feeling like a new person entirely.

Well, maybe it's a good day to start moving on.

Phainon walked downstairs, feeling fully energized. He helped his mom with breakfast, with dishes, with Big Snowy's breakfast, and then, because it was supposed to be the first day of harvest, he also decided to help out in the field. Cyrene frowned when he saw Phainon put on his straw hat, crossing her arms in disagreement.

"What?"

"Aren't you exhausted?" she asked.

"Nope, I've never felt any better in my life," Phainon said. "I'm super refreshed! Can't you see?"

"Hmm," Cyrene hummed, her lips still twisted. "But you deserve rest! Besides, why would *Captain Khaslana* do such manual labor? You should just enjoy yourself while you're here! Act like a tourist once in a while."

Phainon furrowed his brows. "No, I'm not Captain Khaslana in this house," he said, put on his hat anyway, and grinned. "I'm just Phainon."

Just Phainon.

After so many weeks mourning over his ordinary status, how he was a nobody compared to Mydei or Robin, it felt weird to think about how meaningless his worries were. Being just himself was never a shame. It was not supposed to be something to fuss about. But the Dollywood glam disliked *ordinary.* They like everything gleaming and sparkly, and they stomped over ordinary.

It made Phainon feel a little bad for Mydei. He hoped he could still offer him a sanctuary, a home where he could be himself. A hometown small

enough that it did not have room for status or fame, where being yourself was good enough.

Well—

“Mom! Tell him to rest!” Cyrene said when Audata passed by them. “Tell him to stay at home!”

“Why are you so hellbent on insisting that I stay—”

“Oh, you’re going out? That’s great,” Audata said. “Please get Big Snowy to the field with you, and tell your Dad that Mister Watt will come earlier this afternoon to pick up the apples.”

Cyrene shook her head while Phainon chuckled, walking out of his house and whistling to get his dog. He then walked to where his father and the rest of the farmers were already harvesting the spring wheat.

It was exhausting, as it required him to be more active than his usual pilot job. But Phainon enjoyed it, regardless. It felt nice to slow down, to have a place that stays the same despite the passing of time, while the world outside moved so fast it became blurry and unrecognizable.

Phainon gazed at the sun crawling up to the bright, blue sky, feeling a little bit like he was cheating for having peace and quiet while he left Mydei in that noisy world where everyone screamed his name so loud that maybe he couldn’t even hear himself.

He closed his eyes, praying that Mydei could someday find this kind of peace and quiet again.

As time crawled closer to lunch time and the sun was finally too hot to be on the field, Hieronymus called for a break and suggested that it was finally lunch time. Phainon ran excitedly, feeling famished after giving his snacks to Big Snowy. But apparently, Cyrene and Audata forgot to bring his lunch. Cyrene, specifically, said he might have to go home to eat.

“Maybe get some rest, too,” she said with a smile.

Phainon frowned. “You don’t forget my lunch,” he accused. “You do that on purpose so I can go back home.”

She giggled. “Maybe.”

“She’s just looking out for you, son,” Hieronymus said with a knowing smile. “And I’m on her side. Go rest. I can handle the rest of the day just fine. I might be old, but I’m still strong, you know.”

Phainon shook his head in disbelief, but the ghost of a smile hung on his lips. He decided to just do what they want and get Big Snowy to come home with him to rest.

They were not completely wrong. Now that Phainon had done some real physical activities, he could feel the residual exhaustion from his long weeks still lingering in his bones, and the idea of watching TV until he falls asleep is starting to feel so tempting.

Yeah, that sounds like a plan.

When he was close enough to home, however, Big Snowy suddenly perked up, barking far too excitedly and bolting so fast that Phainon had to run just to keep up with him. His dog circled the front door, jumping and barking at the handle repeatedly, as if it could be magically opened if he was excited enough.

“Hey, hey, slow down, buddy,” Phainon chuckled as he opened the door. “What’s getting you all too excited?”

The dog ran straight to the kitchen, barking and rambling happily. Phainon walked into the kitchen, still laughing.

“Mom, did you make slow-cooked beef for lunch? Cause I’ve never seen Big Snowy look so happy since—”

Phainon’s words were cut when he stepped into the kitchen and saw who was standing behind the counter.

Not his mom.

Now that he thought about it, Audata was out in the field with Cyrene.

“Hey,” the man’s low, heavy voice sobered him from his own thoughts.

The man was blond-haired, with red tattoos swirling across his limbs and shoulders and disappeared behind the white cotton shirt. He wore dark jeans as if he didn’t have any brighter clothes. He looked exhausted, like he had just gone through a world tour.

Phainon did not dare to blink. He was afraid that if he let his eyes shut even for a moment, the man would disappear.

This must be a dream.

This *had* to be a dream.

The man looked totally out of place, not just because he was in Phainon’s childhood home, but also because he was holding a spatula, and the soft bubbling of what smelled like mushroom sauce behind him filled the air with its savory delicacy. Big Snowy still barked happily, circling around his feet like he was happy to see him.

Big Snowy was only that excited when he smelled beef and when he saw Mydei.

Mydei.

Mydei. *Mydei*.

Mydei, who was supposed to be on tour.

He couldn’t be here. He had a tight schedule, he left Phainon’s message unread, he—

“I—I’ve got a show in Janusopolis this weekend,” Mydei said. “It’s close by, so I thought, maybe I could stop by before the weekend starts. Cyrene said it’s okay.”

Janusopolis. Right.

Right.

Phainon's heart raced, from the run home or from seeing Mydei in his parents' kitchen, where he was just crying his heart out the morning before, Phainon didn't know. He still couldn't move, still couldn't say anything, still convinced that it's a dream.

"You said you wanna talk," Mydei said quietly, like he was afraid that he would tear this place apart if he spoke louder. "So I'm here to talk. But I gotta finish cooking for a bit. Sit down, would you?"

Sure.

Phainon wasn't sure if he spoke it out loud. He moved automatically, as if Mydei's orders had given his limbs a life of their own. He still watched Mydei's every move: finishing the food, feeding Big Snowy the meat he had just cooked, plating the food he had cooked for Phainon, and pouring the olive juice from the juicer.

He placed both the plate and the glass in front of Phainon.

And the smell, the warmth that radiated from the food, from Mydei, felt so real that it sobered Phainon.

"Is this a dream?" Phainon finally voiced it out loud.

Phainon could hear a scoff tinted by humor from Mydei. He leaned across the table, closer to Phainon,

And then, he pulled a handful of Phainon's hair.

"Ow!" Phainon exclaimed.

Mydei laughed and pulled it again playfully.

"Ow! Ow! Mydei, what's that for?"

Mydei scoffed, letting go of his hold. "Still thinking this is a dream?"

“Damn you, don’t you know how strong you are, *Mighty Mouse*,” Phainon sulked. But the pounding in his heart didn’t subside. Mydei’s smile faltered; there was a flicker in his eyes that looked like a mix of longing, guilt, joy, and… fear.

“Sorry it took me a while to reply to your message,” Mydei said, finally. “I was confused and tired. And I think I was a little bit ashamed too about what happened last time. I’m sor—”

“No, no, no, don’t apologize. *I’m* sorry,” Phainon interrupted frantically. His hand hovered over Mydei’s, but he pulled it back, not sure if he was still allowed to do that. It was strange, it was the closest he was to Mydei for the past week, and yet it felt so fragile, and Phainon was so afraid that he would ruin it beyond repair… again. “I’m sorry I rejected you. I’m sorry I didn’t listen to you and…”

“Phainon,” Mydei said firmly.

Phainon paused. “Y… yeah?”

“Let me talk first.”

Phainon blinked. “Oh,” he cleared his throat. “Y… Yeah, okay.”

Mydei let out a quiet sigh. He placed both hands on the table, his fingers slightly fiddling with each other. He held his gaze on Phainon, then at his own fingers, then back at Phainon.

“Cyrene told me everything,” Mydei said, finally. “What happened from your point of view. And your Mom’s advice. And… and about my world. I…” Mydei paused. “Before I say anything else, I think I owe you an apology. Sorry, I didn’t let you in. Sorry, I insist on keeping you away from my world, hiding you from the public like you’re a dirty little secret. I thought I did it to protect you. But I… ended up deserting you.”

Phainon paused. Mydei still didn’t give him a sign to allow him to speak, so he held his tongue while Mydei paused, probably rehearsing words in his mind, or simply doing mental preparation. This was a talk overdue between

them, after all. And Phainon understands that it must not be easy for Mydei.

“I have to be completely honest with you,” he said. “You were right about me already halfway agreed to the plan when we came to Mnestia Tower. The first proposal I heard from Aglaea was that Robin wants to help amplify Mom’s music in her own way, and she would do it in my term. That almost sounds too good to be true, but regardless, I’m game with the collaboration. But I didn’t expect you to nod along.”

He shifted his eyes to Phainon now. His eyes hardened.

“I expected you to at least show some degree of disagreement. I was anticipating your distaste, whatever. I was afraid of what you would think or do. Because in my head, had it been you staged to be in a fake relationship with someone else, I would definitely throw a fit.”

Mydei smiled quietly, more to himself than to Phainon, because even though he looked at Phainon, there was still some distance there.

“It was too good to be true that Robin wants to do it in *my* term, and you agreed to it so easily. I thought that it would blow up in my face. So I rely on you to stop me,” Mydei said. “I warned you, and I waited, watched your every reaction, so I know when to stop. But it’s hard to try to decode you when we couldn’t always see each other. It didn’t help that when we did, you seemed to be okay with everything, so I think, cool, maybe we’ll do this. But then you start to drift apart, and I’m starting to lose you, and I don't know where I should fix when you are always saying that you’re okay, that this is important for you, too, and that’s…”

Mydei paused again, and this time, he turned away from Phainon.

Phainon could feel the pain in his heart start to pulse again. “I’m sorry,” he said, because Mydei was quiet for quite a long time, and he thought that maybe it was safe to speak now. “That’s where I should be honest. I’m sorry I don’t keep my promises to speak what I feel, ‘Dei. I’m sorry, I thought I was being supportive. It wasn’t all your fault. I should have asked what you feel about the whole thing, too. I should have asked if you even

want to carry your Mom's legacy. I simply assumed, and I ended up becoming the echo that you always hear over and over for your entire career."

At that, Mydei shot his eyes up, staring at Phainon with total shock. Phainon pressed his lips.

Nothing but the truth.

He deserved it, at least. They both did.

"I saw your old interview videos," Phainon admitted. "And it's crazy that I didn't do it sooner. I mean, we've been dating for four years, and I never once thought about looking you up on social media past your official releases. But I finally did, and I noticed how people kept bringing up your mom whenever they had the chance, and… you just went along with it. You even joked about it most times."

Phainon paused, taking a deep breath.

"But when you began fake-dating Robin, you never did that anymore. Maybe I was too jealous about you bringing up your Mom whenever you're with her, saluting her in the studio, and how much Gorgo would love her to ever think of it as anything else other than adoration. And it got worse because everyone was saying that your mom would have wanted you to marry her. But…"

Phainon let out a quiet smile. His fingers fiddled on the table.

"But I guess now that I could move past that feeling, I understand why you do it. I mean, I know it's crazy that I just made an assumption about it, but Dei, I understand why you always consistently place the spotlight on Robin and give her the center stage. I know you respect her, but it was not just respect or adoration. I think…"

"... I'm also trying to place my Mom's legacy on her," Mydei said with a bitter smile. There was a drop of tears coming from his eyes. Once, and

then the rest follows. “Yeah, you’re right. Congratulations, Phainon. You’re the first to crack my cowardice.”

He sighed, and Phainon pressed his lips, watching as Mydei’s breath grew heavy, as if he was physically carrying the weight of his Mother’s name.

“No, ‘Dei…”

“All my life,” Mydei started. “All my fucking life, people have always said to me that she’s gone too soon. That if Mom hadn’t been pregnant with me, she would still be alive, be the bombastic sensation she would be. My own old man was pushing me to be a singer since I could speak, and every time I go on to the stage, they always watch me expectantly, waiting for that Gorgo sensation that they thought Mom would inherit for me, and nod with disappointment when I don’t deliver the same electricity as she always had. I was always so afraid I would let her down, so I tried my best. I promised myself I would try my best, even if it costs me my whole life. But I always lack something. The same bombastic charm, the same rockstar edge—I don’t even know what they expect anymore. I was chased by the thoughts that I owed her my music, my life, and the only way I could pay it was by carrying her legacy. So I did just that, hoping that someday I’ll get it right. People will get the closure, and I’ll deliver my duty. Maybe then, I will finally be free. But I can never live up to her. I couldn’t even finish half the songs she left behind. Maybe I could, if I’d been born a woman. But it’s just… not me.”

Mydei clenched his fists, his shoulders visibly shaking. Phainon instinctively reached for Mydei again, but he held it back.

“‘Dei…”

“When I heard Robin’s demo songs, when I saw her in the recording booth, I found clarity. All this time, I have always fallen short because I am not a woman. And Robin is a woman, so I put two and two together and thought that maybe it didn’t have to be me, specifically. I think it makes more sense for a woman to carry another woman’s legacy. So I talked to Robin about it, and she was hesitant. Not because she thinks that she couldn't do it, but if

she were to take Mom away from me. Heh. Like I didn't spend my whole life trying to get out of her shadow."

Mydei scoffed. He let out a dry laugh at a humor that only he could understand. But there was a tear dropping from his eyes.

"So I began to relate her to Mom every chance I get. It was a fair deal between us. Rob got to rock and get out of her Clockie Princess persona, and I got to be away from Mom's name. The ruse was maintained strongly. It sounded like a win, except I didn't think that you could perceive it differently. I guess I was too desperate to be free."

Mydei let out a little sob now, so quiet that Phainon could barely hear it. He wondered how many times Mydei had done this, crying quietly to himself so no one would hear.

"But 'Dei, that's not your fault," Phainon said. "I also lied to you, insisting that I'm okay."

Mydei let out a humorless laugh. "Oh, please, I was being hypocritical too," he said. "I was mad at you for lying to me, while I'm doing it myself. I kept you in the dark about how cowardly I am because I don't want you to think I'm an ungrateful bastard. Because you seemed to think highly of my Mom, too. I was afraid that the reason you like me is partly that I am my mother's son."

"You think I'd ever do that to you?" Phainon asked, voice breaking.

Mydei smiled sadly. "I don't know. But I didn't want to take my chances. What you think of me is very important to me."

Mydei's voice was small, almost sulky, like a child who had just admitted that he stole the last piece of the cake.

That broke Phainon's heart.

"You know," Phainon said softly, "the reason I was so insistent… was because you were glowing when you were singing with her. That time in

the studio, that time when you two were talking, I thought you were happy. I thought you were proud to finally release her work that had been dusting in the corner. I thought that you were looking so joyful, in a way that I had never seen before… and I never did that to you. We dated for four years, and I could never help you the way Robin could. So I think… I think my presence only held you down."

Mydei shook his head. "I guess that's my fault, too, for never showing you expressions during our time together. You might never guess, but I'm happiest when I'm with you, Phainon," he said. "I mean, don't get me wrong. You were right about the collab, it made me happy. I did. I was so overjoyed. Because, despite everything, I love Mom. I love her music. As heavy as her legacy was on my shoulders, I also love carrying it for her. But I was mostly happy to see my way out of her shadow. But when the PR stunt chipped away at what we had, and you started mentioning her, I thought What if I made a mistake? What if this plan I had to get out of her shadow would make you love me less? Maybe part of the reason you dated me was that I am a son of Gorgo. And if I let go of her name…"

"Dude, stop," Phainon hissed. "I am more of a folk guy, remember? I didn't even know about your mom before I dated you."

Mydei shook his head. "Yeah, folk guy, whatever. But I can't help that thought eat me alive. It's been repeated enough times since I was a child."

Phainon pressed his lips. "Fair point," he said. "Then it's my fault, too, for not making my feelings clear. I never admitted to you that I'm jealous of Robin. People said she had always had a crush on you. And the way you praise her, I thought you started to see that dating her would be better than dating a nobody like me."

Mydei smiled again. "Robin always liked rock," he said. "She told me that she's been trapped in that Clockie Studio since she was five. They had a long contract for her. She had always wanted freedom to express her true passion. Some songs she wrote were from her early teenage years. The studio discarded it every time. Nobody in that gigantic company wanted to follow up on her passion project, afraid that she would flop and ruin her own name, until Aven stepped in with that PR stunt of his."

Phainon raised his brows. “Aventurine?”

Mydei hummed. “The management only agreed to *Robin Goes Rock* if they got insurance. He proposed *me* as his insurance. He gambled on me and ended up setting both Robin and me free from our restraints.”

Phainon scoffed. So it was true, what Aventurine said. He always placed his bet in the right hands.

“But we sacrificed your feelings in the process,” Mydei added again.

Phainon shook his head. “I did that to myself. You’ve done more than enough to take care of me,” he said. “And honestly… I’m glad it happened. Without it, Robin wouldn’t get to chase the genre she loves, and you’d still be stuck under your mom’s shadow.”

Mydei’s eyes softened. “If I’d known losing you was the risk, I never would’ve agreed. That’s too high a price. You may be a person who could love someone enough to let go, but I’m not. “ I will not let go of a person when I have a choice to fight for them.” He let out a smile, then added, “Rob said the same. She was terrified her wish would hurt you. She wanted to be your friend, so it would be easier for you to see me with her. But… you’re always so starstruck when she’s around. She never knew what to do around you that wouldn’t make you feel awkward.”

Phainon laughed. “Yeah, I guess I am,” he said. “It’s so uncool.”

“Good thing I didn’t date you because you’re cool,” Mydei grinned, the teasing in his voice was back.

Phainon giggled, and for a while, silence filled the room, while Phainon was gazing at his hand, open and just a few tiny inches away from Mydei.

“The lipstick was her idea too, you know,” Mydei spoke again. “When… *that* happened on the stage, I threw a fit. Everyone left me alone, afraid of the tantrum-rockstar. But she was there, she stood with me even though I shot curses at her, cried with me, and she said apologies a million times. She was the one who came up with the idea to reverse the narrative. The

public always overwrote you. The shoes, the choker... She said maybe we should use the lipstick to kiss you. To show you that I don't let the public overwrite us again. To claim the story and make it ours. I was so desperate to make up to you that I went with her idea."

Phainon blinked, stunned. He hadn't thought Robin could be that considerate. He didn't know that Robin would care so much about his feelings. He almost felt a little bit ashamed for thinking badly about her.

"And it was adorable," Phainon said. "It should have worked, but by the time it happened, I was already consumed with the idea that you don't want me anymore. You'd better be off with Robin."

Mydei shrugged. "Maybe next time, we should talk about it instead. Just like what your mom said."

"Agreed," Phainon said. "I'm sorry I rejected you, 'Dei. I'm sorry I didn't come clean with what I feel. I'm sorry, I thought that I would lose you, and yet I didn't put up any fight to keep our relationship. I should have told you very clearly how much I love you."

That seemed to spark something inside Mydei. He blinked, looking surprised, but then he grinned.

"Then tell me now, Phainon," he murmured, voice barely above a whisper. There was a flicker of fear in his eyes, like he needed to hear it again just to believe it. "Say that word again, and say it like you really mean it this time."

"I love you," Phainon said, closing the space between their hands on the table and placing his palm over Mydei's, fingers intertwining. "I love you, 'Dei. I love you, Honeycake. I love you, I love you so so much, I love you *Kotik*."

"I love you too," Mydei replied. "I love you so fucking much, you have no idea."

"So work on that, you lazy little cat. Let me *have the idea*."

“Fucking hell, you stupid dorky dog. Come here, then.”

Phainon leaned across the table to kiss him, and Mydei met him with enthusiasm. The chair scraped loudly on Phainon’s side as he shifted forward. It was an awkward angle, his neck strained too far—but he kissed him anyway. Gently. Passionately. Wholeheartedly.

Like he meant the whole world, this time.

Because that was the truth.

The pieces of his heart slid back into place like a puzzle, the cracks filled with gold, like kintsugi. Making the broken even more beautiful, shining, gleaming.

And as he breathed Mydei’s sigh, again, the sweet smell of him, the warmth of his skin, the smile that he showed as he stared at Phainon, he thought that, well, he wouldn’t mind walking through that hell again, or watching his sanctuary fall in ruins.

If it means that he’ll be here, in Mydei’s arms, where his real paradise lies.

Chapter End Notes

> If you feel that they deserve more, indeed they do! I did thinking about writing a happier epilogue with Robin, Aven, and obviously, just with our boys, hence I added extra chapter.
>
> Thank you again for reading. I hope you enjoyed it!

Chapter 8: Epilogue: Mydei

Chapter Summary

> As he and Phainon reunited, Mydei reminisced about what had happened between him and Phainon, while moving forward to do better and love him better.

Chapter Notes

> Ah finally the ending! My apologies for putting this off for so long. I joined Phaidei week and I got caught at work and... well, hehe, here we are.
> Again, I thank Noriko my best girl for listening to my ramble about this, for inspiring me with the pretty-nails stories, and with her love aaa thank you friend! this one is for you!
>
> Oh, and I switched the POV to Mydei to explain some of the parts that I couldn't in Phainon's angle. I hope you enjoy it regardless!
>
> Thank you again for reading, commenting, and leaving kudos up to this point. It is truly an honor for me >.<

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It felt like a dream that was too good to be true.

Mydei was in Phainon’s parents’ house in Aedes Elysiae, cooking in Phainon's mom’s kitchen, wearing Cyrene’s apron, kissing Phainon…

Kissing Phainon.

This had felt so far out of reach a week ago: the silence, the distance, the fear lodged in his chest; the last time they’d seen each other, he’d walked out, feeling betrayed and unloved—and Phainon hadn’t done anything to stop him.

This felt like a dream, still, when he was getting used to the hollow clawing at him so persistently that he almost felt like he had lost his heart altogether.

This felt too much like a paradise.

Perhaps he had a car crash on his way to Aedes Elysiae, and he was dead, and this was the heaven that the holier men promised. Maybe this wasn't Phainon at all but an angel wearing his face…

… until Phainon bumped their noses and *umph'd* into his mouth.

Mydei smiled into the kiss.

Yeah, no. Angels couldn't be this awkward.

This was definitely *his* Phainon.

Mydei wanted to put away the table that kept them apart to kiss him until sundown, to embrace him, to cling to him till the morning comes to make up for the time they drifted apart for the past three weeks, but they were in Audata's kitchen. Any of Phainon's parents (and Cyrene!) could walk in any moment, and a literal big dog was huffing around Mydei's ankles, campaigning for seconds. He broke the kiss, told Phainon to finish lunch, and fed Big Snowy.

This felt like a movie flashback, where Mydei tended to Phainon's pet while Phainon was eating his food, staring at him with that puppy-like excitement in his eyes and a smile that could put the sun to shame.

But he was here, it was all real, and he got to have this moment again; the countryside nostalgic feeling he never had, the small loving family he never got to experience, and a simple moment of domesticity with a man whom he loved and loved him in return, despite all the insecurities, misunderstandings, and the unspoken truth between them.

The man who had given him a home, when Mydei never dared to dream of a place to belong.

Mydei still couldn't believe how Cyrene contacted him yesterday, when he was just finishing the rehearsal for the concert on the weekend. She texted him *urgent!!!!!!!!!!* with that many exclamation marks, and Mydei was scared that it was about Phainon, that maybe Phainon finally found someone else. Someone who was less complicated than Mydei, whose whole life wasn't a preloaded shell filled by his dead mother's legacy, and…

Mydei shook his head, considering what Ratio told him about "keeping your mind from wandering too far", and picked up his phone to call Cyrene.

She told him everything.

Phainon's angle, Audata's advice, and everything in between, uncensored—including Mydei's mistakes (Cyrene, Mydei learned, had no qualms about talking shit to his face) and, of course, Phainon's shortcomings.

You two are in the wrong, if I'm gonna be honest, she said calmly, like she was just listing groceries instead of stripping Mydei of his flaws. *You can't just quietly go out and keep him in the dark about what you do in the name of protection. Because sure, you could protect him from the external factors, but you're ignoring the demons in his mind that could thrive from him not knowing.*

And he loves you, Mydei. But we both know he's just a dumbass. He thought you had found the better love there in the Dollywood spotlight where he couldn't be. He knew it was a ruse, but he couldn't help but think that he held you back. That he would never understand your world, and so he removed himself from the picture…

"He thought a lot of things, but he never asked a single thing," Mydei had said then.

Because Mydei knew that it wasn't true at all, if Phainon asked him, Mydei would confidently say that he would never find a better love in Dollywood. Sure, they exchange the word love so easily, so expressively, but it was all different kinds of love altogether; it was mostly a play pretend, an off-hand remark to admire someone's art, the person they presented, the fame they

earned, but rarely the man within. Strip Mydei of everything he owned; his name, his fame, his music, and no one will ever look at him twice.

And he was confident to say that because he had stepped into the spotlight since he was very young. He had witnessed the industry for over a decade, and never had he ever seen real love formed in Dollywood. It was always an exchange of benefits, mostly. His parents were proof enough. But it was not a surprise at all, once you got there. What do you expect from a world that weaponizes feelings into profits and marketable jargon?

Still, Mydei told Cyrene that he wasn't mad at Phainon. He admitted his own mistake, too. He had been in the industry so long that he had forgotten that not everyone could see the inside as clearly as he did. Phainon most likely couldn't differentiate the thin line between admiration, lust, and love in the Dollywood language. Because for him, it was *love* all the same. No motives, no ruse. Sure, Mydei had assured him to make it absolutely clear to Phainon what to expect in the PR stunt he approved to include Mydei in, including the unexpected. But he should have always assumed that Phainon didn't know.

Because he *didn't*, and they should have known better not to let the silence stretch because Phainon would always rather destroy himself than admit to the people he loves that he was hurting.

"He's just so like Dad. He'd rather suffer in silence than talk. He once had a problem with a loan shark to pay off Phainon's pilot school, and he did not tell any of us. We only knew when he got punched for being one day late," she huffed into the phone. "Phainon suffered the same trait, sadly. And you! You should talk to him about everything that you meant. Clear things up, if you really care about Phainon. I'll help set you two up to talk, because Phainon would never ask, and if I say that I could call you for him he'd be like 'oh no, Mydei is so busy I don't want to be a bother' *or crap like that. So it's gotta be you, if you truly want to mend things with him!"*

And Mydei wasn't convinced then, still thinking that Phainon might not like him that way anymore. But then Phainon texted him, saying all the sappy, stupid things, and between all of that vomit of words, he said *I love you* once.

Once. And it’s already enough to convince him.

So he asked Krateros to arrange a ride to Aedes Elysiae by the end of the night. The old man only raised his brows, looking somewhat amused.

Oh,” he said. “Something urgent there?”

“Phainon,” Mydei answered shortly.

Krateros nodded, like it’s the only reason that ever makes sense. “Is he okay?”

“He is,” Mydei answered again. “We just need to talk.”

“As you should,” Krateros nodded, already pulling up a phone. “Say hello to him for me, yeah? I’m glad you two are okay.”

Mydei paused. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

“You tell me,” Krateros scoffed. “Your brothers in the band had been worried sick about you these past few weeks, and Robin had asked me to talk to you about the whole fake-dating arrangement every chance she got. They thought you would listen to me,” he shook his head. “Bold assumptions. You never listen to anyone but Aglaea and Phainon.”

Mydei rolled his eyes, a little bit surprised that his friends noticed his silence. “No, they’re not.”

“Whatever,” he said. “Come back happier, Mydeimos.”

Mydei had thought how bad he looked for Krateros to even talk like that. But he ignored it and continued going about his day, clinging to the ray of hope he had from Cyrene.

And then, here they are.

When Phainon finally finished his lunch, he asked Mydei to *watch movies till we napsies* in the living room, saying that he was too tired to go back to the field. Mydei didn’t mind cuddling with Phainon, but imagining Audata,

Hieronymus, or Cyrene walking in on them limb on limb made Mydei feel a little uncomfortable. So he asked to watch the movies in Phainon's room instead, sharing a small laptop screen that reflected sunlight from the window.

"I'll buy a big TV later," Phainon said when the movie started. His voice was already sounding a little bit sleepy. "I'll put it there, so we can watch movies here more conveniently whenever we're here."

Mydei hummed. "This is okay."

Wrong.

Calling it just *okay* was an understatement.

This was more than okay.

He had his body half on top of Phainon, his head tucked under Phainon's left jaw, and he could hear Phainon's heartbeat from his ear stuck to Phainon's upper chest.

This was already the most perfect place Mydei had ever been for the past four weeks.

Mydei didn't even pay attention to the movie anymore, wholly absorbed in Phainon's presence. The smell of his body mixed with the scent of the sun from the field. His warmth. The rise and fall of his breath, syncing with the harmony of their heartbeats…

Mydei adjusted his head, burying his nose in Phainon's shoulder, closing his eyes as he mentally chased the dawning melody in his mind while Phainon massaged his scalp idly, his fingers tangled between Mydei's blond mane.

The melody was soft like Phainon's bed, warm like his embrace, gentle like Aedes Elysiae's winds, and flowed like a freshwater stream. It was different from Sons of Gorgo's music, completely tame when compared with his Mother's beats. This music was just as lovable as Phainon, the sound woven

from the fragments of Phainon’s entire being that Mydei had witnessed and loved.

The harmony that was entirely *his*.

His feelings. His stories. His heart. His devotion to Phainon and the memories they had woven together, the very ones Mydei held very closely in his heart, the ones he wished to preserve beyond his lifetime. The memories Phainon allowed him to keep echoed through the grand hall of his own mind, singing to him as if it were the only thing that mattered.

The breath of Phainon’s body, the whisper that spoke his mind, the vibration of his soul, the echoes of his stories, the cadence of the familial love he shared with Mydei…

And maybe, maybe the sound of Phainon’s name, too.

Mydei felt almost guilty, as if Phainon were giving him a dime, even though Mydei had taken millions from him. Mydei should take it slowly; he should just listen to the sounds present with him now—just this piece of Phainon in this room, and nothing else.

But that harmony kept playing in his mind, insisting that Mydei breathe life into it, make it an undying melody that could live infinitely in the passage of time.

“You’re humming,”

Phainon’s quiet voice added a ripple to the flow in Mydei’s mind. It didn’t disrupt it; it enriched it like the sound of rain pouring down to the river. “I‘ve never heard of that song. Is it new?”

“Mmhmm,” Mydei hummed. “Mine.”

Phainon didn’t say anything else, knowing exactly what to do, while a fresh wave of inspiration suddenly struck Mydei. Even in the silence, their harmony was so loud. Phainon’s exhale, the sound of his fingers idly playing with the fabric of Mydei’s shirt…

It took quite a while for him to stop, and when he finally quieted down, he could hear Phainon humming along to the melody he had created, which Phainon himself was the inspiration.

“Do that again,” Mydei opened his eyes, tilting his head to meet Phainon’s eyes.

“The humming? Sure.”

Phainon followed Mydei’s lead, humming to the melody that Mydei created. He captured it perfectly, and it made Mydei grin, because Phainon’s melody sounded so lovely in his voice.

“Perfect,” Mydei hummed. “Can I have you record that hum for the song later?”

Phainon blinked, looking surprised. “Um… are you sure?” he said.”I mean, I… okay,” Phainon chuckled. Must be because of looking at Mydei’s narrowed eyes. “Alright, wow, look at me, debuting as a professional hummer.”

“HKS,” Mydei playfully punched Phainon’s belly. Phainon laughed and returned the punch with the same intensity (which wasn’t a lot, honestly. They were too lazy to actually be a threat to each other).

“That doesn’t sound like Sons of Gorgo material,” Phainon commented. “You guys go for a slower ballad this time?”

“No, that song’s not ours,” Mydei said. “*Mine*.”

Phainon’s fingers that massaged Mydei’s scalp paused. “Um… yours?”

Mydei grabbed Phainon’s other hand, tracing a random pattern on the back of his hand. “After this summer tour,” he said. “The band will take a two-year hiatus.”

“Oh?” Phainon sounded genuinely surprised. “Really, why?”

“Remember when I said Leonnius’s wife is pregnant with twins?” Mydei asked. Phainon hummed an answer, so Mydei continued. “When they went in for the last check before labor, they found out the twins had been hiding a third sibling all along. He had triplets, and Leonnius decided to help take care of them at least until they reached infancy. Perdikkas also said he was thinking about enrolling in med school, and with the two of us gone, we thought maybe it’s time to take a break. Since I graduated high school, we have always gone from tour to tour, studio to studio. We barely have time for ourselves.”

Phainon hummed again, but he didn’t say anything else, seeming content to listen to Mydei.

“So the rest of us decided to look for something to do, too, during the two-year break. Hephaestion got an invitation to be a judge in the School of Rock variety show in Jarilo. That Serval lady had been asking him since the first season. Peucesta and Ptolemy wanted to help compose the music for a Stage Play in Kremnos, while starting their own recording label. It’s a small label under Chrysos Records to help independent musicians rise. Do you wanna know what it’s called?”

“What?” Phainon asked.

“Gorgo Records,” Mydei couldn’t help but feel his own lips curve into a smile. “They said it’s to continue mom’s legacy too. Mom saved em from the street, so they wanna do the same to the kids from Kremnos.”

“That’s so cool. I’m so happy for them.”

Mydei could hear a smile in his words, and it’s so cute that he couldn’t believe that he would let *that* get away from him. He tightened his hold on Phainon.

“And… what about you?” he asked, brushing a thumb on Mydei’s cheek. “What are you planning to do during the two-year hiatus?”

Mydei shifted their position so they could see each other. Phainon looked gorgeous like this. His skin was a bit darker from the sunburn, but it

somehow made his blue-sky eyes brighter and softer.

“I’m thinking of doing a few solo projects,” he said. “Robin is going to launch a full album next year, a pop-rock album that sounds like Queen Gorgo. The collab's revenue and good PR are finally making the studio confident enough to let her rock. And with her practically carrying Mom’s genre now, I can finally make music for myself. The songs that are truly mine. Not mom’s, not the band’s. *Mine*.”

Phainon blinked, looking surprised. “I see,” he said. “I’m so happy for you. Have you written the songs yet? How is it going to sound?”

“A little bit of everything. But slow rock, mostly. Alternative. More mellow than the band,” Mydei said. He gazed at Phainon’s eyes, at the smile he had missed so, so much. “It’s mostly love songs with slower beats, maybe a few folk-rock experiments here and there.”

“Folk-rock? That sounds so cool. I’ve never heard anything like that before!” Phainon said excitedly. “I’m sure you could pull it off nicely. Mydeimos Gorgo isn’t just some rockstar’s son. He is *the* rockstar!”

Mydei chuckled. “Give me your guitar and I can sing it for you now.”

“Hm?” Phainon blinked. There was this unmistakable excitement flickering in his eyes; the ones he always seemed to have whenever he heard Mydei was doing something even slightly interesting. He shifted to pause the movie, dedicating his attention entirely to Mydei. “That sounds appealing. But can’t you do it a cappella instead? I kinda don’t wanna move. It’s super cozy here.”

“Mm,” Mydei hummed, snuggled closer to Phainon in agreement. “Alright, then.”

And so, he started singing the songs he had been writing for the past few weeks. The genuine feeling he had been keeping to himself, the song about their time in Aedes Elysiae, their lovely weekends full of touches, kisses, and desire, a song that was dedicated to Phainon’s sky blue eyes, and *Worldbearer*, a song where Mydei admitted openly through the lyrics how

Phainon had been carrying Mydei's world singlehandedly, giving him a countryside family to live in, a taste of domesticity, and a love so silly, so gentle, and full of fire that it ignited something warm inside him. Something he didn't know existed outside of the romance movie.

Something he didn't know existed in real life.

He originally wrote those songs as ballads. An album of bittersweet memories he thought he had lost and could never get back. But now that he literally lived inside those lyrics, he mixed them up with the melody he had only discovered now, the melody he had woven into Phainon's name.

And the muse himself—Phainon, was listening quietly, as if his life depended on it.

… And all my life, I've only lived through the motions,
A grave-writ script recited like a premonition.
But the sun in your eyes breaks through my static world,
Your light, warm enough to thaw the cold.

Your hands on mine
My shattered skies are gone.
Your smile—it shines,
Burn bright like a dawn

And there might be someone braver,
kinder, prettier,
but no one carries me better
than you, my worldbearer.

"... and da-da-da, I hadn't written the rest of the lyrics for the last one," Mydei said, ending the last part with a snicker. "Most of it only struck me just now, so that's all I have, but…"

Phainon cupped Mydei's cheeks, looking positively *beaming*. "'Dei, it's beautiful," he whispered. "That song is so, so beautiful."

Mydei grinned, another wave of warmth bloomed in his chest. The one only Phainon could create. "You've made a great muse."

"Oh?" Phainon chuckled. "Is it written for me? Why, Mydeimos. I feel so loved right now."

Mydei smiled. "Well, you better, HKS," he said. "'Cause I really do love you."

Phainon let out the tiniest laugh, brushing his thumb on Mydei's lower lip. "Say it again."

"I love you," Mydei said, louder this time. He inched closer, placing a tiny peck on Phainon's lips and the tip of his nose.

"Hear that, world?" Phainon suddenly spoke loudly. "Mydeimos loves me!"

A muffled *Shut Up!* was heard from Cyrene's room, and Phainon blinked, startled with the unexpected response. Mydei laughed, poking at Phainon's nose and calling him a dork.

"You know what, I love you too," Phainon said. "And I will make sure you know, I will love you forever from here on. No more hiding something."

"Not even if it's for my own good?" Mydei challenged.

"No," Phainon said. "I will tell you everything."

"Me too," Mydei hummed. He would rather NOT have the last four hellish weeks again. Heck, he didn't even want to remember it ever happened.

It felt so claustrophobic, holding the hand of a woman he considered a younger sister and trying to make it look romantic while under the gaze of so many eyes and cameras. The fame that had been following him since childhood now magnified, cornered him everywhere, even in the safety of

his own house. It was exhausting to spare a few hours of his day to read all the pre-submitted questions from the interviewees, consider what to answer, how the public would react, and rehearse his gestures and expressions for each interview so that Phainon wouldn't misinterpret them. It was exhausting to have to come to Aventurine and fight his way to tamper with the plan.

Robin had been looking at him worried every morning, asking him if he was okay every time they met; in their shared dressing room, in their shared rehearsal booth, or in Robin's car on the way to wherever they were scheduled that day.

It was almost funny, how the woman that caused everything in the first place, was the only one who cared the most about Phainon.

"I'm sorry, Mydei, I'm sorry," Robin said, for the umpteenth time that day after Mydei told her about the breakup. She pressed her lips, looking as worried as an angel watching the world burn. "We can stop this, then we tell Phainon, then you can go back together. Phainon loves you. He'll have you back, right?"

Before that night, Mydei would definitely say that yes, Phainon loves him. He would be very confident about it. But now, he didn't know if it was true anymore, after Phainon had lied to him, avoided him, and looked at him with empty eyes, without any single desire that actually sparked in his eyes whenever Mydei got down on his knees for him.

He couldn't be sure that Phainon loves him when it looked like love had long gone from him.

At that time, Mydei thought that maybe Phainon had decided there was no point in dating him anymore. Perhaps he was just like everyone else after all, he loved Mydei because of the name and fame his mom had inherited for him.

Now that Mydei would no longer be the Prince of Rock*, perhaps Phainon had lost interest in him. Maybe he couldn't even hold Mydei, even if only as a body to warm his bed.*

“Forget it, Rob,” Mydei said. If his mom’s legacy were what mattered for Phainon, if the band was what was important, then he would do this one last time. “There’s no point in stopping. He’s already gone, now. I don’t think he would be back just because we stop. If anything, he would even be madder. He would think that I would disappoint you. Let’s just consider it a price to pay for the freedom from our inherited legacy, yeah?”

“This is not the price I’m willing to pay,” Robin frowned.

“Neither do I,” Mydei said. “But that’s the thing about life. It’ll force us to pay, anyway.”

It had been so awfully lonely to wake up alone every day, without Phainon behind him, his chest against Mydei’s back, shielding him from the world that had swallowed Mydei whole and spat him countless times, his fingers entwined with Mydei’s own to keep him grounded, to keep him from losing himself in the crowd every day.

It felt so empty without his butterfly kisses, his smiles, and the excitement of seeing him again whenever the time came.

And the quiet of his phone without Phainon’s message…

Holy Strife, it felt like he hopped onto his bed every night, dying, only to be revived to face another exhausting day, and died again when the night came.

“I met Aventurine a few days ago,” Phainon said, suddenly, pulling Mydei’s mind from the flashback of his nightmarish weeks.

“Hmm,” Mydei hummed. Aventurine had mentioned it to him a few days back, but he refused to elaborate. “How much did he bother you?”

“Um, he did not,” Phainon answered quietly. “On the contrary, he told me about how much you made him suffer because you’re trying to protect my feelings. He’s… giving me some sort of wake-up call? He said a lot, and heh, I think he called me stupid with his stare a little bit. But… that aside, he more or less said that I thought about you, it was just all in my mind.”

Mydei blinked. Oh. So Aventurine was actually the one who put some sense into Phainon? That came out of nowhere. Especially because Aventurine seemed to never care about anyone in general. Mydei stared at Phainon, trying to see if he was joking, but Phainon looked very serious. His brows furrowed a little bit.

“He told me that you went to such a great length to make sure you can play the ruse without making me feel insecure,” Phainon said. “And he told me that you were so difficult, you’re actually gaining his respect, and you did that all because of me. That makes me feel bad for never asking you what you’ve been through this whole time.”

Phainon paused, brushing his hand on Mydei’s cheek, his thumb resting under Mydei’s eyes. He looked worried. It made Mydei curious about what exactly Aventurine was saying to Phainon. He’s always so awfully cryptic when talking to Mydei, to the point that Mydei suspected Aventurine actually treated their banter as a game and enjoyed making Mydei *think*.

Bastard.

“I know this may be late but… how are you feeling?” Phainon asked. “Are you truly okay?”

When? In what context did Phainon ask him? During the ruse? Before that? Now? Mydei couldn’t answer. But Phainon’s eyes softened with compassion, tainted with worry, and full of love that Mydei couldn’t help but think to just… tell him everything. He had taken Phainon’s compassion for granted, had taken his respect for Mydei’s privacy as indifference, and that was his biggest mistake. It wouldn’t happen again.

“I’m alright. With you here, I’m always alright,” he said quietly. “And don’t feel bad, HKS. It’s not your fault you didn’t ask. Even if you had, I probably wouldn’t have told you everything. Mom and Krateros raised me like a true Kremnoan. Their version of protection is swallowing pain and standing tough in front of the people they love. No room left to ask or to care. So I’m sorry I did just that to you. I just… followed the only example I knew.”

“Mm, ‘s okay,” Phainon hummed. “Still—how were you feeling the whole time?”

“It was annoying, but bearable. I’m feeling better now that you’re here and willing to be honest about what you feel,” Mydei answered. “You always make things okay, Phainon.”

“I’m glad I can help.”

“Just don’t do that at your expense again, okay?”

Phainon let out a soft chuckle. “Now you sound like my mom,” he said. “But alright, *Kotik*. I promise.”

Mydei smiled. “How about you?”

“Hm?” Phainon tilted his head. “What about me?”

“I never asked you what it feels like, being my partner,” Mydei said. “I mean, being *Mydeimos Gorgo*’s partner that is being hidden from media, from everyone outside of our immediate friends and family,” he continued, elaborating on his question. “I know it’s what Aglaea thought for the best, to protect our privacy and whatever. But the past few weeks made me think… does it ever make you feel like you’re my dirty little secret?”

Phainon hummed. “Um… a little,” he admitted. “I didn’t think about it at first. What we had was enough; I didn’t care that no one knew. But seeing your public ‘relationship’… I do feel like I’m missing out. Not that I want paparazzi or cameras, no. I just want to exist with you without ducking our heads. Going to a theme park. A bowling alley. Or go to Styxia… kissing you on the beach at golden hour. You’d look so beautiful.”

Phainon’s voice trailed with a smile, like he was imagining those moments.

Mydei scoffed. “I see.”

It sounded fun, indeed, to be able to go on vacation and around the town without having to hide. Mydei had never cared about the image Aglaea insisted he keep, or the industry’s harsh gossip. However, when Aglaea’s

team suggested that fame could harm Phainon, Mydei became worried and decided to keep their relationship entirely discreet.

Back then, it didn't even cross his mind how it would make Phainon feel. He seemed to be fine with the arrangement, too. So they rolled with it.

But maybe he could change it now.

"It's alright, though, 'Dei. I always think of it as a risk of dating a celebrity," Phainon said, as if confirming Mydei's thought. "So uh, don't worry about it 'kay?"

No, Mydei couldn't just let things stay the same after everything. He knew what Phainon felt now, and he should change it.

Perhaps they could ask Aglaea to help them with the negative press or random fan attacks if Mydei were to come out.

Or maybe…

Mydei grunted again, begrudgingly thinking that maybe he could ask Aventurine's help. Aventurine was a little more brash than Aglaea, and he also had so many tricks up his sleeve. Perhaps he could help with their case. Counter the negative news and rumors about Phainon if it ever came to that. Aventurine could do it. After all, this was the guy who was crazy enough to pull Robin out of her Clockie Princess Tower.

"We'll find a way, I promise," Mydei said.

"Hmm," Phainon hummed. He looked curious, but he apparently decided that it would have to wait. "And it's okay with you? I'm not a celebrity. Is it going to affect your reputation or something?"

Mydei scoffed. "I'd say fuck it, HKS. Status, rumors, whatever. I love you, and you gave me every single piece of life that I couldn't imagine I have. A countryside family that makes you homemade food with homegrown ingredients, a sister, parents who genuinely care about you, and… a home,"

he paused. “I couldn’t care less what people think of me. It was always you I care about the most.”

That made Phainon beam, somehow. Brighter than the sun, than anything Mydei had ever seen.

“Awww,” Phainon cooed, closing in their distance to attack Mydei with quick kisses all over his face. “You do love me, Mydeimos.”

“Shut up,” Mydei stammered, feeling his face flushed all of a sudden. “Now, no one could ever tell me that I never let you know about my feelings anymore, you stupid dork. Not Aventurine, not Cyrene, no one.”

“No, but keep telling me that anyway,” Phainon chuckled. His smile was so childlike and innocent, and Mydei wanted nothing more than to kiss it. To devour it and make himself sure he remembered every shape and texture of Phainon’s lips. But he knew that if he started it, none of them would stop. Cyrene’s room was just next to Phainon’s, and it sounds embarrassing to even think about her faintly listening to *that* kind of noise.

“Hmph, we really do need our own home here in Aedes Elysiae,” Mydei scoffed.

Phainon tilted his head. “Hm? Where did that thought even come from?’

“Never mind,” Mydei said. But he mentally noted to ask Hieronymus about buying land in Aedes Elysiae and possibly hiring an architect to build a lovely little house. Aventurine mentioned having a distant cousin who was a gifted architect.

“Anyway, speaking about home,” Phainon started. “Can I ask you something annoying?”

“Sure,” Mydei said. “Go ahead.”

Phainon pressed his lips. “Back then, when you walked away from me,” he started, looking positively nervous, like that thought alone pained him.

Mydei could honestly understand that. “You didn’t come home. I was so worried. Where did you go?”

Mydei winced.

“Honestly? I went to Stelle’s,” he said. “Cyrene was staying at her place, so I went there to talk to her that night.”

Phainon’s awkward smile suddenly dropped. He furrowed his brows, looking absolutely flabbergasted, and he blinked again. “Wait,” he said. “You went to Cyrene?”

“Uh huh.”

“*My* sister.”

“Yes.”

“Mydei,” Phainon straightened in his seat, looking very serious. “You thought I broke up with you, and you’re going to *my sister*?”

Mydei shrugged. “She’s my friend too,” he said. “And she’s on my side.”

“*What*?”

Phainon looked comically surprised and baffled. Mydei grinned, feeling this silliness to be awfully familiar and heartwarming, and he would trade anything, anything to keep this for the rest of his life. “I mean, she’s the only one who could understand,” he said. “And she’s the only one with enough guts to call you stupid, that your altruism would kill you before Thanatos even got a chance to. And…”

“Oh, Kephale,” Phainon groaned. “You’re talking about *me* with my sister?”

Mydei shrugged. “What’s the big deal?”

“The big deal is…” Phainon wiped his hand on his face, looking beet red now. “... How does my sister know more about my partner’s feelings than I

do?”

“Because she asked, and you didn’t,” Mydei said, trying his might to hide a laugh.

“Ugh, I guess I deserve that,” Phainon groaned again. His face was beet red now. “This is so embarrassing.”

Mydei couldn’t suppress his snicker.

He threw his head back, laughing along with Cyrene’s muffled laugh in the other room. Phainon rapped the wall to Cyrene’s room and shouted, “Fuck you, Cy!”

Cyrene laughed louder, and then there was Audata’s shout from the first floor, saying, “*no cursing in my house, Phainon!”*. The whole exchange was so hilarious that Mydei couldn’t help but continue his laugh, unable to resist the bubble of joy that burst from his chest despite Phainon’s pestering.

“Shut up,” Phainon said, biting Mydei’s cheek playfully. Mydei could feel a smile in that attack, and how much Phainon didn’t mean it. “Shut up. Fuck you, Mydeimos.”

“Maybe later,” Mydei teased. “Right now, I just want to stay like this. It’s so ridiculously comfortable.”

“Mmmm.” Phainon nuzzled his cheek into Mydei’s hair. “That I agree. But I don’t feel like watching a movie anymore. Do you mind singing for me again, Mydeimos? Maybe we could complete the lyrics that you’re still missing? Your handsome muse is here and willing, after all.”

“Ugh,” Mydei grumbled, but even he couldn’t hide the smile on his face. “Okay.”

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Phainon fell asleep halfway through Mydei's melodic hum, lulled by his voice while Mydei watched his peaceful sleeping face in awe. He couldn't fall into a good nap like Phainon, with the jitters from his morning coffee still so strongly trickling in his system. So Mydei stayed there, just feeling Phainon's warmth and presence while he was scrolling through his phone.

Briefing and rehearsal tomorrow. Radio interview with Janusopolis Radio at night. Aventurine's staff had attached a list of questions the interviewer might ask, as per Mydei's request. Mydei didn't download the file as he usually would. He forwarded it to Phainon instead, asking him to rehearse the answer later.

Halfway through Mydei's text conversation with Aventurine about his hiatus PR matters, Mydei heard the sounds coming from the kitchen. It was probably Audata preparing dinner.

Mydei decided to get up from bed, moving carefully so that Phainon wouldn't be woken up from his nap. He went downstairs and helped Audata prepare for dinner, chopping vegetables and braising chicken while she prepared the sauce, chirping happily. Mydei couldn't help but smile along with her.

"You're beaming today, Mrs. Khaslana."

"Why wouldn't I? All of my family members at my dining table," she sang-song. "What a lovely night, indeed."

Mydei thought she only meant Phainon and Cyrene at first, until Stelle arrived, and they all sat around a dining table for six. This particular furniture was new, Mydei thought. The last time he visited, they'd had to drag over a spare chair so everyone could sit at the same table.

All of her family, Mydei thought, glancing at Audata, who was laughing at Stelle punching Phainon's shoulders repeatedly. *Including Stelle and me.*

For a brief moment, he thought about whether he deserved to be here, to have a loving family alongside Phainon, the man he loved so much. But a

second later, Mydei shook his head, pushing away the worries and just enjoying the feeling of being in a place where he was welcomed as a family.

At the same time, he also tried to keep his head level, and tamped down the sudden thought of asking Krateros for his mother's ring—the one she'd told him to give to the person he loved when the time came.

It's probably too soon for that now. Mydei should have just enjoyed this moment.

When he and Phainon went to say goodbye the next day, Audata packed them so many homemade meals to go for the road, three packs of plastic containers filled with different kinds of food.

Phainon gasped upon seeing the containers. The corner of his mouth curved into a beaming smile.

"Can we pleeease have olive juice too, Mom?" Phainon asked. "Please? You make 'em too, right?"

"What kind of mother do you think I am?" Audata scoffed. "Go grab the bottles from the counter while Mydei helps me pack these."

Phainon yelled 'okay' and ran to the kitchen. With her son out of earshot, Audata turned to Mydei. "Thank you again for taking care of my boy, dear," she said when Phainon was out of their earshot.

Mydei blinked, smiling awkwardly. "But Mrs. Khaslana, it's actually Phainon who took care of me."

Audata's smile softened. "Maybe, but you came all this way to fix things, and you helped me provide homemade meals for him, and…" she cupped Mydei's cheeks in her lined hands. "Thank you for loving him the way we couldn't. The way he doesn't know how to," she whispered. Her voice thinned, and her eyes shone. "Thank you for fighting for him, Mydeimos. Because he damn well won't care about himself. That selfless kid…"

Audata's lower lip twisted, her words cut with tears.

Without another word, she pulled him into a hug, blotting her tears against his jacket. Mydei hugged her back, and before any of them could let go, Phainon suddenly joined in the hug, circling his arms around Mydei and Audata at the same time.

“Phainon, let us have this moment, please,” Audata said, her voice muffled from the hug.

“Nope. Don’t ever think that you two could hug without inviting me,” he said, pressing his cheeks to his mom’s head.

“You dork,” Mydei whispered, and Phainon only tightened his hold.

“Keep talking,” he said. “I won’t ever let go of my two favorite people.”

“Don’t keep to yourself again,” Audata said with a broken whisper. “If trouble finds you again, don’t keep to yourself. Talk to me, my dearests. Talk to me. Let momma help you.”

She hugged Mydei tighter, and Phainon hugged them tighter, and Mydei closed his eyes, embracing the feeling of being hold, of being cared for.

Yeah, he’d get used to this, too.

The sound of a car horn outside broke the moment. Krateros’s driver had arrived, and just like that, they had to bid Aedes Elysiae goodbye to come back to the real life that they paused for the night.

Phainon hummed Mydei’s song from yesterday as the car headed to Janusopolis, staring out of the window with a smile that Mydei was sure he didn’t realize he let out. He grabbed Phainon’s hand, entwining their fingers together, which Phainon quickly welcomed. He shifted his attention to Mydei, smiling wider as the wheat field, washed by the morning sun, served as the background. He looked so peaceful.

“Hey,” he said. “You sure it’s okay that I come along?”

“Why wouldn’t it be okay?” Mydei asked.

“I don’t know… how about the ruse?” Phainon asked. “How about Aventurine? Robin?”

Mydei paused to think and decided that… “Aventurine will have to think about how to work with us for the rest of the campaign. He always took pride in being brilliant. It’s a fine opportunity for him to prove it, don’t you think?”

Phainon snickered. He rested his head on Mydei’s shoulder, and they stayed like that until they arrived at the rehearsal venue in Janusopolis. His shoulder felt stiff from the weight of Phainon’s head, but it was a discomfort he welcomed.

Along the way to the backstage, Mydei held Phainon’s hand again, to the latter’s surprise. Phainon raised his brows, almost looking hesitant.

“Don’t worry about it,” Mydei assured him, before Phainon could even ask.

Phainon nodded, biting his lips to hide a smile, and answered with a tightened grip on Mydei’s hand. When Mydei entered the dressing room to put his belongings away, he could see Robin sitting on the couch, tinkering with her manicured nails.

“Hello, Mydei,” she said as she tilted her head to see him. “I thought y… oh!” she gasped; brows raised so high they disappear behind her bangs. She blinked once, twice, hesitating while she sat straighter, staring at Phainon like she saw a ghost.

“Phainon, hello,” she said. “How… How are you? Are you… Are you two…”

“Yes,” Mydei said. “We’re good!”

“Finally!!!!!”

Robin jumped to her feet, hugging Mydei and Phainon both as she shrieked joyfully. Mydei could see Phainon looked startled, but then his face

softened, his hand reaching Robin’s back to pat her as she blurted out, “I’m happy you two are alright! Thank you for stopping by, Phainon. I was worried about you two!” and Kephale knows what else. Mydei couldn’t comprehend it between her muffled sobs and Phainon’s soft chuckle.

Thankfully, no one from the stage crew asked about Phainon, or even glanced twice at him as they went to the rehearsal stage with their hands entwined with each other. And while Mydei and Robin rehearsed on stage, Phainon happily sat on one of the amplifiers on the side, watching them in silence. He still looked like he tried to make himself invisible, until Peucesta and Krateros came to greet him, and they discussed something that Mydei hoped he could also hear, because Phainon laughed at whatever Peucesta said.

“Hey, Mister Prince, you’re off tune,” Hephaestion shouted from behind his drum kit, sobering Mydei from his musings. “What, a knight in shining armor arrived at the scene and you’re suddenly nervous?”

Robin chuckled, covering her mouth with her hands while Mydei raised his middle finger. Phainon turned his head from where he was, smiling and waving at Mydei, his eyes full of question, probably curious about why Mydei was being hostile towards Hepy.

Mydei couldn’t help but feel his heart warming a little.

It should have been like this from the start.

If only he weren’t that much of a coward.

When rehearsal was over, Robin practically begged them to visit her suite, insisting on showing Phainon and Mydei the nail set she had been working on. Her suite was, to no one’s surprise, next to Mydei with a connecting door. Mydei was worried that Phainon would find such an arrangement disturbing. But Phainon only shrugged, saying that it must be just another Aventurine’s arrangement.

“It is,” Robin said. “It’s just one of his brilliant ideas to keep the ruse. I promise you nothing ever happened, ever,” she added while looking right at

Phainon.

“I know,” Phainon answered calmly, glancing at Mydei again while he grinned. “I believe you.”

While Mydei went to order room service, Robin pulled Phainon to the couch, showing him a set of fake nails she had created in Mydei’s colors: red, gold, white, and black. Phainon looked completely mesmerized, gazing at the set as if it were gold.

“Wow, look at the details,” Mydei could hear Phainon say over the receptionist he was talking to on the phone. “You even got this in Mydei’s cheek tattoo. You made these yourself?”

“I am,” Robin said. “Sometimes when I couldn’t sleep at night, I made these until my eyes were tired enough. I was planning to give these to Mydei for this weekend’s show, but… You can wear them instead.”

“What, me?” Phainon chuckled. “Robin, it’s such an honor, but… I think it’ll be wasted on me. I mean, I’d love to wear it…”

“No, no, please,” Robin insisted, already holding his hand. “Come on, I’m sure it’ll look gorgeous on you! Mydei wouldn’t mind too, right, Mydei?”

Mydei still paid attention to the room service repeating his order, so he only raised his thumb. Robin smiled excitedly, and before Phainon could protest further, Robin had already prepared the nail glue and the wipes to clean Phainon’s hand. His boyfriend glanced at Mydei as if asking permission, and Mydei only snickered.

“But what about Mydei’s show?” Phainon asked when Robin finally pressed one nail on Phainon’s thumb.

“I have another set in your color, don’t worry,” she said, not breaking her attention from Phainon’s nails. Mydei could still catch a flicker of doubt in Phainon’s eyes, as if he still wasn’t sure that he belonged here. But Mydei smiled

This moment couldn’t be any more right. It was just so in place, so perfect, it almost hurt. Another reminder that this was the world he should have built from the start for them.

But, well, not too late to make this permanent.

“Oh, I remember that one,” Mydei said as he put the hotel’s phone back and joined them on the couch. “You mean the blue-gold-white you showed me a few weeks ago, right?”

“Mmhmm,” Robin hummed. “It’s only half-finished. I didn’t see Phainon often enough to decide on the right blue color that matches him. But now you’re here, I think I could finish it later after the radio interview.”

Phainon blinked. “Wait,” he said. “You made a nail color set based on… me?”

“Yep,” Robin said. “I was gonna give it to you so you could match. But I think you should swap and wear each other’s color now, right?”

Phainon blinked, looking so shocked like someone pulled a chair from under him. “Oh, I… um…”

“Yeah,” Mydei said. “Definitely, yeah.”

“Oooh, that’s so wonderful!” Robin giggled as she swayed left and right, looking almost like she was vibrating. “Okay, okay, please do not distract me now! I need to make sure this is set nicely on Phainon’s fingers!”

Phainon smiled, staring at Robin and Mydei like he was dreaming. It was a ridiculous emotion on him, but at least Mydei could empathize with where it was coming from. A week ago, all of this felt so out of reach.

But in the midst of their calm evening, the bell suddenly rang, multiple times, in an abysmally annoying way that there’s only one person in Mydei’s mind who could do that. Mydei got up from his seat, with each step praying that he was wrong, only to open the door to Aventurine’s cocky smirk.

Guh. Figured.

“Hello, my dear Prince,” he greeted him with that lazy elegance that made Mydei appreciate his own patience. “Aren’t you gonna let me in?”

“No,” Mydei said.

“Aw, come on, lovely Prince. No need to be so hostile to the little old me,” Aventurine chirped, like Mydei’s rejection did not bother him even a little bit. Making Mydei wondered what Aventurine had experienced in his life that led him to be this kind of person. “Anyway, Veritas is here too. If you won’t let me in, would you deny him?”

No, he wouldn’t; and though Mydei suspected the annoyance he felt every time he saw Aventurine’s face would last a little longer, he didn’t actually hate Aventurine, nor did he ever plan to shut the door in his face. After that little game they played during the ruse, he had kind of come to respect this man. Plus, considering his decisions on his solo projects and his relationship with Phainon, Mydei thought that he wouldn’t have any choice but to get along with Aventurine from here on, after all.

But that didn’t mean he couldn’t give Aventurine a hard time, push him around a little, just as he had done to Mydei with all of his PR campaign plan.

“I could deny both of you and wouldn’t lose sleep, I bet,” he said.

Then the elevator dinged, and Ratio walked into the corridor with a huge box in his hands.

“Hello, Mydeimos,” Ratio greeted, looking just as exhausted as Mydei felt. Sometimes Mydei wondered how someone as calm and as sensible as he could end up with Aventurine. Love was such a mystery. “We brought a gift for you and Phainon.”

“Especially for Phainon. He would really love this!” Aventurine added. “Still gonna deny us?”

Mydei rolled his eyes, opening the door and just nudging inside with his chin. “Get in.”

“Aww, I know you wouldn’t resist,” Aventurine said, patting Mydei’s shoulder and walking in with a loud announcement made by the loud taps of his polished shoes against the marble and the jangle of his bracelets cutting through the chatter. Phainon turned his head and smiled when he saw Aventurine and Ratio, while Robin did not waver from her task, making Phainon’s nails look pretty.

“Hi, Aventurine, hi… Dr. Ratio,” Phainon greeted. “Uh… nice to meet you.”

“Hello, Mister Aventurine,” Robin greeted him, too, but without looking up from Phainon’s fingers.

“Oh, shush, stop being so formal with me, sweethearts,” Aventurine said, taking a seat next to Phainon and making himself feel entirely at home. He circled his hand around Phainon’s shoulder, which made Phainon visibly stiff. He looked uncomfortable, and Mydei almost stepped in to save him, but Aventurine held his hand. “I saw from Hep’s private account that you’re hanging around the Cherry Bomb couple today, so I thought, why not drop by and see you again?”

“Um…” Phainon shifted his eyes toward Aventurine, looking nervous. “Am I not allowed? Am I causing a problem?”

Mydei narrowed his eyes, crossing his arms in front of his chest, ready to counter. But Aventurine only laughed, rubbing his hand on Phainon’s shoulder.

“Oh no, no, don’t worry about it, I’m not here to scold you,” he said. “I just want to see you, honest! It’s been a while since the last time I saw you.”

“Um… It’s only been like… what, a week?”

“A week too long! You see, my daughter is still giving me attitude for ‘*losing*’ the extra souvenir Captain Khaslana promised her. She’s not talking

to me for three full days!" Aventurine sighed dramatically. "I tried to buy her another Okhema Air plushie, but she wanted the one that *The Captain* is giving her. Good thing we're going to be buddies from here on, right? I expect you to hand-deliver that plushie or whatever souvenir you forgot to give Juliet in one of Mydei's taping shoots for the MegaChef."

Phainon laughed awkwardly, then shifted his eyes to Mydei with a question. "Um…"

Mydei sighed.

Leave it to Aventurine to drop the bomb without warning.

"What, you haven't told him?" Aventurine chuckled.

Oh, this bastard.

"Because it's not even final, yet" Mydei scoffed. "But fine, so remember when I said I'm planning to have solo projects?" he turned to Phainon, who only nodded. "Yeah, I don't plan to go on tour as intensely as Sons of Gorgo in this project, so I uh… I may have mentioned that I will be *considering* Aventurine's offer as a Celebrity Judge for MegaChef," Mydei said, glaring at Aventurine when he emphasized the word *considering*.

At that, Phainon's brows shot up so high they almost disappeared behind his bangs.

"Oh," he said. "So… so you'll be home more often?"

Mydei almost laughed. Of course, that's what Phainon paid attention to. He was just so adorable. He looked almost like Big Snowy now, and Mydei could even imagine him wagging his tail, if he ever had any.

"Maybe? Yeah, kinda," Mydei shifted on his feet, suddenly feeling nervous with the whole implication of him being the house hus… *house partner*. "It's still *under discussion*, though, right, Aventurine?"

"Aw, come on, you're thrilled, and you know it," Aventurine clapped, bracelets jangling. "Between that and *The Noise*, you'll skyrocket IPC's

ratings. Millions rolling in, guaranteed. Veritas already ran the numbers—trust me, they're pretty." He leaned forward, patting the box with a sly grin. "Which is why I bringing a gift. Especially for Captain Khaslana."

"Oh," Robin shifted her eyes from Phainon's left hand, now decorated with pretty pressed-on nails. "Is this the gift that you've discussed with my brother, Mister Aventurine?"

"The very one," Aventurine smirked smugly. "Have you done with the nails, baby bird? I want Captain Khaslana to be the one to unwrap this gift. After all, it was because of him we're all here counting our successes and well, *gains*, if you know what I mean."

"Juuust a little bit more," Robin said. She pressed a nail on top of Phainon's ring finger, decorated with a gold and red motif, and raised her hand. "Yup, all done!"

"So, captain," Aventurine urged, the corners of his mouth tugging higher. "If you would."

Phainon hesitated, glancing between Mydei and the box like it might explode.

Robin clasped her hands together, bouncing with excitement. "Open it, Captain!"

So, he did. Carefully, he peeled back the glossy wrapping and lifted the lid. Inside, nestled in layers of velvet, sat a gleaming scale model of a mini jet. Complete with the tail number and the manufacturer's crest. Under that, there's a flight logbook, its leather cover embossed with the golden crest of a falcon.

Mydei raised his brows. He glanced at Aventurine, who was grinning in a way that looked like he had just won a game against Mydei.

Which he did. As much as Mydei hated to admit it, Aventurine kind of beat Mydei into buying Phainon his own jet.

Mydei sneered. Oh, he was so going to get back at Aventurine for this.

“Um, this is nice,” Phainon said. “I don’t know much about Bombardier planes, but it’s cute. And the logbook…” he paused, and Mydei could almost see his gears grinding, and how all the physical evidence clicked in Phainon’s mind before he shot his eyes up to Aventurine. “This belongs to a real jet.”

“Yup.”

“With my name.”

“A super rock and roll gift!” Robin chuckled.

“Yes, not officiated yet since I still need your ID, and whatever for your paperwork but—”

“*Aventurine*,” Phainon said sternly, like he was forcing Aventurine to be serious. “This is an actual Bombardier plane. This costs double-digit millions of credits.”

“Very true, I see you’re very knowledgeable in the jet department,” Aventurine cackled. “Don’t worry about the numbers, Captain. Have you seen the earnings reports for the Mydei-Robin fake-dating campaign? I only make a little percentage of that profit, and yet, this plane only costs me a little of what I make,” he flashed a grin. “Consider it a *compensation* for your trouble. Or maybe a friendship offering from me. You know, I like to keep my friends happy,” he added with a wink.

Mydei could see Ratio roll his eyes. “If you’ve actually seen that number, getting you a 6000 model is kind of a stingy gift. Especially considering what I heard happened in your relationship,” Ratio crossed his arms. “I say you could demand a 7500 model instead with…”

“Ah ah ah, honey, please, don’t spoil our pillow talk to our friends,” Aventurine interrupted him, letting his usual smirk spark with a little bit of fake shyness. Mydei knew that it wasn’t the case. It was just their dynamic; Ratio countering him, and Aventurine deflected him just to be annoying. He

almost jabbed at Aventurine, if only he weren't so distracted by Phainon's face, looking at the plane model as if it horrified him.

Mydei shook his head, feeling a little bit regretful for not thinking about buying an actual private jet for Phainon sooner. Though it was not without reason. He always believed that Phainon was a little bit too difficult to give expensive gifts. Phainon still insisted on paying for the groceries, and when they moved into that apartment, Phainon's concern about the rate of the space was so palpable that Mydei asked Krateros to handle the house buying, so he wouldn't know the actual price and taxes to Phainon, and thus, never had to mention it.

But maybe he didn't try to make him understand enough.

Mydei sighed, begrudgingly accepting his defeat to Aventurine this time.

Phainon's lips parted, no sound coming out at first. He looked like a boy again, wide-eyed, holding the little model as if it were a burning coal.

"But…" he paused, gaping like a fish. "Mydei?"

Mydei shrugged. "Ratio was right, you were supposed to get a better model," he said. "You've put up with his craziness. And considering the profit Aventurine said we make…"

"Next time, talk to me about your discomfort, and I do not have to think about compensation at all," Aventurine remarked.

"But you should have thought about it, if you ever care about anyone's feelings," Ratio scolded.

"Fine, whatever, I have to do *everything* around here, huh? By Qlipoth, do you guys want me to mop the floor too?" Aventurine rolled his eyes dramatically, but not without a grin on his lips.

Robin chuckled, as if knowing that it was just Aventurine's usual antics. Maybe it was. As much as Mydei didn't like him, he had to admit that even though he's a scheming bastard, Aventurine was actually playing his cards

fairly. A private jet as a gift was not something to take lightly. It costs a fortune, even considering Aventurine's net worth. Mydei could respect him for the good intention alone.

"But guys?" Phainon asked again. "Do you… have any idea how much it costs to maintain one of these? The hangar fees, the insurance, the— Kephale almighty, the *fuel* alone would bleed us dry in a month! Mydei. I…"

At that, Aventurine's smile faltered. "Wait…" he said. "Mydei, did you not tell him how much you make a month?"

Oh shit.

"He never asked," Mydei said defensively. "He knew the pin to my bank account. Phainon, you should have known."

"I'm not peeking at your bank account. I'm not that kind of guy," Phainon scrunched his nose, as the idea itself disgusted him. "I could still pay for the groceries just fine, including that Kobe Beef you like to buy every now and then."

Aventurine raised his brows, looking absolutely entertained, now. "Wh… you pay for the groceries?" he chuckled. "Mydei, really?"

"What about it?" Phainon said, looking defensive all of a sudden. "He bought the house. I gotta help maintain it, right?"

"Oh dear Qlipoth," Aventurine cackled now, shoulders shaking with laughter. "No wonder Mydei went all the way for you. All of those hassles Mydei caused me to make a lot of sense, now. No wonder he's so attached to you," he shook his head. "You know, Phainon, if my boyfriend is one of the biggest rock stars in the world, I would just let him bankroll everything and just enjoy my life completely spoiled rotten. He's not just a rockstar. He is *The* Rockstar, you know that, right?"

"Mister Aventurine!" Robin shook her head. "Don't punish Phainon for being a complete gentleman!"

“Took words right out of my mouth,” Ratio added. “Also, speak for yourself. You don’t even let me bankroll everything and insist on working your ass off.”

“It’s cause the IPC would go bankrupt without me, and I like to spoil you, honey,” Aventurine winked at Ratio. “But alright, fine, Mister Gentleman. If it makes you feel better, I’ll help with the hangar fee for the first year and…”

“Nonsense,” Mydei cut off, feeling a bit disturbed that him allowing Phainon to provide for him, becoming the subject of Aventurine’s jab. “Don’t worry about the maintenance and stuff. Just focus on flying it, okay? Fly *me* when you have the time.”

Robin cooed and clapped like it was the best song she’d ever heard. Aventurine raised a toast with an invisible glass. Ratio sighed, long-suffering, like he’d already foreseen this exact chaos.

Phainon opened his mouth, closed it again, and opened it again. He looked like he still had a lot to say, but upon seeing the plane model, Mydei, and Robin, his gaze softened, and Mydei could almost sense it.

“I guess, alright, thanks,” he said, shifting his eyes to Mydei again. “It could take me months to get the type-rating, but… I don’t mind flying my rockstar boyfriend and going with him on tour every once in a while.”

“Perfect,” Aventurine smiled. “Now, would you listen to my top-of-mind idea on how the Mydei-Robin breakup campaign would roll? Spoiler alert: The angst is expected to gain us another million. Do you know how long sad songs usually last? And how much do they usually sell?”

Mydei rolled his eyes and hmph-ed loudly so Aventurine could hear him. They still had months to go on the Cherry Bomb fake relationship idea, but here Aventurine was, already set with a timeline for moving on to the next one.

But he didn’t mind. Because this time, he would make sure none of them messed up.

This time, it wouldn’t cost him his real relationship again.

-

A few more weeks have blurred past since then. The ruse was still in motion; the tour was as hectic as it could be, and yet their relationship had only gotten stronger.

Phainon would tell Mydei when he saw something on social media he didn’t like. Mydei would assure him with his confession of love. Sometimes he made it so cringe that Phainon would laugh and later apologize. Phainon helped rehearse Mydei’s answers for the interview whenever he got a chance. When he wasn’t, Mydei would text him all about it. When he couldn’t text Phainon, Mydei would ask Krateros to do that in his stead, or Hephaestion, or Robin, if she had the time.

Though Phainon immediately asked him to skip Hephaestion. That man, apparently, did not shy away from using that opportunity to send an embarrassing text that none of them would ever want to read twice.

But Mydei still couldn’t forget Phainon’s face when Robin finally exchanged her number with him. He looked at his phone for one full minute, and then, slowly looking at Mydei and said, “I think the ten-year-old Phainon is screaming in joy somewhere inside my brain.”

And Mydei had only laughed.

It amazed him—how, even with Mydei tangled in tour rehearsals and solo project preparations, and Phainon buried under his flight schedules and their new jet’s Type Rating test—they still carved out time for each other through phone calls, video chats, voice notes, and random pictures. Maybe they should’ve been honest from the outset, with themselves and with those closest to them.

Now, with a week off before the second leg of the world tour and Aglaea having allowed the band a week's rest, Mydei decided to come home. By fortune, Phainon told him that he would be home by the weekend as well. He had just completed his ultra-long-haul journey and was on mandatory rest.

For the first time in weeks, they finally had real time together.

And boy, did Phainon waste no time.

The moment Mydei stepped into the room, Phainon quickly grabbed him, pushed him back into their bed, and kissed him like a starving man. There was no preamble—just raw urgency, the kind that made Mydei’s chest squeeze with longing and desire.

Mydei couldn’t possibly stay still in the face of that kind of passion. He kissed back, just as hungry, just as greedy, their lips clashing like a dare with each other. They wrestled for dominance—hands tugging, pulling, stripping clothes away piece by piece—until the bed became too small for the war they waged.

Too late, Mydei realized they had rolled to the edge.

Phainon toppled to the carpet with a muted *thud,* dragging Mydei with him.

Mydei broke the kiss to ask if Phainon was alright, if he was hurt. Phainon only chuckled, soft and breathy, already chasing his lips again. He rolled them back onto the floor with reckless abandon, his darkened eyes glinting with challenge and a tease.

Oh.

Oh, it’s on.

He kissed Phainon twice as eagerly, their giggles and longing tangling with groans as they rolled across the carpet. He didn’t even know where they were in the room anymore, until Phainon’s hand suddenly cupped the back of his head, protecting him from the sharp corner of the bedside table.

“Careful,” Phainon teased between ragged breaths, laughter tumbling with the words. “Watch where you move, *Kotik.*”

“Mmm, can’t,” Mydei murmured, already peppering kisses across Phainon’s skin that he could reach. “I’ve got a battle to win.”

Phainon caught his lips in a quick peck, then another, then another, speaking between them as though each syllable was a kiss itself: “Mm, love, me, my, kitten, with, concussion.”

Mydei laughed. “Silly dog.”

“Woof woof,” Phainon answered, brushing a thumb on Mydei’s kiss-swollen lips. Mydei leaned to kiss him again, but Phainon kept him in place. “Wait.”

Mydei arched a brow. “What, truce already?”

“As if,” Phainon smirked. “I’ve got something in my pants to show you, before you actually take them off.”

Mydei snorted, leaning closer as he teasingly pressed his hips against Phainon’s. “I’ve seen everything in your pants. And I love it better when it’s unwrapped properly.”

Phainon’s breathy laughter was mixed with a hint of nervousness. “Kinky,” he said. “But I’m serious, ‘Dei. Just a moment.”

Mydei blinked, tilting his head. “Alright,” he said. “Shoot, then.”

Phainon shifted, rolling onto his side. His hand dipped into the pocket of his lounge pants, fishing for something. Mydei’s brow raised, half expecting another joke or, Kephale forbids, something even kinkier. There was no telling with Phainon.

But to his surprise, Phainon pulled out a slim velvet box and opened it to reveal a matching pair of rings with a special shape and carving, one in Mydei’s red and one in Phainon’s eye color. They sparkled under the light of their room.

Mydei could feel his heart skip a beat.

“You know, it’s… It’s not exactly a proposal. Kinda… but, we don’t have to make it that way if you’re not comfortable with it?” Phainon’s voice was hushed now, uncertain in a way that twisted Mydei’s chest. It was kind of weird for him to look so boyish when his eyes were still dark from the desire they shared a second ago.

“It’s just… um… something like a promise ring? I don’t know, I don’t want to push you into something serious too soon, but I wanted something that marked us. Something real,” He shrugged, laughing weakly, like he was trying to make light of his own stumbling and trembling. “I mean, I only kind of want something in your color that I could wear, and when I ask Cartonus, I thought, why not make one for you, too? I… uh… you know,” he laughed, helpless, as if afraid to look up.

Mydei did not respond.

Instead, he got to his feet, leaving Phainon on the floor while he walked to the other side of the wardrobe. He grabbed something in the furthest corner of the drawer, the one he had been thinking about since that day in Aedes Elysiae.

“Mydei?” Phainon asked, confused and unsure.

Mydei sat before Phainon again, who was looking at him nervously, and his velvet box was still out in the open. Mydei showed the ring that he grabbed, the one that his mother gave him when he was very young, when that ring was too large even for his thumb.

“Marry me, Phainon Khaslana of Aedes Elysiae,” he whispered, the words leaped out of Mydei before he even knew he was saying them. His pulse raced; his own voice had cut him off. Phainon’s eyes went wide, the box still trembling between his fingers.

“…M… Mydei?”

“Marry me.” Mydei’s throat tightened, but he said it again, firmer, like an order and a plea tangled together. “I don’t care if it’s stupid, I don’t care if it’s too soon, I don’t care if half the world thinks we’re insane. You bring me a matching ring and tell me it’s not a proposal?” He laughed, his heart raced like a formula car and he could even sense his own giddiness, it’s almost embarrassing. “You’re a fucking coward, Phainon Khaslana.”

Phainon’s lips parted, and for a moment all Mydei could see was disbelief flashing into something brighter—something softer. His laughter came out choked, wet at the edges, and he shook his head like he couldn’t believe it.

“Shut up,” he said. “It *was* a proposal. I was just worried that I’m pushing it, and you think it’s too soon, and we could always talk it over…”

“Yeah, you shut up,” Mydei said, grabbing Phainon’s hand and slipping the ring on his finger. “And do your thing, *Fos mou*. Make me a Khaslana, too.”

“You’re taking my na—yeah, yep, okay, *Kotik*,” Phainon let out a nervous exhale. He pulled the ring from the box, placing the one with the blue gem to Mydei’s ring finger. “Okay, Mydeimos Khaslana.”

Mydei grabbed the other ring from the box and slipped it onto Phainon’s finger, gazing at how beautiful it looked above his mother’s old band—the ring Gorgo had once given Eurypon, and later reclaimed when that love fell apart. He kissed the ring, promising himself that he—no, *they*—would carry this one into a better love story: the happy ending his mother had always dreamed of.

He would fight for Phainon again and again, in this lifetime and the next. He would love Phainon the way he deserved to be loved.

And as Phainon kissed his ring too, then Mydei’s knuckles one by one, Mydei knew he felt the same.

After all, Phainon had always helped him carry his mother’s love and legacy—gladly, as if it were his own.

Chapter End Notes

Happy ending, as promised! Hehe!

I'm also on twitter! let's talk cause I do need more Phaidei friends at @mydaymousee

End Notes

thank you so much for reading! :D

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